



From Refuge *to Removal*

*Deportation Patterns Among
Southeast Asian Communities
in the United States*

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May 2026*

Report prepared for AAPI Force

The author conducted this study as part of the program of professional education at the Goldman School of Public Policy, University of California at Berkeley. This paper is submitted in partial fulfillment of the course requirements for the Master of Public Policy degree. The judgements and conclusions are solely those of the author and are not necessarily endorsed by the Goldman School of Public Policy, by the University of California or by any other agency.

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Acknowledgements

This capstone would not have been possible without the support, wisdom, and generosity of many people.

To my capstone advisor, Dan Lindhiem, thank you for being a guiding force and a voice of reason as I navigated such a complex issue. Your steady mentorship helped me find clarity when the path forward felt uncertain, and your insights pushed me to think more deeply at every turn.

To my clients, Timmy Li and Nkauj Iab Yang, thank you for your partnership throughout this process. Your passion for this work and the guidance you offered inspired me to keep going, especially in the moments when the weight of the issue felt heavy. It has been an honor to work alongside you.

To everyone who agreed to be interviewed for this project: thank you for trusting me with your stories. Despite the sensitivity of this topic, you took the time to sit with me and share. This work exists because of your willingness to speak, and I am deeply grateful.

Finally, I want to acknowledge this community as a whole. The resilience and strength of this community, and all that it has been through, have shaped not only this capstone but me. I hope this work, in some small way, honors that.

Executive Summary

The inauguration of the second Trump administration in January 2025 created an immigration-enforcement environment of unprecedented scale and intensity. The administration has framed this enforcement as a targeted campaign against "the worst of the worst," but the empirical record raises serious questions about who is actually being removed. This paper examines that question for one specific population: the Southeast Asian (SEA) refugee community, nationals and descendants of Cambodia, Laos, and Vietnam, whose presence in the United States is itself a direct consequence of decades of American military and political engagement in Southeast Asia.

The analysis draws on four administrative datasets compiled by the Deportation Data Project, ICE arrests (October 2022 to February 2026), ICE detentions (January 2022 to February 2026), ICE removals (October 2011 to February 2026), and EOIR immigration court proceedings (July 1988 to February 2026), supplemented by semi-structured interviews with directly impacted individuals and written responses from advocacy organizations serving this community.

The findings document an extraordinary intensification of enforcement against SEA refugees. Total removals reached 1,778 in the first thirteen months of Trump II, more than the Obama and Trump I administrations combined, and a 22-fold increase over Biden's monthly baseline. A Poisson regression places SEA nationals at 17.28 times the Biden-era removal rate, the third-highest multiplier among all nationality groups in the analysis, behind only Cuba and Venezuela. The age of executed removal orders, the age of underlying convictions, and the age distribution of those removed all shifted sharply: 41 percent of orders being executed are at least fifteen years old; the median violent-crime conviction is nineteen years old, with 22.2 percent predating the 1996 statutory reforms; and the median age at removal has risen to forty-six, nine years older than under Obama.

These findings describe the predictable activation of structural mechanisms that have long been in place. The Antiterrorism and Effective Death Penalty Act and the Illegal Immigration Reform and Immigrant Responsibility Act of 1996 retroactively expanded the definition of "aggravated

felony" and stripped judicial discretion in removal proceedings, converting decades-old convictions into deportation predicates. Bilateral repatriation agreements with Cambodia (2002) and Vietnam (2008), together with recent diplomatic pressure on Laos (2025), made those removals executable. The current administration has not invented this architecture; it has fully activated it. The resulting pattern is incidental in design but consequential in effect: a disproportionate enforcement burden falls on a population whose criminal records were themselves produced by the resettlement conditions the U.S. government created, or those without criminal records. Given the unique history of the SEA community, the state has a moral, legal, and social obligation towards this particular group of people.

The paper closes with three tiers of recommendations. At the state level, California should institutionalize a streamlined pardon track for SEA refugees facing removal based on old convictions, expand funding for vacatur litigation under Penal Code § 1473.7, create a pathway for deported individuals to reopen cases for pardon, and close the CalGang-to-ICE data pipeline. Federally, Congress should pass the Southeast Asian Deportation Relief Act, reintroduced in February 2026, which would limit DHS's authority to remove SEA nationals who arrived by 2008, authorize employment eligibility for those with unexecuted removal orders, and create a return pathway for those already deported. Structurally, the 1996 laws themselves require reform: narrowing the aggravated-felony definition, restoring judicial discretion, and extending procedural protections to long-term lawful permanent residents facing removal based on old convictions.

Section 1: Introduction

The inauguration of the second Trump administration has marked a significant shift in U.S. immigration enforcement. On the one hand, proponents of this shift describe this period as a restoration of national priorities; on the other, critics describe it as one of economic disruption, democratic strain, and racial regression. One dimension of the shift is the expansion of ICE operations: warrantless home entries, expanded community-based enforcement, and a climate in which large numbers of immigrant households have had to go into hiding.¹ The enforcement campaign affects many immigrant communities; this paper examines its impact on the Southeast Asian (SEA) refugee community, whose situation reflects a distinct and decades-long pattern of state-imposed harm. For the purposes of this paper, "Southeast Asian" refers to nationals and descendants of Cambodia, Laos, and Vietnam.

The intensification of ICE enforcement has produced documented increases in stress and fear within SEA refugee communities.² Deportations remove household members with little advance notice, leaving spouses, children, and elderly parents to absorb both the separation and the financial consequences that often follow. When the deported individual was a primary earner, the household effects extend to lost wages, housing instability, and reduced access to care, in communities that already face structural disinvestment.³ A substantial share of these deportees are being sent to countries they have not lived in, whose governments may target them for the very histories that brought their families to the United States.

The escalation of immigration enforcement by the current administration has been advertised as a public-safety measure, evident through the current president's executive order titled "Protecting the American People Against Invasion,"⁴ formalizing the immigration enforcement framework

¹Chloe N. East, Caitlin Patler, and Elizabeth Cox, "ICE Arrests across Trump's First and Second Terms: Variation in Targeting, Method, and Geography," NBER Working Paper No. 34794 (Cambridge, MA: National Bureau of Economic Research, February 2026); Human Rights Watch, "US: Masked Federal Agents Undermine Rule of Law," December 18, 2025, <https://www.hrw.org/news/2025/12/18/us-masked-federal-agents-undermine-rule-of-law>.

² Congressional Asian Pacific American Caucus, "Trump's Immigration Policies are Terrorizing Asian Communities, CAPAC and Minnesota Leaders Warn," press release, March 11, 2026, <https://capac.house.gov/press-release/trumps-immigration-policies-are-terrorizing-asian-communities-capac-and-minnesota>; Jireh Deng, "ICE Enforcement Affects Vietnamese, Cambodian Communities in SoCal," *LA Public Press*, July 9, 2025, <https://lapublicpress.org/2025/07/ice-enforcement-affects-vietnamese-cambodian-communities-in-socal/>.

³ Ajay Chaudry, Randolph Capps, Juan Manuel Pedroza, Rosa Maria Castañeda, Robert Santos, and Molly M. Scott, *Facing Our Future: Children in the Aftermath of Immigration Enforcement* (Washington, DC: Urban Institute, 2010)

⁴ Exec. Order No. 14159, "Protecting the American People Against Invasion," 90 Fed. Reg. 8443 (January 29, 2025), <https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2025/01/29/2025-02006/protecting-the-american-people-against-invasion>.

that would define his second term. The rhetoric accompanying it has been consistent; the president, in numerous speeches and public statements, has pledged to deport “the worst of the worst first,” a framing that has been consistently echoed by administration officials across press briefings and policy rollouts,⁵ casting mass immigration enforcement as a targeted campaign against dangerous criminals. This framing warrants examination on three fronts. The first is empirical: who is actually being deported, and does the population match the rhetorical description? The second is normative: even if the rhetoric were accurate, would the rationale itself justify the scope and methods of enforcement? The third is structural: how do these deportations compare against the constitutional, international, and economic commitments the United States has formally adopted?

The first of these questions, who, in fact, is being deported, is the central concern of this paper. Through analysis of deportation numbers, criminal histories, and other demographic factors, the paper attempts to identify patterns in immigration enforcement. The quantitative analysis presented here indicates a clear trend: the criminal profiles of those being deported do not align with the administration's stated priorities. The central argument is that these removals are more accurately described as a broad enforcement net, one that captures longtime residents, refugees, individuals who have completed their sentences and rebuilt their lives, and people with no criminal record at all.

The second question takes a broader view of moral responsibility. Before turning to deportation itself, the conditions under which the underlying criminal records were produced merit examination. The SEA refugee population carries a difficult history of war, displacement, fractured resettlement, poverty, and racial discrimination. As discussed in Section 2, for many in this population, criminal involvement is closely connected to the socioeconomic conditions encountered after arrival. This raises a related question: what responsibility does the United States bear for those conditions, and what responsibility does American society bear for the

⁵U.S. Department of Homeland Security, "100 Days of Secretary Noem: Making America Safe Again," press release, May 5, 2025, <https://www.dhs.gov/news/2025/05/05/100-days-secretary-noem-making-america-safe-again>; U.S. Department of Homeland Security, "Under President Trump and Secretary Noem, the Department of Homeland Security Has Historic Year," press release, December 19, 2025, <https://www.dhs.gov/news/2025/12/19/under-president-trump-and-secretary-noem-department-homeland-security-has-historic>; "As ICE Arrests Increased, a Higher Portion Had No U.S. Criminal Record," *FactCheck.org*, January 28, 2026, <https://www.factcheck.org/2026/01/as-ice-arrests-increased-a-higher-portion-had-no-u-s-criminal-record/>.

circumstances under which these individuals came into contact with the criminal legal system? The paper draws on stakeholder interviews and existing literature to engage these questions.

The third question draws together several overlapping arguments. The first is legal. The Fifth Amendment provides that no person shall be "deprived of life, liberty, or property, without due process of law,"⁶ and the Fourteenth Amendment extends that protection against state action while guaranteeing "equal protection of the laws."⁷ Both clauses apply to persons, not citizens, a distinction the Supreme Court has affirmed repeatedly. Current ICE enforcement practice raises serious due process questions under both. Beyond domestic constitutional protections, the refugee status of many SEA deportees triggers an additional layer of obligation under international law, most notably the principle of non-refoulement, codified in Article 33 of the 1951 Refugee Convention and binding on the United States through the 1967 Protocol, which prohibits returning refugees to countries where their life or freedom would be threatened. Finally, the policy rationale itself is weaker than commonly assumed: the empirical literature does not show that heightened immigration enforcement reduces crime⁸, and the economic costs of mass deportation, in lost labor, lost tax revenue, and enforcement spending⁹, substantially exceed the claimed benefits.

Understanding why the SEA case carries distinctive moral weight requires correcting how this population is commonly framed. Public discourse and policy alike tend to fold the population into the broader category of "immigrants," but this conflation obscures a critical fact: most members of this community are refugees, and those who arrived through other immigration channels are largely family members of refugees.¹⁰ Their arrival in the United States was not a matter of choice but a direct consequence of U.S. military engagement in the Vietnam War and

⁶ U.S. Const. amend. V.

⁷ U.S. Const. amend. XIV, § 1.

⁸ Graham C. Ousey and Charis E. Kubrin, "Exploring the Connection between Immigration and Violent Crime Rates in U.S. Cities, 1980–2000," *Social Problems* 56, no. 3 (August 2009): 447–473; Thomas J. Miles and Adam B. Cox, "Does Immigration Enforcement Reduce Crime? Evidence from 'Secure Communities,'" *Journal of Law and Economics* 57, no. 4 (November 2014): 937–973.

⁹ Felipe Ruiz Mazin and Felix Reichling, "Mass Deportation of Unauthorized Immigrants: Fiscal and Economic Effects," Penn Wharton Budget Model, July 25, 2025, <https://budgetmodel.wharton.upenn.edu/issues/2025/7/28/mass-deportation-of-unauthorized-immigrants-fiscal-and-economic-effects>; Maria-Elena De Trinidad Young, Abby Raisz, et al., *The Economic Impact of Mass Deportation in California* (San Francisco: Bay Area Council Economic Institute and University of California, Merced, June 17, 2025), <https://www.bayareaeconomy.org/report/economic-impact-of-mass-deportation-in-california/>.

¹⁰ Southeast Asia Resource Action Center and Asian Americans Advancing Justice—Los Angeles, *Southeast Asian American Journeys: A National Snapshot of Our Communities* (Washington, DC: SEARAC, March 2020).

the broader Indochina conflicts. The marginalization that began with displacement did not end at the point of arrival. SEA refugees were resettled into under-resourced neighborhoods with limited institutional support, where they encountered racism and persistent poverty, and were left to navigate a society that offered few of the structural footholds it had promised. The criminalization that has now become the legal pretext for deportation should be read against this backdrop. Where members of this community came into contact with the criminal legal system, that contact was rarely unconnected to the conditions of resettlement.

SEA deportations are sometimes treated as marginal within the broader immigration debate, since other communities are being affected in larger absolute numbers. The analysis here is grounded in a different premise: every deportation matters on its own terms. A single removal of a longtime resident, refugee, or person who has rebuilt their life after a completed sentence raises the same constitutional and moral questions, whether it occurs once or ten thousand times, and the legitimacy of the underlying commitments cannot be assessed by aggregate counts alone. Beyond this, no removal involves only one person. Each carries downstream effects on spouses, children, parents, and communities, and the harm compounds across these groups.

The paper takes a multi-method approach. Quantitative analysis of deportation data, criminal histories, and demographic patterns identifies who is most at risk and examines the gap between official rhetoric and enforcement outcomes. Stakeholder interviews and existing scholarship situate that data within the lived experience of the community and the longer history of U.S. foreign policy, refugee resettlement, and racialized criminalization that produced it. The combined approach reflects what numerical analysis alone cannot capture: behind each figure is a person with a family, a history, and a life that current enforcement policy now disrupts.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 sets out the historical and legal background: the war and displacement that produced the SEA refugee population (2.1), the failures of the U.S. resettlement system (2.2), the resulting entanglement of this population with the criminal legal system (2.3), and the statutory architecture that constructed the legal basis for the current enforcement environment (2.4). Section 3 describes the methodology, covering data sources (3.1), research questions (3.2), the analytical approach (3.3), and the relevant data and methodological limitations (3.4). Section 4 presents the empirical results, organized around

overall enforcement trends in arrests, detentions, deportations, and the gap between court orders and actual removals (4.1); regression analysis of nationality-specific enforcement intensity across administrations (4.2); and the enforcement profile of those being removed, including age at removal, criminal charge profile, enforcement classifications, and the age of underlying convictions (4.3). Section 5 discusses these findings in light of the constitutional, international, and policy arguments developed above. Section 6 offers recommendations.

Section 2: Background

2.1 War, Displacement, and the Creation of the SEA Refugee Community

To understand the present situation of SEA refugees in the United States, one must begin with the conditions that displaced them. The mass migration of Cambodian, Laotian, Hmong, and Vietnamese populations to the United States was not the product of opportunity or aspiration; it was the direct consequence of decades of American military and political intervention in Southeast Asia. Beginning with U.S. material support for French colonial rule in Indochina and intensifying through the anti-communist Cold War policy of containment, American foreign policy treated the region as a frontline in a global ideological struggle.¹¹ The Vietnam War (commonly dated 1955–1975, with major U.S. ground escalation beginning in 1965) was the most visible chapter of this engagement, along with the bombing of Cambodia and the Secret War in Laos, in which the CIA recruited and armed Hmong fighters to support American objectives.¹² Across all three countries, the human toll was catastrophic. When American forces withdrew, the populations who had been most closely aligned with U.S. operations, particularly the Hmong in Laos and South Vietnamese collaborators, were left to face violent retaliation from the regimes that emerged.¹³ The refugee flows that followed were a predictable consequence of American foreign policy.

SEA refugee resettlement in the United States unfolded across three distinct waves. The first wave, beginning with the fall of Saigon in 1975, brought roughly 130,000 refugees in that year alone, processed through four reception camps in California, Arkansas, Florida, and Pennsylvania.¹⁴ This first cohort was disproportionately drawn from the educated, professional, and affluent strata of South Vietnamese society, those with the resources and connections to

¹¹ Fredrik Logevall, *Embers of War: The Fall of an Empire and the Making of America's Vietnam*, New York: Random House, 2012; John Lewis Gaddis, *The Cold War: A New History*, New York: Penguin Press, 2005.

¹² Taylor Owen and Ben Kiernan, "Bombs over Cambodia," *The Walrus*, October 2006, 62–69; Hamilton-Merritt, *Tragic Mountains: The Hmong, the Americans, and the Secret Wars for Laos, 1942–1992*, Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1993.

¹³ Hamilton-Merritt, *Tragic Mountains*; Desbarats, Jacqueline, and Karl D. Jackson. "Vietnam 1975–1982: The Cruel Peace." *The Washington Quarterly* 8, no. 4 (Fall 1985): 169–82.

¹⁴ Stephanie M. Kula and Susan J. Paik, "A Historical Analysis of Southeast Asian Refugee Communities: Post-War Acculturation and Education in the United States," *Journal of Southeast Asian American Education and Advancement* 11, no. 1 (2016): Article 1, <https://doi.org/10.7771/2153-8999.1127>;

leave first.¹⁵ By the end of 1975, the camps closed, assuming the refugee crisis had been officially resolved, which it was not. A second wave, beginning in 1979 and continuing through the early 1980s, brought roughly half a million refugees and looked very different from the first.¹⁶ It included rural Vietnamese and ethnic Chinese-Vietnamese expelled in the wake of the Sino-Vietnamese conflict, Cambodians fleeing the Khmer Rouge and its aftermath, and Lao and Hmong refugees fleeing persecution tied to their wartime alignment with U.S. forces. These were largely subsistence farmers with little formal education, no English-language knowledge, and few skills transferable to the U.S. labor market. A third wave through the 1980s and into the 1990s arrived under increasingly restrictive admissions categories, with refugee status gradually replaced by regular immigrant classifications.¹⁷ By the end of 1991, the total SEA refugee population in the United States had reached roughly 995,000.¹⁸

SEA relocation to the US continued beyond the 3 major waves, with the last recorded refugee-based admission dating as far as 2008; however, a growing percentage of arrivals in the 2000s were via permanent residence routes for family reunification.¹⁹ In the 2010 U.S. Census, the SEA population reached approximately 2.5 million. The Vietnamese American community accounted for the largest share at roughly 1.7 million, nearly two-thirds of the total, followed by Cambodian Americans at 276,000, Hmong Americans at 260,000, and Laotian Americans at 232,000.²⁰ More recent estimates, cited in the 2026 reintroduction of the Southeast Asian Deportation Relief Act, place the Vietnamese American population above 2.1 million, with smaller but substantial Cambodian (338,637), Laotian (254,304), and Hmong (326,843) populations.²¹ Yet despite decades of residence in the United States, a portion of this population has never naturalized, a fact that bears directly on present deportation vulnerability, since lawful permanent residents and other non-citizens remain subject to removal in ways that citizens are not. The reasons for this naturalization gap are well documented and include language barriers

¹⁵ Kula and Paik, *A Historical Analysis*; Rubén G. Rumbaut, "The Structure of Refuge: Southeast Asian Refugees in the United States, 1975–1985," *International Review of Comparative Public Policy* 1 (1989): 97–129.

¹⁶ Rumbaut, *The Structure of Refuge*; Kula and Paik, *A Historical Analysis*.

¹⁷ Rumbaut, *The Structure of Refuge*.

¹⁸ U.S. Department of Health and Human Services. Office of Refugee Resettlement. *Annual Report to Congress, Fiscal Year 1991*. Washington, DC: Office of Refugee Resettlement, 1991. , Page ii

¹⁹ U.S. Department of Homeland Security, *Yearbook of Immigration Statistics: 2008* (Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security, Office of Immigration Statistics, 2009), <https://www.dhs.gov/immigration-statistics/yearbook/2008>.

²⁰ Elizabeth M. Hoeffel et al., *The Asian Population: 2010* (Washington, DC: U.S. Census Bureau, 2012).

²¹ U.S. Congress, House, *Southeast Asian Deportation Relief Act of 2026*, H.R. 7608, 119th Cong., 2nd sess., introduced in House February 20, 2026, sec. 2(1), <https://www.govinfo.gov/app/details/BILLS-119hr7608ih>.

(especially among Hmong, Lao, and Cambodian elders), the cost and complexity of applications, and distrust of government institutions among populations who experienced state violence in their countries of origin.²²

2.2 The Failure of Refugee Resettlement

For most SEA refugees, the process of resettlement in the United States was more unsettling than not. Successful resettlement of any group is contingent on a plethora of factors; however, central to it is the tension between assimilation and integration. Is the goal of resettlement to mold refugees into their new environment, or is it to safely welcome them in ways that create space to retain their culture and identity? This tension also plagued SEA resettlement in the US. From its inception, resettlement policy prioritized minimizing disruption to American communities; the successful acclimation of refugees was, at best, a secondary goal. As one advocate described, vulnerability in this community is produced by 'arrival as child refugees, language barriers, a broken immigration system, the school-to-prison-to-deportation pipeline, [and] racism and xenophobia in America', a chain of failures, not a single one.²³

Given the circumstances under which they fled, the community arrived with very particular needs that extended far beyond what resettlement policy was designed to provide. At the very least, they needed English-language instruction and employment assistance tailored to skills that did not readily transfer to the US economy, which was partially addressed by policies.²⁴ But they also needed what the policy framework systematically failed to recognize: trauma-informed care for the psychological and physical aftermath of war and displacement, reunification with extended family and community networks, access to religious and cultural institutions, multilingual navigation of US bureaucracies, and protection from the racism awaiting them in their new neighborhoods.²⁵ The system that received them was unprepared for these needs; both

²² SEARAC and AAAJ-LA, *Southeast Asian American Journeys*; Le, *Asian American Immigrant Inclusion in California*, 23–29, 51.

²³ Author interview with Advocate, April 2026.

²⁴ Kula and Paik, *A Historical Analysis*; Rumbaut, *The Structure of Refuge*.

²⁵ Edith Hsu, Catherine A. Davies, and Daniel J. Hansen, "Understanding Mental Health Needs of Southeast Asian Refugees: Historical, Cultural, and Contextual Challenges," *Clinical Psychology Review* 24, no. 2 (2004): 193–213; Rumbaut, "Structure of Refuge,"; Carol A. Mortland and Judy Ledgerwood, "Secondary Migration among Southeast Asian Refugees in the United States," *Urban Anthropology and Studies of Cultural Systems and World Economic Development* 16, no. 3–4 (1987): 291–326; Kula and Paik, "A Historical Analysis."

the resettlement camps and the private sponsors charged with their acclimation lacked the capacity to meet even the most basic requirements.²⁶

The values that shaped the resettlement policy were grounded in an individualist framework, one that emphasized self-sufficiency, material independence, and rapid economic productivity as measures of successful integration.²⁷ These values directly contradicted the cultural and communal frameworks that SEA refugees brought with them, in which family, community, and collective identity were central. The early language of resettlement programs reflected this mismatch: "self-sufficiency" was the recurring metric, and most of the support offered focused on language acquisition and cultural adaptation rather than on psychological recovery, community-building, or the rebuilding of social fabric.²⁸ Refugees were expected to internalize American values quickly, prove their worth in a racially hostile environment, and demonstrate productivity as a precondition for belonging; a set of demands that asked them to surrender substantial parts of who they were in exchange for a conditional welcome.

Compounding this cultural mismatch was the federal policy of geographic dispersal. The guiding principle of refugee placement was to scatter refugees across the country as widely as possible, assuming that proximity to American communities would accelerate assimilation.²⁹ Interviews with SEA refugees and their descendants revealed the educational barriers many faced upon resettlement. One interviewee recalled being the only SEA at his high school, with no English language skills to navigate it.³⁰ Not only were the refugees stripped away from their homelands, but also from one another. Already separated from extended family and community networks by the violence of displacement, they were now separated from others who shared their language, history, and cultural understanding. This dispersal policy created a sustained pressure to conform to the values and norms of white, middle-class American life.³¹

²⁶ Kelly, Gail P. "Coping with America: Refugees from Vietnam, Cambodia, and Laos in the 1970s and 1980s." *Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science* 487, no. 1 (1986): 138–49.; Rumbaut, "Structure of Refuge"

²⁷ Refugee Act of 1980, Pub. L. No. 96-212, § 412(a)(1)(A), 94 Stat. 102; Rumbaut, "Structure of Refuge"; Hein, *Ethnic Origins*; Nguyen, *Gift of Freedom*.

²⁸ Rumbaut, *Structure of Refuge*; Kula and Paik, *A Historical Analysis*; Hein, *Ethnic Origins*.

²⁹ Desbarats, "Indochinese Resettlement"; Mortland and Ledgerwood, "Secondary Migration"; see also the Indochina Migration and Refugee Assistance Act of 1975, Pub. L. No. 94-23, 89 Stat. 87.

³⁰ Author interview with Impacted Individual, April 2026.

³¹ Nguyen, *Gift of Freedom*

Beyond dispersal, SEA families were disproportionately settled in under-resourced neighborhoods with high crime rates and underfunded schools, where existing competition for scarce public resources intensified racial tensions that newly arrived families were poorly positioned to navigate.³² These neighborhoods were typically deficient in the civic infrastructure, libraries, tutoring services, and youth programming that might have buffered the inadequacies of the local schools. One of the advocates claimed that coming into low-income neighborhoods from war-torn countries was like “trading one war zone for another.”³³ The long-term consequences of these placement decisions are evident today: data compiled by the Southeast Asia Resource Action Center indicate that approximately 26 percent of Hmong Americans, 20 percent of Cambodian Americans, 15 percent of Vietnamese Americans, and 17 percent of Laotian Americans live below the federal poverty line, with roughly 460,000 SEA Americans in poverty overall.³⁴ During one of the interviews with an impacted individual, they recounted the bleak conditions of his childhood: a neighborhood shared with other minority communities, where even necessities like food were a struggle and a sense of confinement that, as he put it, meant “we couldn't go nowhere.”³⁵

The cumulative effect of these resettlement conditions on SEA families was profound. Refugees encountered racism in their schools, neighborhoods, and workplaces, and the bullying their children experienced, often layered on top of existing trauma, became a documented factor in the formation of self-protective youth groups, some of which would later be designated as gangs.³⁶ One impacted individual described joining a youth gang because he and his sisters were being bullied at school. The gang, he explained, came together as “protectors of people”, a defense mechanism against the harsh conditions they faced.³⁷ Family hierarchies were disrupted in ways that traditional structures were not equipped to absorb. Children, who acquired English far more quickly than their parents, were thrust into adult roles of navigating government forms, medical

³² Tang, *Unsettled*; Kula and Paik, “Historical Analysis”; Rawlings, Lynette, Randy Capps, Kerstin Gentsch, and Karina Fortuny. *Immigrant Integration in Low-Income Urban Neighborhoods*. Washington, DC: Urban Institute, 2007.

³³ Author interview with Advocate, April 2026.

³⁴ SEARAC and AAAJ-LA, *Southeast Asian American Journeys*, 28.

³⁵ Author interview with Impacted Individual, April 2026.

³⁶ Michael Liu and Kim Geron, “Changing Neighborhood: Ethnic Enclaves and the Struggle for Social Justice,” *Social Justice* 35, no. 2 (2008): 18–35; Patrick Du Phuoc Long with Laura Ricard, *The Dream Shattered: Vietnamese Gangs in America* (Boston: Northeastern University Press, 1996).

³⁷ Author interview with Impacted Individual, April 2026.

appointments, school systems, and legal documents on behalf of their families.³⁸ As one interviewee described it: "At home I was the child, but outside the house I was the parent."³⁹ The weight of that responsibility on children, many of them already carrying the inherited trauma of displacement, has been documented across the literature on refugee mental health, and the cumulative toll on individual and family well-being is impossible to overstate.⁴⁰

Layered on top of all of this was the structuring role of private-sector involvement in resettlement: a neoliberal model that increasingly outsourced the work of integration to nonprofits, religious organizations, and individual sponsors through the Voluntary Agency (VOLAG) system, fragmenting accountability and entrenching the very self-sufficiency framework that resettlement policy already demands.⁴¹ Secondary migration in the years that followed, as refugees defied dispersal policy and gathered in places like California, Minnesota, and Texas, was a partial corrective, producing the ethnic enclaves that now sustain the SEA American community life.⁴² But the silos that resulted were also a marker of how thoroughly the original resettlement framework had failed.

2.3 Entanglement with Crime

The consequences of these resettlement failures soon became measurable. SEA youth, growing up in under-resourced neighborhoods with under-funded schools and surrounded by gang-active peer groups, were arrested and incarcerated at rates dramatically exceeding their representation in the population.⁴³ Subsequent scholarship has connected these conditions to what is now termed the school-to-prison-to-deportation pipeline, a trajectory produced not by cultural deficiency but by the structural disinvestment and over-policing of the neighborhoods into which

³⁸ Kula and Paik, "Historical Analysis"

³⁹ Author interview with Impacted Individual, April 2026.

⁴⁰ Hsu, Davies, and Hansen, "Understanding Mental Health Needs"; Marshall et al., "Mental Health of Cambodian Refugees."; Marshall, Grant N., Terry L. Schell, Marc N. Elliott, S. Megan Berthold, and Chi-Ah Chun. "Mental Health of Cambodian Refugees 2 Decades After Resettlement in the United States." *JAMA* 294, no. 5 (2005): 571–79.

⁴¹ Nguyen, *Gift of Freedom*; Norman L. Zucker and Naomi Flink Zucker, *The Guarded Gate: The Reality of American Refugee Policy* (San Diego: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1987).

⁴² Mortland and Ledgerwood, "Secondary Migration"; Rumbaut, "Structure of Refuge"; SEARAC and AAAJ-LA, *Southeast Asian American Journeys*.

⁴³ Southeast Asia Resource Action Center, *Southeast Asian Americans and the School-to-Prison-to-Deportation Pipeline* (Washington, DC: SEARAC); Kevin D. Lam, "Racism, Schooling, and the Streets: A Critical Analysis of Vietnamese American Youth Gang Formation in Southern California," *Journal of Southeast Asian American Education and Advancement* 7 (2012); Angela E. Oh and Karen Umamoto, "Asian Americans and Pacific Islanders: From Incarceration to Re-Entry," *Amerasia Journal* 31, no. 3 (2005): 43–59.

refugees were placed.⁴⁴ Interviews with directly impacted individuals trace this pipeline in concrete terms.⁴⁵ The protective youth groups described in the previous section, formed in response to bullying and racial violence in dispersed neighborhoods, became the entry point through which many first encountered the criminal-legal system. Once inside it, many faced adult prosecution as teenagers, an experience that compounded the structural disadvantages they carried into adolescence and locked in the trajectory toward removal that this paper now documents.

A 2006 study of California Youth Authority administrative data found that Cambodian and Laotian youth are significantly overrepresented in California's juvenile justice system, with Laotian youth in particular experiencing disproportionately high rates relative to their population share.⁴⁶ The Asian American and Pacific Islander prison population grew by roughly 250 percent during the 1990s prison boom, and juveniles of Asian descent were more than twice as likely to be tried as adults compared with white juveniles accused of the same offenses.⁴⁷ These outcomes were not the result of cultural pathology or individual moral failure. They were the structurally-predictable consequence of placing traumatized refugee families in neighborhoods with no community infrastructure, no trauma-informed care, and no meaningful path to economic stability, the very conditions that resettlement policy had created. Reflecting on his own pathway through that system, one interviewee said simply that he "didn't know any better, and wished someone had told him to make better decisions" ⁴⁸

Compounding all of this is the structural racism of the carceral system itself. The convictions now being weaponized for removal were produced by a prison-industrial complex with a long history of over-policing and over-punishing communities of color.⁴⁹ And the punishment does not end with a completed sentence. Formerly incarcerated individuals face compounding

⁴⁴ Southeast Asia Resource Action Center et al., *AAPIs Behind Bars: Exposing the School to Prison to Deportation Pipeline* (Washington, DC: Southeast Asia Resource Action Center, 2015); Lam, "Racism, Schooling, and the Streets"; Oh and Umemoto, "From Incarceration to Re-Entry."

⁴⁵ Author interview with Impacted Individual, April 2026.

⁴⁶ Isami Arifuku, Delores D. Peacock, and Caroline Glesmann, "Profiling Incarcerated Asian and Pacific Islander Youth: Statistics Derived from the California Youth Authority Administrative Data," *AAPI Nexus* 4, no. 2 (2006): 95–110.

⁴⁷ SEARAC et al., *AAPIs Behind Bars*.

⁴⁸ Author interview with Impacted Individual, April 2026.

⁴⁹ Michelle Alexander, *The New Jim Crow: Mass Incarceration in the Age of Colorblindness*, rev. ed. (New York: The New Press, 2020).

collateral consequences in housing, employment, and social standing, even before immigration enforcement reaches them.⁵⁰ To then deport someone decades after they have served their time is not enforcement of the law; it is a second punishment imposed on a person the state has already extracted its penalty from. The pages that follow trace how this second punishment has been intensified under the current administration's enforcement regime, and what it has cost the families who arrived in this country decades ago, expecting refuge.

2.4 The Legal Construction of the Current Crisis

The legal architecture that converts old criminal records into deportation orders rests on a foundational distinction that most do not consider: deportation is, in U.S. law, a civil matter, not a criminal one.⁵¹ The consequence of this is that the constitutional protections that attach to criminal proceedings, the right to appointed counsel, proof beyond a reasonable doubt, protection against retroactive penalties under the Ex Post Facto Clause, and the prohibition on double jeopardy do not apply.⁵² A long-term lawful permanent resident facing removal for a decades-old conviction has fewer procedural rights than a defendant facing a misdemeanor charge. The gravity of what deportation actually does to a person, separation from family, return to a country they may not remember, and exposure to the political conditions their family fled, is not legally recognized as punishment, even if it functions as one.

This civil-criminal distinction became consequential for SEA refugees in 1996, when Congress passed two laws that fundamentally restructured the relationship between criminal records and immigration status. The Antiterrorism and Effective Death Penalty Act (AEDPA)⁵³, passed in April 1996, expanded the categories of criminal convictions that triggered deportation and curtailed judicial discretion to grant relief. The Illegal Immigration Reform and Immigrant Responsibility Act (IIRIRA)⁵⁴, passed in September 1996, went further: it dramatically expanded the definition of "aggravated felony", a term in immigration law that triggers mandatory detention and deportation, to include offenses that were neither aggravated nor

⁵⁰ Alexander, *New Jim Crow*.

⁵¹ *Fong Yue Ting v. United States*, 149 U.S. 698, 730 (1893).

⁵² On the absence of a right to appointed counsel, see Immigration and Nationality Act § 292, 8 U.S.C. § 1362 (2018), and *Aguilera-Enriquez v. INS*, 516 F.2d 565 (6th Cir. 1975). On the lower burden of proof, see *Woodby v. INS*, 385 U.S. 276, 285–86 (1966). On the inapplicability of the Ex Post Facto Clause, see *Galvan v. Press*, 347 U.S. 522, 531 (1954), and *Harisiades v. Shaughnessy*, 342 U.S. 580, 593–96 (1952).

⁵³ Antiterrorism and Effective Death Penalty Act of 1996, Pub. L. No. 104-132, 110 Stat. 1214.

⁵⁴ Illegal Immigration Reform and Immigrant Responsibility Act of 1996, Pub. L. No. 104-208, div. C, 110 Stat. 3009-546.

felonies in any conventional sense, including misdemeanors with sentences as short as one year.⁵⁵ Crucially, IIRIRA applied these expansions retroactively.⁵⁶ Convictions that had not been deportable at the time of plea, convictions for which lawful permanent residents had served their sentences and rebuilt their lives, could now be reclassified as grounds for removal years or decades later. Because deportation is civil rather than criminal, the Ex Post Facto Clause does not apply: retroactive consequences that would be unconstitutional in the criminal context are permitted here.

For SEA American refugees, the effect was catastrophic. The structural conditions of resettlement had produced a population of refugees and lawful permanent residents with disproportionately high rates of criminal-legal contact, much of it from the 1980s and early 1990s.⁵⁷ The 1996 laws retroactively converted those records into deportation orders. The legal mechanism that had been described in 1893 as a sovereign administrative act now functioned, for thousands of SEA American families, as a delayed punishment imposed decades after the original sentence had been served.⁵⁸ Today, SEA Americans are three to five times more likely to be deported based on an old criminal conviction than other immigrant populations.⁵⁹

The institutional infrastructure for executing these removals expanded sharply after September 11, 2001. The Homeland Security Act of 2002⁶⁰ dissolved the Immigration and Naturalization Service and redistributed its functions across three new agencies within the newly created Department of Homeland Security: U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services, U.S. Customs and Border Protection, and U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE). ICE was charged with interior immigration enforcement, including the apprehension, detention, and removal of non-citizens with criminal records. Its founding marked a shift in how immigration enforcement was understood: it was now framed primarily as a national-security function rather than as a regulatory one, and its budget, personnel, and detention capacity grew accordingly.⁶¹ The 1996

⁵⁵ Illegal Immigration Reform and Immigrant Responsibility Act of 1996, Pub. L. No. 104-208, div. C, 110 Stat. 3009-546. The expanded definition of "aggravated felony" appears at Immigration and Nationality Act § 101(a)(43), 8 U.S.C. § 1101(a)(43).

⁵⁶ Nancy Morawetz, "Understanding the Impact of the 1996 Deportation Laws and the Limited Scope of Proposed Reforms," *Harvard Law Review* 113, no. 8 (2000): 1936-62.

⁵⁷ Arifuku, Peacock, and Glesmann, "Profiling Incarcerated Youth."

⁵⁸ SEARAC et al., *APIs Behind Bars*.

⁵⁹ *APIs Behind Bars* (2015)

⁶⁰ Homeland Security Act of 2002, Pub. L. No. 107-296, 116 Stat. 2135.

⁶¹ Doris Meissner, Donald M. Kerwin, Muzaffar Chishti, and Claire Bergeron, *Immigration Enforcement in the United States: The Rise of a Formidable Machinery* (Washington, DC: Migration Policy Institute, 2013).

laws had built the legal architecture for mass removal; the post-9/11 reorganization built the institutional capacity to execute it.

Even with the legal and institutional architecture in place, however, removal of SEA deportees was not always practically possible. Deportation requires a receiving country willing to accept the deportee, and for years, Cambodia, Vietnam, and Laos refused. That changed under diplomatic pressure: Cambodia signed a repatriation agreement with the United States in 2002,⁶² and the first deportation flights of Cambodian Americans, many of them long-term lawful permanent residents who had arrived in the United States as small children, began that same year. The agreement immediately rendered approximately 1,600 Cambodian refugees eligible for deportation; in the years that followed, more than 1,000 were ultimately removed to a country most had not seen since childhood, while thousands more received final removal orders that left them awaiting deportation indefinitely.⁶³ Vietnam signed a more limited repatriation agreement in 2008, which excluded refugees who had arrived in the United States before July 12, 1995, the date diplomatic relations were normalized.⁶⁴ Laos initially refused to sign any repatriation agreement and, for two decades, issued travel documents only in rare individual cases, effectively shielding most Laotian and Hmong deportees from removal. As of 2025, partial travel bans and visa holds invoked by the US have created pressure on the Lao government, which has since begun issuing travel documents.⁶⁵ These bilateral agreements, negotiated quietly and largely outside public scrutiny, were the final piece of the architecture: they made the deportations IIRIRA had authorized actually executable.

On January 20, 2025, the second Trump administration assumed office and immediately moved to dismantle the restraints against immigration enforcement. Executive Order 14159, Protecting the American People Against Invasion, rescinded the Biden-era enforcement priorities, expanded the categories of non-citizens subject to expedited removal, and directed ICE to maximize

⁶² Memorandum of Understanding Between the Government of the United States of America and the Royal Government of Cambodia for the Establishment and Operation of a United States-Cambodia Joint Commission on Repatriation, U.S.-Cambodia, March 22, 2002.

⁶³ Bill Ong Hing, "Detention to Deportation: Rethinking the Removal of Cambodian Refugees," *UC Davis Law Review* 38, no. 3 (2005): 891–950; Memorandum of Understanding Between the United States and the Royal Government of Cambodia, March 22, 2002.

⁶⁴ Memorandum of Understanding Between the Government of the United States of America and the Government of the Socialist Republic of Vietnam Concerning the Acceptance of the Return of Vietnamese Citizens, U.S.-Viet., art. 2, § 2, January 22, 2008.

⁶⁵ Asian Law Caucus, "Resources for Southeast Asian Refugees Facing Deportation," <https://www.asianlawcaucus.org/news-resources/guides-reports/resources-southeast-asian-refugees-facing-deportation>.

detention and deportation across all enforcement priorities simultaneously.⁶⁶ Subsequent executive actions and agency guidance have expanded ICE's use of administrative warrants for residential and workplace enforcement, prolonged detention pending removal, and the practice of agents conducting operations while masked and without visible identification.⁶⁷ Reports from December 2025 and February 2026 document ICE operations targeting refugee communities directly, including Cambodian, Vietnamese, and Hmong neighborhoods in California, Massachusetts, and Minnesota. Within this enforcement regime, the legal architecture that has been in place for three decades is being deployed at full capacity.

What this history reveals is that the deportation crisis facing SEA American refugees today is not a sudden departure from prior policy but the predictable activation of a system that was built piece by piece over decades. The civil-criminal distinction permitted retroactivity. The 1996 laws built the legal weapons. The 2002 reorganization built the institutional capacity. The bilateral repatriation agreements made removals executable. The cruelty of this enforcement machinery carries particular moral weight for SEA American communities, given that their displacement is a product of US foreign policy.

⁶⁶ Exec. Order No. 14159, *Protecting the American People Against Invasion*, 90 Fed. Reg. 8443 (January 20, 2025).

⁶⁷ American Immigration Council, "How ICE Went Rogue" (February 2026); Human Rights Watch, "US: Masked Federal Agents Undermine Rule of Law" (December 18, 2025)

Section 3: Methodology

3.1 Data Sources

The primary data source used is ICE removals, arrests, and detentions data, and EOIR immigration court data, all extracted from the deportation data project.⁶⁸ ICE collects data on every person it encounters, arrests, detains, transports via flight, and departs, which the deportation data project has compiled through FOIA requests to ICE.

The arrests dataset (October 2022 – February 2026)⁶⁹ contains 38 variables capturing each apprehension, including temporal details (date, year, month), geographic information (state, area of responsibility, site landmark, duty site), and characteristics of the apprehension itself (type, method, arresting agency, program, operation). It also records demographics (birth year, gender, citizenship country, and grouped citizenship), case-level attributes (status, category, criminality, threat level), and outcome indicators (final order issuance and date, departure country, departed date), along with administrative fields such as a unique identifier, source file references, and a duplicate flag.

The removals dataset (October 2011 – February 2026) contains 49 variables describing individuals who were deported. Alongside overlapping fields on demographics, citizenship, case status, and final program, it provides richer detail on each case's legal trajectory: entry status and date, most serious criminal charge information (charge, code, and date), conviction date, criminal charge status, final charge section and code, and processing disposition. It also includes flags for known terrorist status, suspected gang affiliation, aggravated felony status, and prior deportation, plus state and county geography, port of departure, and age at departure. Shared identifiers and overlapping fields allow enforcement to be examined at both the arrest and removal stages.

The detentions dataset (January 2022 - February 2026)⁷⁰ is structured at two levels: detention stints (61 variables, the full custody episode from initial book-in to final release) and detention

⁶⁸ Deportation Data Project, Ice Removals Database, accessed Feb 10, 2026, <https://deportationdata.org/data/processed/ice.html>

⁶⁹ While the latest update includes data upto March 15, 2026, the month of March is filtered out of all datasets to allow for complete month to month analysis.

⁷⁰ ICE detention records released through FOIA are going back to December 2004, however coverage effectively begins in 2022. Reasoning behind this cutoff decision is further outlined in Appendix A3.

stays⁷¹ (64 variables, each book-in at a specific facility within a stint), together describing individuals held in ICE custody. Alongside overlapping fields on demographics, citizenship, and case status, it provides richer detail on each person's custody trajectory: facility name and type at each stay, book-in and book-out timestamps, area of responsibility (AOR) at book-in, custody length, release reason, and transfer history across facilities. It also includes flags for threat level, criminality classification, mandatory detention, and prior detention, plus apprehension method and landmark, custody classification, and final disposition program. Shared identifiers allow detention episodes to be linked back to arrest and removal records, enabling end-to-end tracing of individuals through the enforcement system.

The EOIR dataset (July 1988 – February 2026) contains 75 variables describing immigration court proceedings. It includes a case identifier, demographics (sex, birth year, nationality, language), and geography (state, county, place, with FIPS codes). The procedural arc is captured through entry date, Notice to appear date, up to four charge sections, first and final courts, hearing locations, assigned judge, in absentia status, and the dates of the immigration judge's decision and final case completion, along with case priority.

Together, the four datasets allow enforcement activity to be examined across arrest, detention, court proceedings, and removal, with overlapping fields on geography, citizenship, and case characteristics enabling linkage across stages.

In addition to the quantitative datasets, I collected qualitative data to contextualize the patterns observed in the enforcement records and to explore dynamics that administrative data cannot capture. This included informal conversations with professors and colleagues, semi-structured interviews with two directly impacted individuals, and written responses to a structured questionnaire from representatives of advocacy organizations.⁷²

The advocacy organization questionnaire was designed to elicit expert perspectives on immigration enforcement against SEAs, the barriers faced during advocacy, and thoughts on future relief pathways.⁷³ Interviews with directly impacted individuals followed a

⁷¹ Each "stay" represents a single, contiguous detention episode in ICE custody; a person held twice in separate episodes is counted twice, and the count is therefore best understood as a measure of throughput rather than unique individuals.

⁷² The questionnaire was sent out to seven organizations, however responses were only received from 3. The low response rates is a consequence of time constraints and the sensitivity of this topic.

⁷³ Complete questionnaire available in Appendix A1

semi-structured protocol designed to trace each person's trajectory from resettlement, through encounters with the criminal justice system, and into the immigration enforcement process, while leaving room for personal reflection at each stage.⁷⁴

All Interview participants requested anonymity; therefore, no identifying information about community members appears in this paper. Interview data is used to contextualize quantitative findings and illustrate the human impact of enforcement patterns identified in the data; it is not used as a source for quantitative claims. Where interview insights are incorporated, they are clearly distinguished from data-derived findings through direct attribution.

Together, the advocacy questionnaires and individual interviews provide complementary perspectives, organizational and systemic on one hand, personal and experiential on the other, that help interpret the trends visible in the data analysis.

3.2 Research Questions

The analysis that follows is organized around a central empirical question:

Who is the United States actually deporting from the SEA American community under the current enforcement regime, and how does that population compare to the "worst of the worst" rhetoric used to justify the removals being executed?

This central question opens onto five sub-questions, each of which is examined in the analytical chapters that follow.

1. How has the scale and intensity of enforcement against SEA Americans changed over time, and how does that change compare to enforcement against other nationality groups?
2. Does the profile of SEA Americans actually being removed correspond to the "worst of the worst" criminal-threat rationale invoked to justify the removals, or does the data reveal a gap between rhetoric and reality?

⁷⁴ Complete interview structure available in Appendix A1

3. How is the enforcement burden distributed geographically, and what does California's profile reveal about the relationship between the concentration of SEA communities and enforcement intensity?
4. What do the lived experiences of directly impacted individuals and the institutional perspectives of advocacy organizations reveal about dynamics that administrative data cannot capture?

Together, these questions are designed to produce a layered answer to the paper's core inquiry. The empirical analysis establishes what is happening and to whom; the qualitative material illuminates what that means for the people experiencing it; and the structural framework developed in Section 2 explains why this population merits special attention.

3.3 Analytical Approach

This paper employs a mixed-methods approach combining quantitative analysis of administrative data with qualitative interviews with community members, legal advocates, and policy experts.

3.3.1 Time Series and Descriptive Analysis

All time series analyses use calendar-year reporting rather than the federal fiscal year (October to September) convention used by ICE in its official reporting. This decision was made to enable cleaner comparisons across administrations, as inaugural dates fall in January, making calendar-year reporting more intuitive for identifying administration-specific enforcement shifts. All figures for 2026 reflect partial-year data covering January through February only and are labeled accordingly throughout.

Monthly and annual trends are examined across four administration periods: Obama's second term (2012–2016), Trump's first term (Trump I, 2017–2020), Biden's (2021–2024), and Trump's second term (Trump II, 2025–2026). Administration boundary lines are marked consistently across all charts. Descriptive statistics include counts, percentages, year-on-year absolute and proportional changes, and distributional summaries including medians, means, and interquartile

ranges where sample sizes permit. Age analysis uses birth year to calculate age at time of removal, with ages below 15 and above 80 excluded as implausible.

Proportional change measures how sharply enforcement has escalated relative to a group's own baseline, not how heavily a group is targeted overall. Nationalities with already-high baselines mechanically show smaller percentage increases, while those with previously low baselines can show dramatic jumps. The figures, therefore, are not a measure of who is most targeted, but of where targeting has intensified most sharply under the current administration, surfacing nationalities now drawn into enforcement at rates far above their historical norms.

Overall trends are compared with the Top 10 nationalities, identified by removal volume in 2025, to extract the top 10 targeted by ICE, and then assess how this compares with SEA nationals.

3.3.2 Regression Modeling

A Poisson regression model⁷⁵ is used to test whether SEA nationals experienced disproportionately larger enforcement surges under Trump II compared to other nationalities, after controlling for baseline differences in removal volumes. Poisson regression is appropriate for count data, such as monthly removal totals, which are non-negative, right-skewed, and cannot be modeled using standard linear regression.

The model disaggregates by nationality group, estimating separate interaction effects for the ten nationalities with the highest 2025 removal volumes plus SEA nationals as a combined group, with all remaining nationalities collapsed into an "All Other Nationalities" category.

All regression results are reported as Incidence Rate Ratios (IRRs), multiplicative effects relative to the Biden baseline, with 95 percent confidence intervals. The key coefficient of interest is the $is_sea \times trump2$ interaction term, which captures the enforcement surge experienced by SEA nationals beyond the general enforcement increase under Trump II.

⁷⁵ Further explanation of the model available in Appendix A2

3.4 Limitations

3.4.1 Data Limitations

Despite the caveats outlined below, the Deportation Data Project provides the most recent and granular publicly available record of U.S. immigration enforcement. The data nonetheless carry limitations that bear on how the findings in this paper should be read.

Every record reflects what ICE itself entered into its operational system at the time of the action, not an independently verified account. Categorical fields, including charge classifications, threat level, criminality, gang and terrorist flags, and aggravated-felon status, depend on ICE's internal labels rather than on independent court verification. ICE's practice of treating dismissed and pending charges as "criminal" for removal purposes can blur the distinction between conviction and allegation, and the "aggravated felony" flag follows the post-1996 immigration-law definition under INA §101(a)(43), which is broader than the criminal-law sense of the term. These fields should therefore be read as evidence of how ICE characterizes its enforcement, not as the ground truth about the people it enforces against.

The field population is also uneven across both time and variable. Some fields have been reliably populated only in recent years: the Area of Responsibility (AOR) field in the removals table, for example, is largely missing before 2023, which restricts pre-2023 geographic analysis to the small subset of records with a recorded state field. The full pattern of missingness is documented in Appendix B Table B20 and is reported transparently throughout the analysis.

The data are also limited in scope. DDP's ICE arrest data, like all FOIA-based ICE arrest extracts, capture only arrests made by ICE's Enforcement and Removal Operations (ERO) division. They exclude arrests by non-ERO ICE officers, by other DHS components, and by state and local actors operating under 287(g) agreements. Counts derived from these data will therefore understate the full scope of interior immigration enforcement, particularly in counties with active 287(g) cooperation.

A reader might reasonably ask whether ICE could fabricate records to meet enforcement targets, given the daily arrest quotas reported during the second Trump administration. Direct fabrication is structurally difficult: ICE records are tied to A-numbers, biometrics (fingerprints, photos), and cross-references with CBP arrest logs, EOIR court dockets, detention facility book-in systems, and federal criminal databases, and any invented person would need to be reconciled across all of these systems. OIG audits, congressional inquiries, FOIA litigation, and routine attorney access to client A-files create multiple opportunities for ghost records to surface, and none have been documented at scale. The better-evidenced concern is categorical manipulation, mid-period redefinition of arrest types, elastic application of the "criminal" label, and re-arrests of the same individual generating multiple records, which can shift what aggregate counts appear to mean without inventing anyone.

Finally, the data are likely to underreport the true scope of enforcement impact on the SEA American community. They capture only formal enforcement actions that produced a recorded outcome; voluntary departures, individuals who self-deport before formal proceedings begin, U.S. citizen family members and dependents affected by a relative's removal, and cases that resolved before reaching a removal record are all invisible to this analysis. The figures presented in the chapters that follow should therefore be read as a floor on enforcement intensity rather than as a comprehensive measure of community impact.

3.4.2 Methodology Limitations

The analysis is fundamentally descriptive rather than causal. The pre-Trump II to Trump II comparisons document association rather than effect: they describe what enforcement looked like before and after the second administration began, but cannot isolate the causal contribution of any specific policy from the broader environment in which it was implemented. The findings throughout this paper should therefore be read as descriptions of observed enforcement patterns under Trump II, not as estimates of the causal effect of the administration itself or of any individual policy within it.

The analysis compares 13 nationality groups across 4 administrations and multiple enforcement metrics, producing several hundred individual comparison cells. In a comparison space this large, some apparently striking differences will arise by chance alone, and any single point estimate should be read with that in mind. The argument advanced here does not rest on any one comparison but on the convergence of patterns across multiple distinct metrics, enforcement volume, detention length, ICE/EOIR ratio, the age of removal orders being executed, the age of underlying convictions, and the age distribution of those removed, all of which point in the same direction for the SEA population specifically. Convergence across independent metrics is harder to attribute to chance than any individual finding would be, but readers should nonetheless treat individual percentages and multipliers as illustrative of the broader pattern rather than as precise effect sizes.

The analysis covers only the first 13 months of Trump II. Patterns observed in this window may not persist; they may also intensify, or shift in character as new policies are implemented, existing ones consolidate, and operational capacity continues to scale. The SEA-specific findings, the surge in detention volume, the inversion of the ICE/EOIR ratio, the rising share of decades-old orders being executed, and the lengthening of detention stays describe an enforcement environment still unfolding rather than settled. Conclusions presented here are therefore point-in-time and subject to revision as additional months of data become available, and as the operational, diplomatic, and judicial conditions that produced the documented patterns continue to evolve.

Section 4: Data Analysis

4.1 Overall Trends

The four subsections that follow examine SEA enforcement at each stage of the system: arrests (4.1.1), detentions (4.1.2), deportations (4.1.3), and the gap between court-issued removal orders and the removals ICE actually executes (4.1.4).

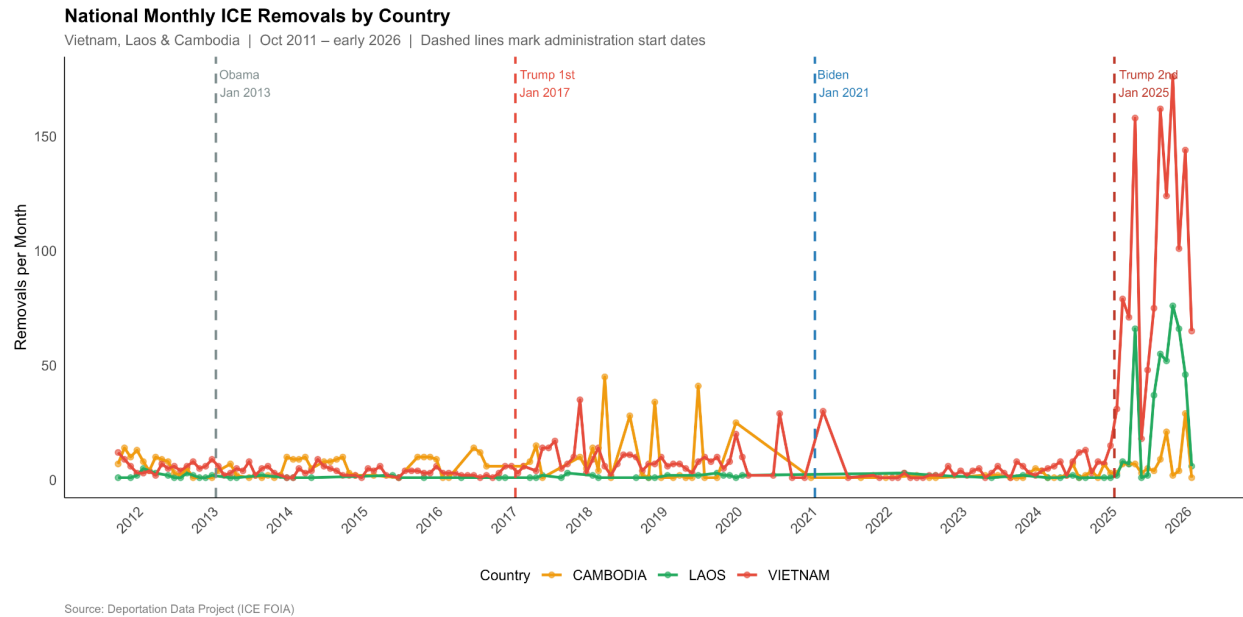
4.1.1 Arrests

Between October 2022 and February 2026, ICE arrested a total of 438,380 individuals across all nationalities. Central America and Mexico had the highest numbers, 350,401 arrests (79.9 percent of all arrests), followed by South America with 54,295 (12.4 percent), the Caribbean with 16,091 (3.7 percent of all arrests), Europe and Asia with 11,125 (2.5 percent of all arrests), and the Middle East and Africa with 4,043 (0.9 percent of all arrests).⁷⁶

Of the 438,380 ICE arrests recorded between October 2022 and March 2026, Mexico accounts for 201,872 (46 percent), the single largest share by nearly a factor of three over any other country. Guatemala (61,704, 14.1 percent) and Honduras (52,100, 11.9 percent) follow as the second-largest and third-largest contributors. Each of the remaining top-10 nationalities accounts for less than 5 percent of the national total: El Salvador (20,057, 4.6 percent), Venezuela (19,587, 4.5 percent), Nicaragua (13,862, 3.2 percent), Colombia (12,406, 2.8 percent), Ecuador (11,153, 2.5 percent), Cuba (6,089, 1.4 percent), and Brazil (4,797, 1.1 percent). All other nationalities combined account for another 33,405 (7.6 percent). Vietnamese, Laotian, and Cambodian arrests combined total 1,348, 0.3 percent of the national caseload.⁷⁷

⁷⁶ See Appendix; Table B1 for underlying data and Figure C1 for Graph.

⁷⁷ See Appendix; Table B3 for underlying data and Figure C2 for Graph.

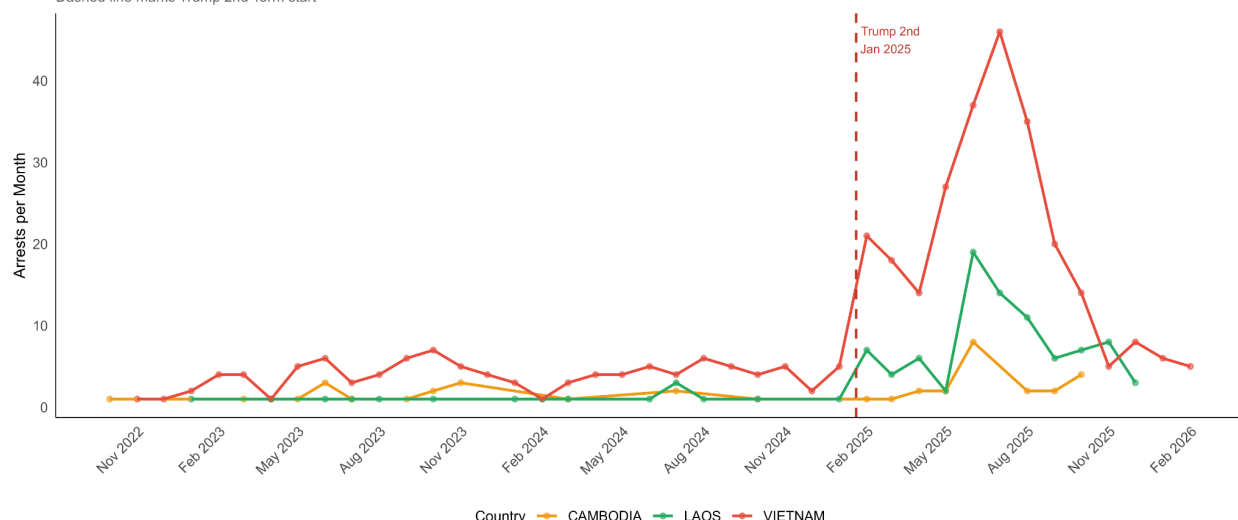


Despite the low absolute numbers of SEA arrests, the story changes when analyzing the surge. SEA nationals saw the largest percentage increase among all groups. Under Trump II, monthly arrest volumes rose for every top-10 nationality, but the proportional surge varied dramatically. Of all nationalities tracked, Southeast Asia ranks third in proportional intensification (+628 percent, monthly average rising from 11 to 80 arrests), trailing only Venezuela (+1,009 percent) and Cuba (+747 percent). Ecuador (+460 percent), Brazil (+424 percent), and Guatemala (+381 percent) followed. The remaining top-10 nationalities saw more moderate but still substantial increases: Honduras +238 percent, Nicaragua +223 percent, El Salvador +214 percent, Colombia +206 percent, and Mexico +205 percent (with monthly arrests rising from 2,984 to 9,103, the largest absolute increase of any nationality). Arrests of all other nationalities combined rose 188 percent.⁷⁸

⁷⁸ See Appendix; Table B4 for underlying data.

California Monthly ICE Arrests by Country

Vietnam, Laos & Cambodia | October 2022 – Feb 2026 | California identified via AOR (LA, SF, San Diego)
Dashed line marks Trump 2nd Term start



Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA)

California arrests of SEA nationals mirror the national surge. In the pre-Trump II period (October 2022 to January 2025), California recorded a total of 135 SEA arrests over 28 months, averaging just 5 arrests per month. Vietnam dominated even in this baseline period with 101 arrests (monthly average 3.7), followed by Cambodia with 18 (monthly average 1.5) and Laos with 16 (monthly average 1.1).⁷⁹

Under Trump II, the surge in California arrests is dramatic across all three nationalities. Vietnamese arrests rose from a monthly average of 3.7 to 18.5, a 405 percent increase, with a single-month peak that dwarfs anything in the prior period. Laotian arrests saw a similar trend, rising from 1.1 per month to 7.9 per month, a 618 percent increase, making Laos the fastest-growing arrest category in California. Cambodian arrests grew from 1.5 to 2.8 per month (87 percent increase), the most modest growth of the three, consistent with Cambodia's smaller California community concentration relative to Vietnam and Laos.⁸⁰

Contextualizing California within the national picture reinforces the state's outsized role. Nationally, SEA arrests averaged 11 per month before Trump II and 80 per month under Trump II, a 628 percent increase. California's pre-Trump II monthly average of 4.8 arrests represented roughly 46 percent of the national total, consistent with California's known concentration of SEA

⁷⁹ See Appendix; Table B6 for underlying data.

⁸⁰ See Appendix; Table B6 for underlying data.

communities. Under Trump II, California's combined monthly average of approximately 26 arrests accounted for about 35 percent of the national monthly average.⁸¹

While SEA arrests remain numerically small relative to other nationalities, comprising just 0.3 percent of the national caseload and ranking last among the nationalities tracked, the magnitude of the surge tells a different story. Despite low absolute numbers, this proportional surge reflects an equal, if not greater, intensification of targeting. The 628 percent increase in monthly arrests, the third-largest of any nationality and a third of which comes from California, signals an enforcement intensification that is disproportionate to the size of the SEA population.

4.1.2 Detentions

Across the period analyzed, ICE booked a total of 1,051,748 detention stays, of which the largest share, 602,600 stays (57 percent), involved nationals of Central America and Mexico. South America accounted for 245,873 stays (23 percent), Caribbean nationals 64,893 (6 percent), and Other Asian nationals 51,451 (5 percent). SEA nationals account for 4,781 detention stays across the seven-year window, or 0.5 percent of all detentions.⁸²

A shift in immigration detention under Trump II is not uniform across the regions tracked. Mexico saw the second-largest proportional surge, with monthly detention bookings rising from a pre-Trump II average of 5,170 to 12,118, a 134 percent increase. Central America rose 80 percent (5,841 to 10,517 monthly). The Caribbean rose 13 percent (1,522 to 1,713 monthly); Other East/Southeast Asia rose 12 percent (415 to 465 monthly); South America dropped by 22 percent (6,461 to 4,998 monthly); Europe & Central Asia also dropped 18 percent (830 to 679 monthly); and Sub-Saharan Africa dropped 40 percent (852 to 510 monthly). Decreases were also recorded for the Middle East & North Africa (-34 percent) and South Asia (-41 percent).⁸³

The negative values across South America, Europe & Central Asia, Sub-Saharan Africa, MENA, and South Asia likely reflect a shift in enforcement patterns rather than a relaxation of pressure. Detention bed space is finite, and even with expanded ICE capacity under Trump II, the administration's prioritization of southern-border nationals appears to have crowded out other

⁸¹ See Appendix; Table B5 for underlying data.

⁸² See Appendix; Table B1 for underlying data.

⁸³ See Appendix; Table B2 for underlying data and Figure C3 for Graph.

groups. However, in reality, where bed space is unavailable, enforcement is increasingly likely to rely on direct expulsion. A drop in detentions for these regions, then, may signal not less enforcement but a different form of it, one that bypasses U.S. detention infrastructure entirely.

A closer look at the top 10 nationalities makes it clear that the regional decreases are the exception, not the rule; most heavily detained groups saw surges under Trump II. Mexican detentions rose from a pre-Trump II monthly average of 5,171 to 12,118 under Trump II, an increase of 134 percent. The Northern Triangle countries followed: Guatemala rose 108 percent (2,250 to 4,670), El Salvador 65 percent (844 to 1,396), and Honduras 65 percent (2,083 to 3,441). Cuba rose 90 percent (472 to 894), Venezuela 62 percent (1,320 to 2,141), Nicaragua 65 percent (574 to 947), and Brazil 51 percent (286 to 432). Colombia (–54 percent) and Ecuador (–42 percent) were the only top-10 nationalities to see declines in detention under Trump II.⁸⁴

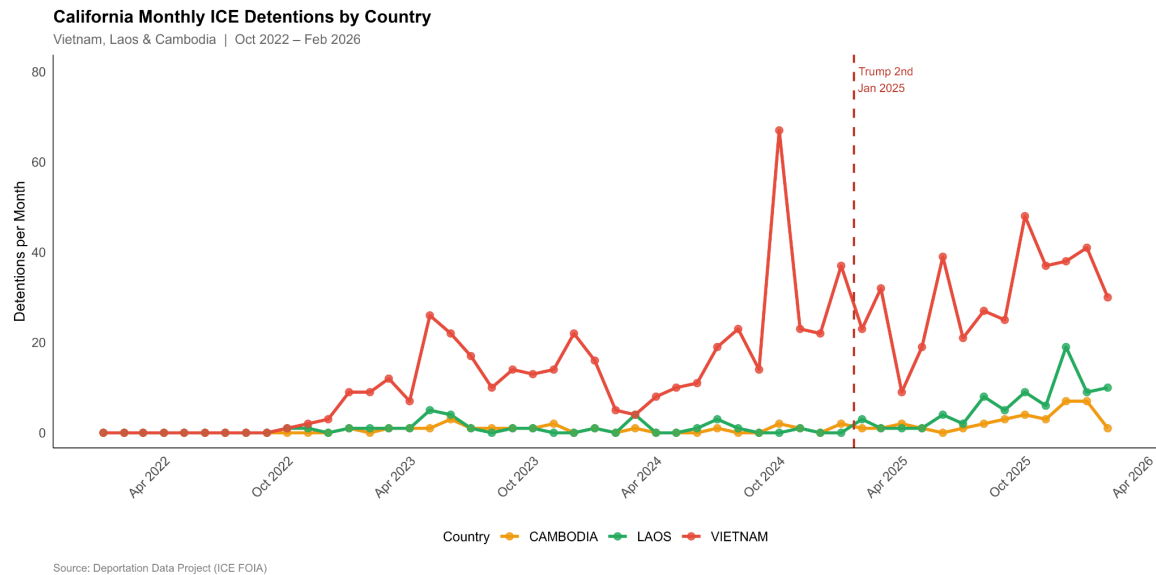
SEA detentions rose from a pre-Trump II average of 71 stays per month to 215 stays per month under Trump II, an increase of 203 percent. This is the steepest proportional surge among the nationality groups examined, exceeding those of Mexico, the Northern Triangle countries, and every other top-10 nationality. While SEA volumes remain a small share of national totals, the rate of escalation tells a different story than the absolute numbers alone suggest.⁸⁵

The annual breakdown reinforces the magnitude of the 2025 acceleration. In 2025 alone, ICE booked 2,535 SEA nationals into detention, the highest single-year total in the available data. However, this trend cannot be attributed solely to Trump; while the Trump surge is higher, there has been a general year-to-year increase in detentions. SEA detentions have effectively doubled year-over-year since 2023, rising from 506 in 2023 to 1,189 in 2024 (2.35×) and 2,535 in 2025 (2.13×). January and February 2026 added approximately 461 detentions, a monthly pace of ~230, close to 2025's monthly average of ~211, suggesting 2026 is tracking 2025's elevated baseline so far. The 2022 figure should be read with caution, as the detention dataset only begins in October of that year.⁸⁶

⁸⁴ See Appendix; Table B4 for underlying data and Figure C4 for Graph.

⁸⁵ See Appendix; Table B4 for underlying data.

⁸⁶ See Appendix; Figure C5 for Graph.



The California monthly time series shows the operational ramp-up. Across the pre-Trump II window (October 2022 – January 2025), monthly California SEA detentions remained consistently low, typically under 35, with a notable one-month spike to 69 in October 2024, predominantly Vietnamese (67 of 69), and briefly exceeded any subsequent Trump II month. Under Trump II, however, the elevated level became sustained rather than episodic: monthly California SEA detentions averaged 38.5 across the 13 months from February 2025 to February 2026, roughly 2.2 times the pre-Trump II monthly average of 17.5. Vietnam dominated the country-level distribution as expected, accounting for 389 of the 500 California SEA detentions during Trump II (77.8 percent); Laos accounted for 78 (15.6 percent), and Cambodia for 33 (6.6 percent). The Laotian surge is particularly striking in temporal terms: California Laotian detentions averaged just 1.7 per month before Trump II but jumped to 6.0 per month under Trump II (+253 percent), with the increase concentrated sharply in the second half of 2025 and early 2026, tracking directly with the June 2025 U.S. travel ban on Laos that restored the diplomatic conditions for removal. The combination of high California detention volume, sustained Vietnamese dominance, and a sharply rising Laotian share makes California one of the more consequential subnational geographies for SEA detention enforcement.⁸⁷

Under Trump II, the median length of completed SEA detention stays was 85.3 days. The corresponding median for Mexican nationals was 8.9 days, meaning the typical SEA detention is

⁸⁷ See Appendix; Table B5 and B6 for underlying data.

roughly ten times longer than the typical Mexican detention. The median for Northern Triangle nationals was substantially shorter as well: 17.3 days for Guatemalans, 20.8 for Hondurans, and 26.8 for Salvadorans. SEA detainees are held meaningfully longer than every other major nationality group analyzed; the next-longest group, Cuba, has a Trump II median of 73.0 days, with all remaining groups clustered between 8 and 50 days.⁸⁸

The 85-day median may underestimate the true SEA detention length under Trump II for two reasons. First, the calculation includes only completed stays, those with both a book-in and a book-out date. Approximately 39 percent of SEA Trump II stays in the dataset have no book-out date, indicating ongoing detention as of the most recent data refresh.⁸⁹

Taken together, the detention findings tell a consistent story. SEA detentions surged at the steepest rate of increase among the nationality groups examined. Once detained, SEA nationals are held substantially longer than any other group: a Trump II median of 85.3 days against 8–50 days for most major nationalities, and a 75th percentile of roughly 132–134 days in both pre-Trump II and Trump II periods, meaning a quarter of SEA detainees are held for more than four months. The next-highest 75th-percentile figure under Trump II is Cuba at 121.7 days; for most groups, it falls between 30 and 75.⁹⁰

These figures are not abstract; even a longer detention period is a significant and disproportionate burden on this community. Months in detention sever primary earners from their families, drain household savings, and produce a kind of prolonged legal limbo, no scheduled court date, no removal date, no certainty about what comes next. The interview material captures the lived shape of this experience. One interviewee described being transferred directly from state custody into ICE detention the moment his criminal sentence ended; unable to contact his family, with no understanding of what was happening to him or where it was leading, he described the experience as one of fear and confusion, a continuation of punishment that no one had prepared him for.

⁸⁸ See Appendix; Table B14 for underlying data and Figure C6 for Graph.

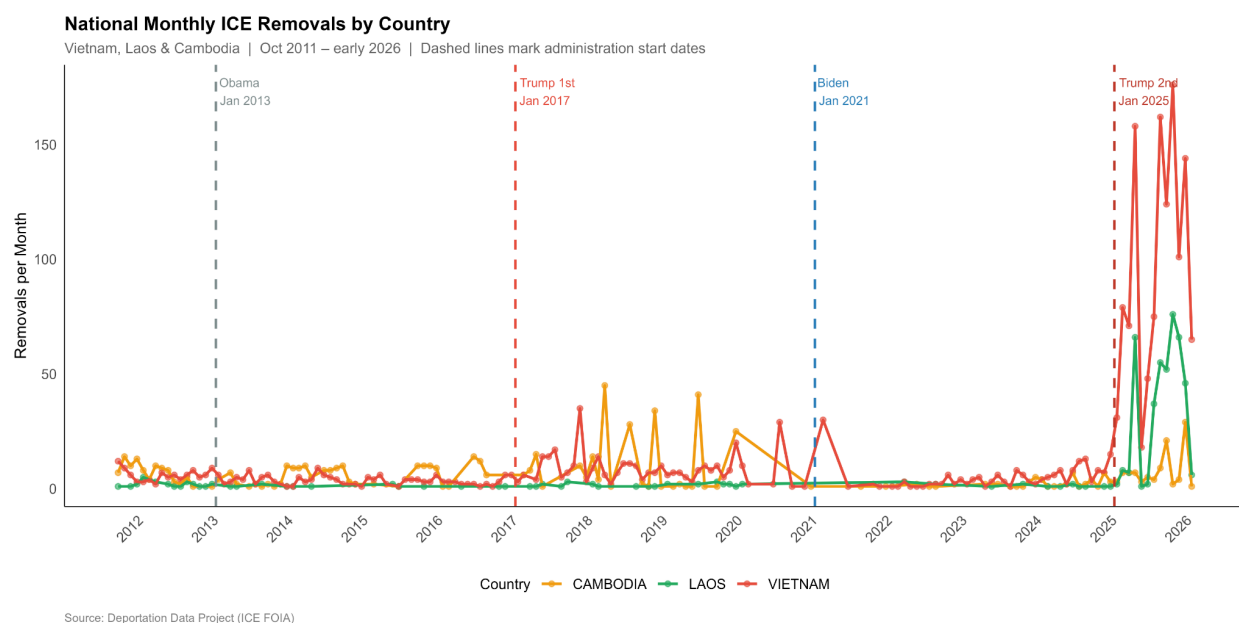
⁸⁹ See Appendix; Table B14 for underlying data and Figure C6 for Graph.

⁹⁰ See Appendix; Table B14 for underlying data.

4.1.3 Deportations

Between October 2012 and February 2026, ICE executed 3,672,718 removals across all regions. Mexico (1,930,469) and Central America (1,256,668) together accounted for 86.8 percent of all removals over the period, followed by South America (6.7 percent), the Caribbean (2.5 percent), and all other regions combined (4.0 percent). Vietnamese, Laotian, and Cambodian removals totaled 3,252 (0.1 percent).⁹¹

When evaluating the top 10 nationalities targeted, Mexico remained the largest single source country throughout, but its share fell from 63 percent under Obama to 53 percent under Trump I, 36 percent under Biden, and 39 percent under Trump II. The Northern Triangle (Guatemala, Honduras, and El Salvador) accounted for the next-largest share, ranging from 28 percent to 37 percent across administrations. The declining concentration among these traditional source countries reflects the rise of Venezuela, Cuba, Colombia, and Ecuador, which collectively grew from under 1.5 percent under Obama to 15.4 percent under Trump II.⁹²



SEA nationals were a negligible share of total removals across all administrations until 2025. Total SEA removals were 577 under Obama over four years (monthly average 9.0), 635 under

⁹¹ See Appendix; Table B1 for underlying data and Figure C7 for Graph.

⁹² See Appendix; Table B7 for underlying data and Figure C8 for Graph.

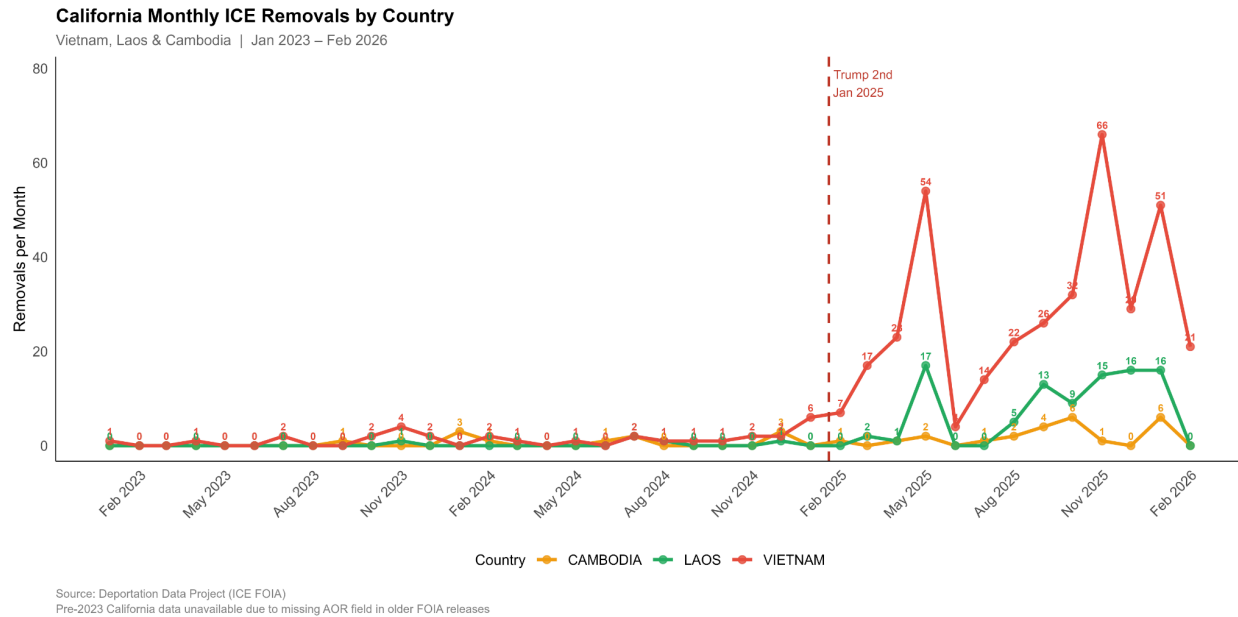
Trump I (monthly average 14.8), and just 262 under Biden (monthly average 6.2), the lowest of any prior administration despite Biden's overall higher removal volumes. Under Trump II, 1,778 SEA nationals were removed in just 13 months (a monthly average of 137), more than the Obama and Trump I periods combined, and a 2,110 percent increase over Biden's monthly baseline. The scale of this acceleration is without precedent in the data. Every single one of the 10 highest monthly SEA removal totals in the entire dataset occurred under Trump II: November 2025 (254), May 2025 (231), September 2025 (226), January 2026 (219), October 2025 (197), December 2025 (171), August 2025 (116), March 2025 (94), April 2025 (85), and February 2026 (72). Before January 2025, the highest single month on record was just 51 removals in 2018.⁹³

SEA's share of all removals rose from 0.03 percent under Obama to 0.07 percent under Trump I to 0.04 percent under Biden to 0.4 percent under Trump II, a 10-fold increase in share within a single administration. For comparison, Central America and Mexico saw their monthly average roughly double from 11,003 under Biden to 22,295 under Trump II, a 103 percent increase. South America's monthly average more than doubled from 2,468 to 5,121 (108 percent increase). SEA's monthly average increased 22-fold over the same period, a growth rate approximately 10 times larger than the dominant removal group. This disproportionality is not explained by any general enforcement escalation: every other nationality group saw modest to moderate increases while SEA experienced an order-of-magnitude surge with no precedent in the prior 13 years of data.⁹⁴

These growth rates are not directly comparable across groups because baseline sizes differ by orders of magnitude. SEA's pre-Trump II monthly removals (~6 per month under Biden) were tiny relative to Mexico and Central America combined (~11,000 per month), which means proportional changes are mechanically easier to generate from a small base. The point of the comparison is therefore not that SEA enforcement now rivals these other groups in volume; it does not, and will not on the trajectory shown, but that the rate at which enforcement against this small, long-settled population is escalating is itself the finding worth attention.

⁹³ See Appendix; Table B7 for underlying data.

⁹⁴ See Appendix; Table B7 for underlying data.



Of the 3,252 SEA nationals removed between 2011 and early 2026, geographic data sufficient for California-level analysis is available only from 2023 onwards, when the AOR field becomes fully populated. California's share of national SEA enforcement under Trump II is substantial: of the 1,778 SEA removals nationally during Trump II, 484 (27.2 percent) were confirmed California removals.⁹⁵

Within California, Vietnam dominates the country-level breakdown. Of the 484 SEA removals carried out in California under Trump II, 366 (75.6 percent) were Vietnamese, 94 (19.4 percent) were Laotian, and 24 (5.0 percent) were Cambodian. Vietnamese California removals averaged 28.2 per month, Laotian 10.4 per month, and Cambodian 2.7 per month. The Vietnamese concentration in California is consistent with the state's large Vietnamese diaspora.⁹⁶

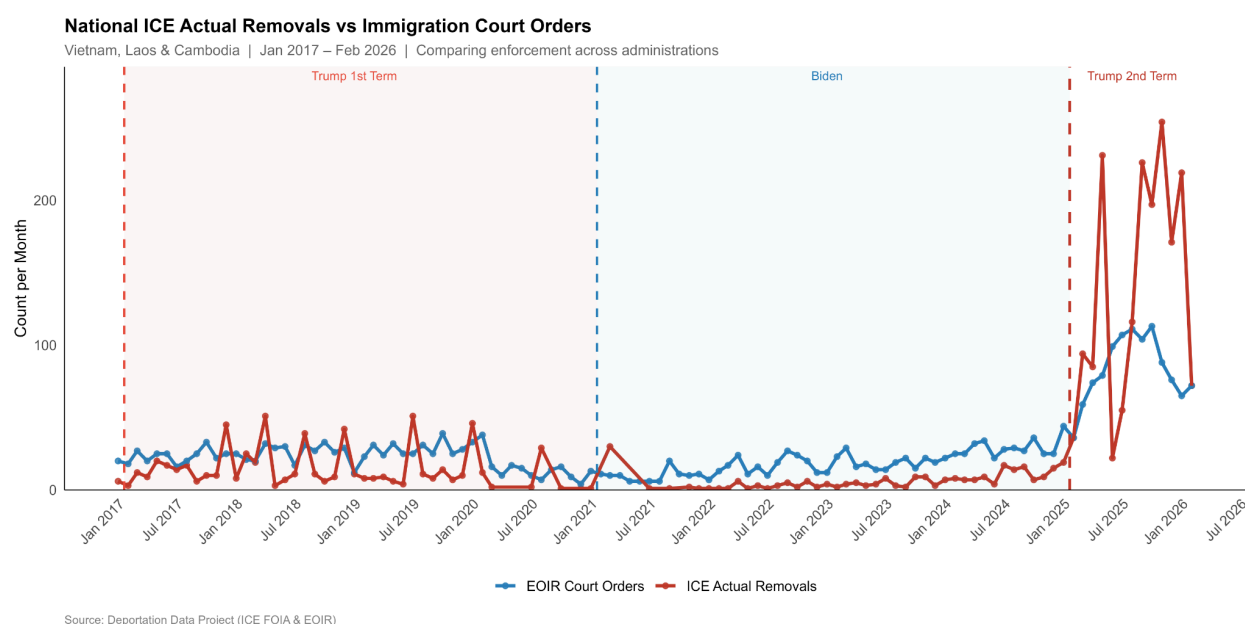
The pre-Trump II-to-Trump II contrast at the country level is dramatic. Vietnamese California removals rose from 33 total pre-Trump II (2/month) to 366 under Trump II (28/month), a 1,467 percent increase. Laotian removals rose from 5 (1.2/month) to 94 (10.4/month), a 767 percent increase. Cambodian removals rose from 11 (1.8/month) to 24 (2.7/month), a 50 percent

⁹⁵ See Appendix; Table B5 for underlying data.

⁹⁶ See Appendix; Table B6 for underlying data; On Vietnamese diaspora, Pew Research Center. (2023). *Facts about Vietnamese in the U.S.* [Analysis of 2023 U.S. Census data] <https://www.pewresearch.org/race-and-ethnicity/fact-sheet/asian-am>, while ICE executed just 9 actual removals per month, a ratio of 0.26, meaning ICE was removing roughly one person for every four removal orders issued.

increase. Combined, SEA California removals rose from 49 (2.3/month) to 484 (37.2/month), a 1,517 percent increase in monthly enforcement intensity. For context, California's Trump II SEA removal total of 484 is nearly twice the entire national SEA removal total under Biden across four years (262). The pre-Trump II to Trump II jump in California directly mirrors the national pattern, confirming that California's SEA communities experienced the same abrupt enforcement escalation as the rest of the country, and that California, home to the largest concentration of Vietnamese Americans nationally, bears a disproportionate share of that enforcement burden.⁹⁷

4.1.4 Court Orders vs Actual Removals



An interesting addition to this analysis is the comparison of two distinct measures of immigration enforcement against SEA nationals: EOIR immigration court removal orders, the legal instrument authorizing deportation, and ICE actual removals, the physical execution of those orders. Under a functioning legal system operating with due process, these two lines should move together, with court orders preceding or tracking removals. The data reveals a dramatic structural break under Trump II that inverts this relationship entirely.

Under Obama and Biden, court orders consistently and substantially exceeded actual removals. During Obama, EOIR issued an average of 35 removal orders per month against SEA nationals

⁹⁷ See Appendix; Table B6 for underlying data.

while ICE executed just 9 actual removals per month, a ratio of 0.26, meaning ICE was removing roughly one person for every four removals ordered by a court. Under Biden, courts issued 18.8 orders per month on average while ICE executed ~6 removals, a ratio of 0.33, or roughly one removal for every three court orders. In 41 of 42 Biden months, EOIR court orders exceeded ICE's actual removals. This pattern is consistent with prior administrations exercising prosecutorial discretion; courts were ordering removals that ICE did not execute, leaving people with final orders living in the community.⁹⁸

During Trump I, EOIR issued an average of 22.9 removal orders per month while ICE executed 14.8 actual removals per month, a ratio of 0.65, meaning ICE was removing roughly two people for every three removal orders by a court. The headline ratio of 0.65 masks substantial month-to-month volatility within Trump I: ICE removals fluctuated between 0 and 51 per month with no consistent baseline, while EOIR orders held relatively steady in the 16-39 range across the entire four-year period. The five highest ICE removal months, April 2018 (51), July 2019 (51), January 2020 (46), December 2017 (45), and December 2018 (42), together account for 235 removals, more than a third of the 640 executed in total. These spikes are the operational signature of charter-flight batch deportations, most prominently the documented Cambodian repatriation flights of late 2017 and December 2018, when ICE briefly mobilized to clear long-pending orders during narrow diplomatic windows.

Trump II inverts this relationship completely. ICE actual removals surged to a monthly average of 137, exceeding EOIR court orders, which averaged 83.3 per month, producing a ratio of 1.64. In 9 of 13 months of Trump II, ICE removals exceeded new court orders. The gap is now positive and large; ICE is executing an average of 53.5 more removals per month than courts are issuing new orders.⁹⁹

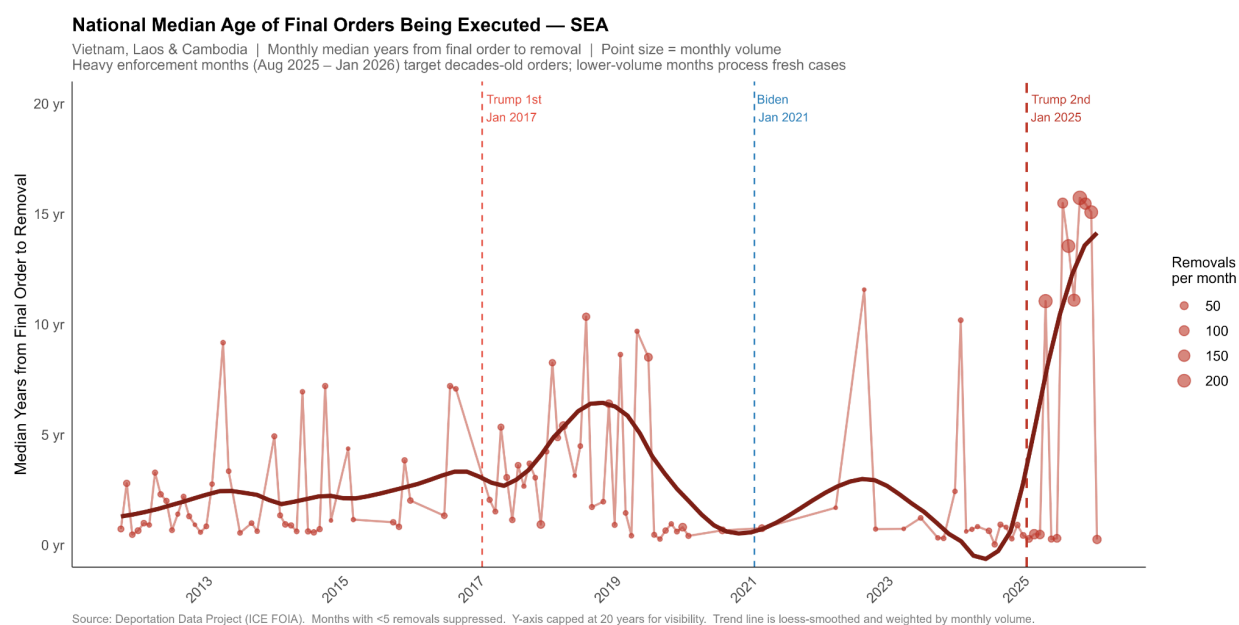
The SEA inversion is not a general phenomenon but a highly selective one. Plot 21 extends this analysis to the top 10 nationalities and reveals that the SEA pattern is shared by only two other groups. For most nationalities, ICE/EOIR ratios actually declined under Trump II even as raw enforcement volumes increased. Honduras fell from 0.97 under Trump I to 0.55 under Trump II; Guatemala from 1.26 to 0.77; El Salvador from 0.92 to 0.60; Colombia from 2.10 to 0.46; Brazil

⁹⁸ See Appendix; Table B7 for underlying data.

⁹⁹ See Appendix; Table B7 for underlying data.

from 1.23 to 0.60; Ecuador from 0.89 to 0.46; and Venezuela from 0.53 to 0.46. Mexico is the consistent outlier in the opposite direction: ICE has exceeded EOIR removals by nearly a factor of 6 under Obama, and has declined steadily to 1.34 under Trump II. This is largely explained by Mexican removals being largely processed through expedited removal authority that bypasses formal immigration court proceedings entirely.¹⁰⁰ Cuba's ratio shifted from 0.07 under Obama and 0.45 under Biden to 1.09 under Trump II.¹⁰¹

An ICE/EOIR ratio above parity has two possible sources, and the data lets us distinguish between them. Either ICE is using expedited removal pathways that bypass court proceedings entirely, denying residents due process rights, which could explain the "No Criminal Charge" surge discussed in Section 4.3.2. A second explanation is that ICE is not waiting for new court proceedings; it is reaching back into a stockpile of old, previously unexecuted final orders accumulated over the years when prosecutorial discretion and diplomatic barriers kept enforcement dormant. This pattern is evident when scrutinizing the issue date of the final orders.



Under Trump II, ICE is executing removal orders against SEA nationals that are, on average, more than a decade old. The combined median age of SEA orders executed during Trump II is

¹⁰⁰ Bush-Joseph, K., & Chishti, M. (2025, October 22). *Trump Administration's Expansion of Fast-Track Deportation Powers Is Transforming Immigration Enforcement*. Migration Policy Institute.
<https://www.migrationpolicy.org/article/trump-expedited-removal>

¹⁰¹ See Appendix; Table B7 for underlying data and Figure C9 for Graph.

11.3 years, roughly fifteen times the Biden-era median of 0.7 years, and 41 percent of these removals enforce orders that are at least fifteen years old, compared to 18 percent under Biden, 13 percent under Trump I, and just 5 percent under Obama.¹⁰²

The pattern is most extreme for Laotian nationals, whose median executed order is 18 years old, with 62 percent of removals executed against orders fifteen years old or older. Cambodian nationals show a similar profile: a median of 16.8 years and 57 percent of orders in the 15+ year bucket. Vietnam's median appears lower (0.56 years), but this masks the distribution: 32 percent of Vietnamese removals are still being executed against orders at least 15 years old, 40 percent against orders at least 10 years old, while the rest are recent cases. The volume context matters too: SEA removals jumped from 215 under Biden to 1,607 under Trump II (a 7.5x increase), and that surge was overwhelmingly composed of decades-old orders rather than fresh cases. This ties in with the Section 2.4 discussion of legal and diplomatic restrictions that were previously preventing deportations, which the current administration has actively eroded through the 2025 sanctions on Cambodia¹⁰³, the June 2025 travel ban on Laos¹⁰⁴, and the documented coercion of Vietnam to accept pre-1995 arrivals previously protected under the 2008 MOU.¹⁰⁵

Looking at the age of final orders for other nationalities solidifies how distinctive this pattern is to SEA nationals. The "All Other Nationalities" category has a median order age of 0.19 years, with only 4 percent of removals enforcing orders fifteen years or older, essentially unchanged across all four administrations (Obama: 3 percent, Trump I: 4 percent, Biden: 5 percent). Mexico, Guatemala, Colombia, Ecuador, Venezuela, and Brazil all show Trump II median order ages of less than four months, and in Venezuela's case, only 0.2 percent of removals are against orders fifteen years or older. Where some old-order targeting does appear outside SEA, it is modest in comparison: El Salvador's share of 15+ year-old orders rose from 4 percent under Biden to 13 percent under Trump II; Cuba's from 5 percent to 13 percent; and Honduras's from 4

¹⁰² See Appendix; Table B13 for underlying data.

¹⁰³ American Immigration Council, "Trump Administration Issues New Visa Sanctions on Four Countries, in Retaliation for Their Stance on Deportation," 2025, <https://www.americanimmigrationcouncil.org/blog/trump-visa-sanctions-deportation/>.

¹⁰⁴ American Immigration Council, *Trump's 2025 Travel Ban: Who Is Affected and What It Could Cost the U.S. Economy* (Washington, DC: American Immigration Council, 2025), <https://www.americanimmigrationcouncil.org/report/trump-2025-travel-ban/>; Proclamation No. 10949, *Restricting the Entry of Foreign Nationals to Protect the United States From Foreign Terrorists and Other National Security and Public Safety Threats*, 90 Fed. Reg. (June 4, 2025).

¹⁰⁵ See Appendix; Table B13 for underlying data; On Vietnam MOU, Asian Law Caucus, "Resources on Deportation of Vietnamese Immigrants Who Entered the U.S. Before 1995," accessed May 10, 2026, <https://www.asianlawcaucus.org/news-resources/guides-reports/trinh-reports>.

percent to 8 percent. These shifts are real but remain a fraction of the SEA pattern, where a majority of executed orders predate the second Bush administration. The contrast clarifies what is distinctive about SEA enforcement under Trump II: most national removal pipelines are flowing forward in time, processing recent orders against recent migrants, while the SEA pipeline is flowing backward, searching the archive for orders issued against people who have been living in the United States, in many cases, since the 1990s.¹⁰⁶

A separate but equally striking pattern under Trump II is the rate of increase in EOIR court order issuance. This is equally affecting all nationalities. Across virtually every top-10 nationality, EOIR's monthly removal-order pace accelerated dramatically from Biden levels: Venezuela's monthly average rose from 641 to 4,269 (a 6.7x increase), Cuba's from 146 to 702 (4.8x), SEA's from 19 to 83 (4.4x), Mexico's from 2,384 to 9,790 (4.1x), Colombia's from 831 to 2,835 (3.4x), and Ecuador's from 788 to 2,394 (3.0x). Nicaragua, Honduras, Guatemala, El Salvador, and Brazil each saw their EOIR monthly rates roughly double. Combined across the top 10, SEA, and all other nationalities, total EOIR order issuance rose from approximately 15,600 orders per month under Biden to roughly 45,000 orders per month under Trump II, a 2.9x increase. This surge reflects an across-the-board acceleration of immigration-court throughput under Trump II, faster dockets, narrower grounds for relief, and more in absentia orders, which have produced final removal orders at a pace unprecedented in the available data.¹⁰⁷

¹⁰⁶ See Appendix; Table B13 for underlying data and Figure C10 for Graph.

¹⁰⁷ See Appendix; Table B7 for underlying data; On acceleration mechanics, Greg Chen and Vanessa Dojaquez-Torres, *Critical Threats Endanger Due Process in Immigration Courts*, Policy Brief (Washington, DC: American Immigration Lawyers Association, October 16, 2025), <https://assets.aila.org/files/81ddf2bd-ef3b-41fd-a394-1dfd8dc136f9/25101602.pdf>.

4.2 Regression Analysis



A Poisson regression with nationality-by-administration interaction terms estimates the incidence rate ratio (IRR) of removals under Trump II relative to the Biden baseline, holding Mexico as the reference category.¹⁰⁸ The results in Table B12 reveal a sharply tiered enforcement landscape. Cuban nationals face removal at 24.37 times the Biden-era rate (95 percent CI: 23.44–25.35), and Venezuelans at 22.19 times the rate (95 percent CI: 21.67–22.72), both of which are among the largest multipliers observed in the data. SEA nationals from Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia follow at 17.28 times the Biden-era rate (95 percent CI: 15.92–18.77), placing the SEA category third among all national-origin groups in terms of the magnitude of the removal-rate increase. By comparison, the four Northern Triangle and Mexican nationalities that historically dominate U.S. enforcement statistics, Honduras, Guatemala, Mexico, and El Salvador, show multipliers between 0.95 and 1.52, indicating that their removal rates have remained largely stable or risen only modestly relative to Biden-era levels. All coefficients are significant at $p < 0.001$.¹⁰⁹

The magnitude of the SEA multiplier is particularly notable given the population's relative size. Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia account for a small share of the overall U.S. noncitizen population

¹⁰⁸ Regression with categorical predictors requires one category to be omitted as a reference, against which the others are compared. More details and the decision to use Mexico as the reference is outlined in Appendix A2.

¹⁰⁹ See Appendix; Table B12 for underlying data.

and an even smaller share of total removals in absolute terms; the population of removable SEA nationals is dwarfed by the populations of Mexican, Central American, and other Latin American nationals. A 17-fold increase in the removal rate relative to this comparatively small base does not yield headline-grabbing absolute numbers, but it does signal a dramatic intensification of enforcement against a specific population. The confidence interval (15.92–18.77) is the widest among the top three groups, reflecting the smaller sample size, but the lower bound alone, nearly sixteen times the Biden-era rate, places SEA enforcement intensification on par with the Cuban and Venezuelan multipliers and well above the multipliers observed for any other group in the analysis.¹¹⁰

These findings have important implications for how Trump II enforcement is understood and discussed publicly. The administration's enforcement narrative has centered on Cuban, Venezuelan, and Central American nationals, with relatively little public attention to SEA removals. The regression results suggest that this rhetorical framing obscures the actual structure of enforcement: SEA nationals are among the most disproportionately targeted groups in the data, even when they are largely absent from administrative messaging and mainstream press coverage.

4.3 Enforcement Profile: Who Is Being Removed

Geographic disaggregation below the national level is limited by the data constraints documented in Section 3.4.1; the state and AOR fields in the removals data are absent for 2011-2021. State-level analysis of who is being deported is therefore not possible without introducing severe selection bias. This section analyzes the full national cohort of SEA removals across all available years. The California-specific analyses in Section 4.1 tracked closely with the national patterns at every stage; the findings that follow can therefore reasonably be read as applying to the California cohort as well, even where direct disaggregation is not possible.

¹¹⁰ See Appendix; Table B12 for underlying data.

4.3.1 Age at Removal

The age composition of SEA removals reveals a consistent trend across administrations toward older deportees, reaching its most extreme under Trump II, and the pattern carries profound implications for understanding who is actually being removed.

Under Obama, the median age at removal was 37 years, with 34 percent of removals in the 25-34 age group and 35 percent in the 35-44 age group. The distribution was relatively concentrated in working-age adults, with only 8 percent under 25 and just 8 percent over 55. During Trump I, the median rose to 40, with the 35-44 group becoming the dominant cohort (40.5 percent) and the over-40 share growing from 42 percent to 53 percent. Under Biden, the median held at 41 with a broadly similar distribution, though the over-50 share grew to 26 percent.¹¹¹

Trump II represents a dramatic shift. The median age jumped to 46, nine years older than under Obama, with 65 percent of removals involving individuals aged 40 or above and 39 percent aged 50 or above. The 45-54 age group became the largest cohort, accounting for 35 percent of all removals, compared with just 16 percent under Obama. The 55-64 group more than doubled in share from 7 percent under Obama to 16 percent under Trump II. Even the 65+ group, while small at 4 percent, represents 72 elderly individuals removed in just 13 months.¹¹²

The age data tells a specific demographic story about SEA refugees. A person aged 46 in 2025 was born in approximately 1979. They would have fled Vietnam, Laos, or Cambodia as a child or young person in the early to mid-1980s, arrived in the US as a refugee, and spent 40 or more years building a life in America. A person who was removed in 2025 at age 55 was born around 1970. They arrived as a child refugee and have lived in the United States for virtually their entire conscious life. The 38 percent of Trump II removals involved people over 50, and the 20 percent involving people over 55, are not people with recent ties to Southeast Asia; they are people whose entire adult lives, families, careers, and communities are in the United States, being deported to countries many of them have not seen since childhood.

¹¹¹ See Appendix; Table B11 for underlying data and Figure C11 for Graph.

¹¹² See Appendix; Table B11 for underlying data and Figure C11 for Graph.

4.3.2 Criminal Charge Profile

The year-on-year charge category analysis reveals two simultaneous and seemingly contradictory trends under Trump II: a massive surge in removals of people with no criminal record, and an equally large surge in removals of people with serious criminal convictions. Both trends are real, and understanding them together is essential to evaluating the administration's public safety justification.

The single largest driver of the 2024 to 2025 surge is the "No Criminal Charge (Immigration Violator)"¹¹³ category, people removed with no criminal history whatsoever. This category grew from 72 removals in 2024 to 564 in 2025, an increase of 492 removals, or 683 percent. Given the current structure of the data, it is hard to determine the exact basis for the removal of this group. However, ICE's own definition of the immigration violator is "individuals without any known criminal convictions or pending charges in ICE's system of record at the time of the enforcement action."¹¹⁴ Further research is needed to categorize what these violations constitute; however, this lack of clarity does not undermine the underlying argument, a substantial share of those removed under Trump II had no criminal convictions or pending charges, directly contradicting the admin's narrative. This mass enforcement is not targeting the 'worst of the worst'; rather, it is a wholesale acceleration across all categories. This is further evident by the shift in other categories. The violent crime category produced the second-largest absolute increase, rising from 28 removals in 2024 to 436 in 2025, an increase of 408 removals (1,457 percent). Property and financial crime grew from 8 to 239 (2,888 percent), drug offenses from 3 to 87 (2,800 percent), and sex offenses from 5 to 84 (1,580 percent). Every single charge category increased dramatically in 2025. Only 20 records have missing data.¹¹⁵

The increase in enforcement against those without criminal charges represents a clear departure from ICE's stated enforcement focus. However, it is just one side of the story. Removal of those with convictions or pending charges has at least a surface-level public-safety rationale, but the picture for SEA complicates even that defense. The following sections further disaggregate the

¹¹³ The classification was cross-validated against three independent ICE fields to confirm these records represent people with no criminal history rather than missing-data artifacts. See Appendix A4 for the full validation procedure and results.

¹¹⁴ U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement, "ICE Enforcement and Removal Operations Statistics," accessed May 9, 2026, <https://www.ice.gov/statistics/characterization>

¹¹⁵ See Appendix; Table B8 for underlying data and Figure C12 for Graph.

nature of these criminal convictions and evaluate whether the public-safety justification holds for those removed with criminal histories.

4.3.3 Enforcement Classifications

This section evaluates the agency's internal classifications of known terrorists, suspected gang members, and aggravated felons, comparing SEA nationals with all other nationalities from 2023 onwards, the only period for which these variables are available. The findings partially contradict the administration's public justification for the enforcement surge.

Firstly, the known terrorist flag. Zero SEA nationals have been flagged as known terrorists in any year across the entire dataset, not in 2023, not in 2024, not across the 1,506 removals executed in 2025. This is not a rounding artifact; it is a literal zero. By contrast, other nationalities had 691 known terrorist flags in 2023 (0.34 percent), 821 in 2024 (0.23 percent), and 1,332 in 2025 (0.34 percent). The administration's characterization of deportees as including terrorists simply does not apply to the SEA population by its own records.¹¹⁶

When looking at the suspected gang member flag, SEA nationals show consistently higher rates of suspected gang membership than all other nationalities: 3.6 percent in 2023, 4.2 percent in 2024, and 5.6 percent in 2025, compared to 1.9 percent, 1.1 percent, and 1.6 percent, respectively, for all other nationalities. This is one enforcement flag where SEA nationals exceed the general population, and it warrants careful interpretation. Firstly, the word "suspected" should be treated with caution; this is ICE's internal classification, not a criminal conviction, and does not require proof of gang membership. Additionally, although these rates are elevated relative to other nationality groups, the share of suspected SEA gang members who have been removed remains low. In absolute terms, 85 of 1,506 SEA removals in 2025 (5.64 percent) were flagged as suspected gang members, meaning 1,421 of 1,506 SEA removals (94.4 percent) had no gang flag. Crucially, the gang flag rate rose from 3.57 percent to 5.64 percent as total removals grew from 56 to 1,506, meaning the absolute number of non-gang SEA removals grew from 54 to 1,421.¹¹⁷

¹¹⁶ See Appendix; Table B9 for underlying data and Figure C13 for Graph.

¹¹⁷ See Appendix; Table B9 for underlying data.

Finally, the aggravated felon classification warrants particular attention here, as the previously discussed expansion of this category has been increasingly used by Trump II as a basis for removal. Among the top-10 deported nationalities, only two groups show meaningfully rising aggravated-felony rates under Trump II: SEA and Cuba, and SEA's shift is by far the more extreme of the two. Pre-Trump II, 10.3 percent of recorded SEA removals carried an aggravated-felony classification, a baseline more than three times as high as the next-highest top-10 nationality (Mexico, at 3.2 percent in the same period). Under Trump II, the SEA rate jumped to 30.7 percent. Cuba moves in the same direction but at lower magnitudes, rising from 1.8 percent pre-Trump II to 7.4 percent under Trump II. Every other top-10 nationality is either essentially flat or moving in the opposite direction: Mexico fell from 3.2 to 1.8 percent, Nicaragua from 0.5 to 0.2 percent, and Colombia, Honduras, El Salvador, Ecuador, Venezuela, Guatemala, and Brazil all sit below 1.3 percent in both periods, with shifts of fractions of a percentage point in either direction. The aggregate aggravated-felony share across the top 10 plus all others fell from 4.4 percent pre-Trump II to 2.5 percent under Trump II, driven by Trump II's targeting of very large numbers of routine immigration violators with no criminal record. SEA and, to a lesser extent, Cuba are discrete outliers within an enforcement system that, on aggregate, is moving in the opposite direction.¹¹⁸

Comparing aggravated-felon rates across nationalities should be done with caution. The field is missing for a substantial share of records, and at very different rates across nationalities. Roughly 34 percent of SEA records are unpopulated in both periods, the lowest rate of any group in the table, and stable across the pre-Trump II/Trump II transition. For most other top-10 nationalities, the field is unpopulated at much higher rates: 70 to 93 percent pre-Trump II for Honduras, El Salvador, Guatemala, Venezuela, Brazil, Nicaragua, Colombia, and Ecuador, and 45 percent for Mexico. SEA records, in other words, are by some distance the most completely classified, meaning SEA's reported aggravated-felony rate is computed on the most representative subset in the table. Therefore, it is hard to say with conviction that removal rates for aggravated felons are meaningfully higher for SEAs.¹¹⁹

¹¹⁸ See Appendix; Table B10 for underlying data and Figure C14 for Graph.

¹¹⁹ See Appendix; Table B10 for underlying data and Figure C14 for Graph.

What can be meaningfully evaluated is the SEA aggravated-felon subset itself, and the story it tells about the profile of those being deported.

To more meaningfully evaluate crime as a basis for removal, the analysis below will expand beyond the aggravated-felon designation to the underlying charge categories themselves. Every charge category in the SEA cohort contains both aggravated-felon and non-aggravated-felon records, meaning the aggravated-felon flag alone is insufficient. The more informative cut is by charge category itself. The starting point is the set of categories within the aggravated-felon subset, in which the legal threshold for "serious" has already been met. Four categories dominate: violent crime (43.2 percent), property crime (16.8 percent), sex offense (15.3 percent), and drug offense (10.9 percent), together accounting for 86.2 percent of all SEA AF records. The sections that follow examine each of these four categories.¹²⁰

4.3.4 Age of Convictions

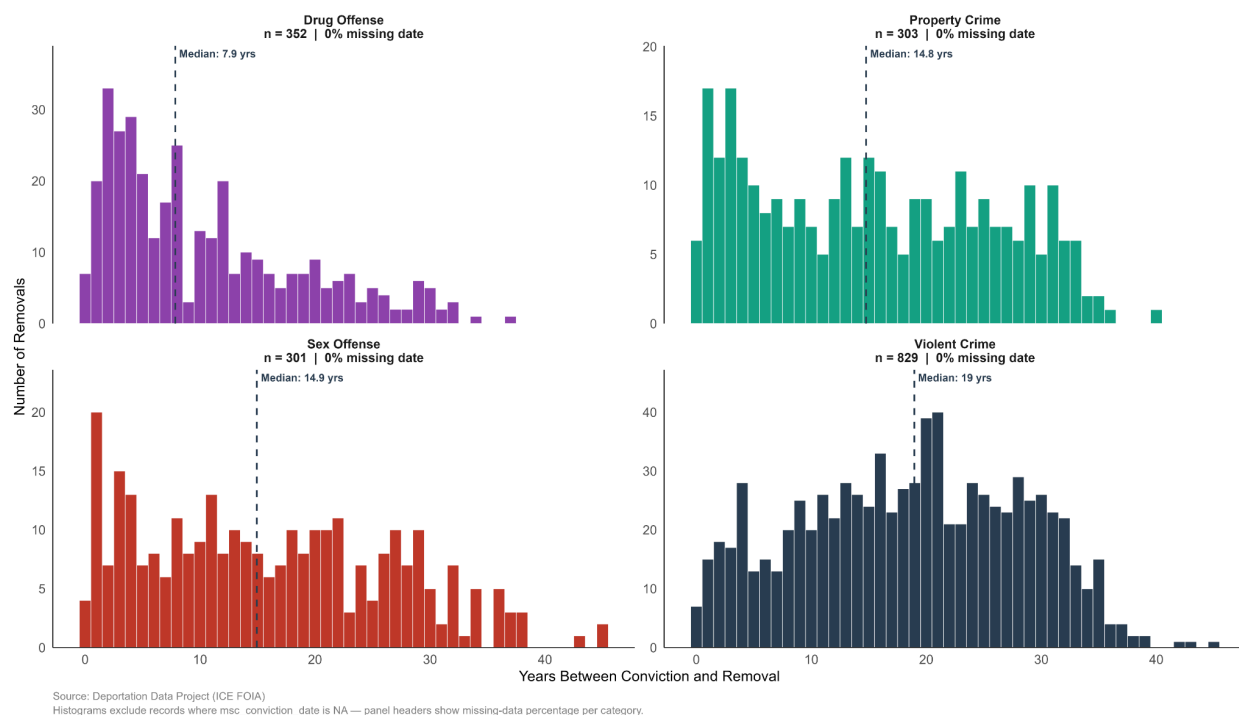
One way to interpret the age of these convictions is by comparing them to the typical sentence imposed for each category. According to the Bureau of Justice Statistics, average sentence lengths for state prison releases in 2018 were roughly 10 years for violent crime and sex offenses, and 5 years for drug offenses and property crime.¹²¹ Taking the averages as a working baseline, and treating the full maximum sentence as if it were served in its entirety, when in practice prisoners serve roughly 44 percent of their sentences before initial release, the math is straightforward. At a conviction age of 10 years or more for violent crimes and sex offenses, and 5 years or more for property and drug sentences, the average sentence for even the most serious categories has been fully completed. Conviction ages going above these baselines would mean the individual has had a chance to rehabilitate. The question then becomes how long the person has been free since release. If, in most cases, it is long enough to have rebuilt a life on the outside, then the bases of their removal can be questioned.

¹²⁰ See Appendix; Table B18 for underlying data and Figure C15 for Graph.

¹²¹ U.S. Department of Justice, Bureau of Justice Statistics. (2021). *Time Served in State Prison, 2018*. NCJ 255662. <https://bjs.ojp.gov/document/tssp18.pdf>

Charge Age at Time of Removal — SEA Serious-Charge Removals by Category

Vietnam, Laos & Cambodia | Each panel shows years between conviction and removal for that category



The age of SEA serious-charge convictions varies sharply by offense type, and violent crime is both the largest category and the oldest. Of the 1,785 SEA serious-charge removals, 829 (46 percent) carry violent-crime convictions, with a median conviction age of 19 years at removal and a median conviction year of 2002; a quarter of these cases rest on convictions from 1996 or earlier. Nearly half (46.3 percent) are more than twenty years old, and 22.2 percent predate the 1996 AEDPA and IIRIRA reforms entirely. The mean conviction age (18.5 years) sits just below the median (19.0), so the distribution is essentially symmetric; these are not a handful of outliers pulling an average up, but a population centrally concentrated around two-decade-old convictions.¹²²

Sex offenses (n=301) and property crimes (n=303) form a near-identical middle tier: median conviction ages of 14.9 and 14.8 years respectively, roughly 36 percent of convictions over twenty years old, and 12–13 percent pre-1996. Drug offenses (n=352) are the only recent category, with a median conviction age of 7.9 years, with only 15.9 percent over twenty years old

¹²² See Appendix; Table B17 for underlying data.

and 4.3 percent pre-1996. The mean for drug offenses (10.4) sits meaningfully above the median (7.9), indicating a right-skewed distribution.¹²³

Applying the aforementioned baseline to these categories. Even on the conservative assumption that every individual served their full statutory sentence, the median SEA serious-charge removal has been free for roughly 9 years in the violent-crime category, 5 years for sex offenses, 10 years for property crime, and nearly 3 years for drug offenses. Using the more realistic 44-percent-served figure, those gaps widen to roughly 14.6, 10.5, 12.6, and 5.7 years, respectively. The pre-1996 share of violent convictions, 22.2 percent of that category, with convictions roughly thirty years old, is the upper limit case: under the conservative reading, the median individual in that subset has been out in the community for two decades. Across every category, then, the typical SEA serious-charge removal is being carried out against someone who has not only served the sentence the court imposed but has also spent years, in many cases decades, building a post-release life.

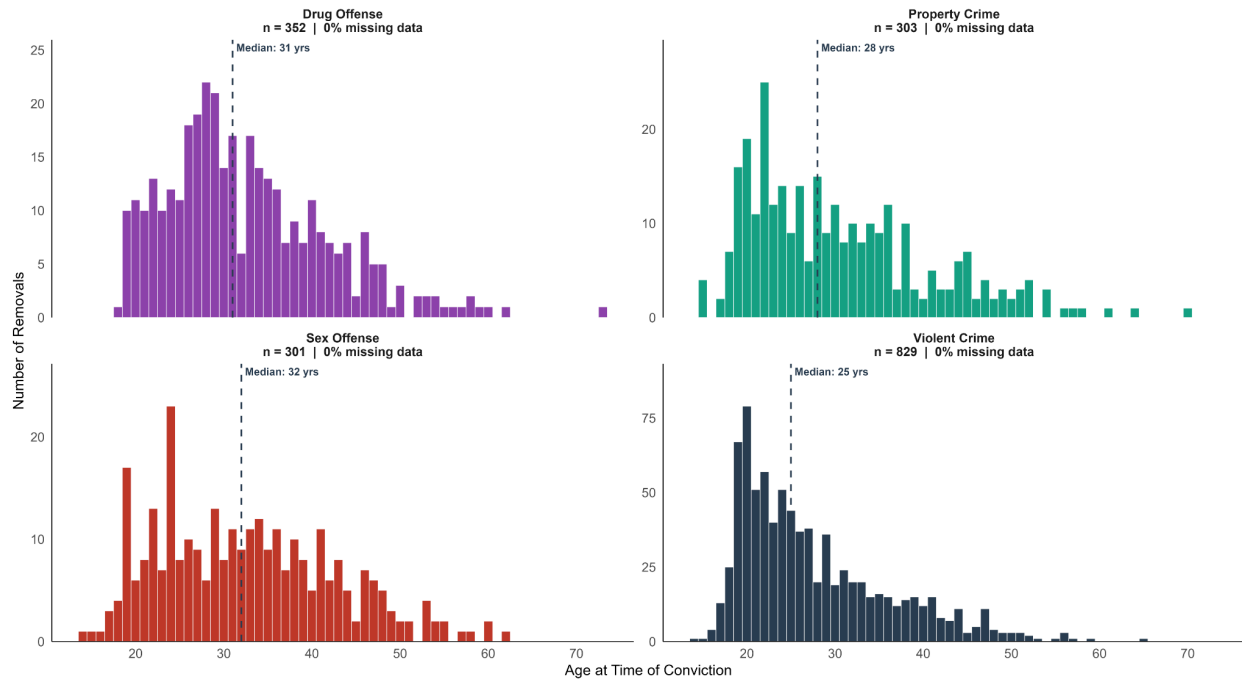
A second moral question follows: how old were these individuals when they were convicted? Anecdotal evidence and community accounts suggest most were young at the time of their offense, and many were tried as adults despite being teenagers. Both directly impacted individuals interviewed for this project confirmed the pattern. Each described his first encounter with the criminal-legal system as occurring during his teenage years, in circumstances closely tied to the neighborhood and school environments documented in Section 2, bullying, racial violence, peer-group exposure, and the absence of mentorship or institutional support.¹²⁴ If this is the case for most, it raises another ground for reconsideration of these removals. Does an offense committed at a young age, under difficult circumstances, served in full and never repeated, constitute a valid basis for removal? And to return to the research question: Does this enforcement actually capture the "worst of the worst" that the administration claims to target?

¹²³ See Appendix; Table B17 for underlying data.

¹²⁴ Author interview with Impacted Individual, April 2026.

Age at Time of Charge — SEA Serious-Charge Removals by Category

Vietnam, Laos & Cambodia | Each panel shows the age distribution at conviction for that category



Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA)
Age computed as conviction year minus birth year. Histograms exclude records with NA conviction date or birth year — panel headers show missing-data percentage per category.

The anecdotal account finds empirical support here. This population was indeed young at the time of conviction. Violent crime defendants stand out with a median age of 25 at conviction, nearly half (46.9 percent) under 25, two-thirds under 30, with the youngest offenders just 14 years old. Property crime shows a similar pattern, with a median of 28 and 54 percent under 30. Drug offenses and sex offenses have slightly older medians (31 and 32), but still include substantial youth representation: 45 percent and 43 percent under 30, respectively, with teenagers present in both categories. Across all four categories, conviction in the teenage years or early twenties was the norm, not the exception. The overall pattern reflects not a population of hardened career criminals convicted in adulthood, but people who encountered the criminal justice system as teenagers and young adults, often under the structural trauma and displacement of refugee resettlement. That context reshapes the question posed in the prior section: if these offenses were committed at 14, 20, 25, or 28, were served in full, and have never been repeated over the decades since, does this population truly fit the "worst of the worst" designation the administration invokes to justify their removal?¹²⁵

¹²⁵ See Appendix; Table B19 for underlying data.

Section 5: Discussion

5.1 A Disproportionate Burden

The findings presented in Section 4 elucidate the complexities around immigration enforcement trends. While it feels instinctive to compare trends across nationalities, each group has its own history, profile, and structural relationship with the enforcement system, and direct comparison risks flattening differences that matter. The analysis in the previous section tells a clear, distinct story about the SEA community's interaction with immigration enforcement. Structural mechanisms that have long existed are now being activated, producing a disproportionate enforcement burden on this community even in the absence of explicit targeting.

Taken together, the increases in detention volume and detention length, the increase in the age of deportation orders, the inversion of the ICE-to-EOIR ratio, the rise in aggravated-felony classification rates, and the increase in the age of the removed population make clear that this community's experience of the current enforcement environment warrants serious attention. The proportional shifts in SEA outcomes are larger than those for any other group with a meaningful detention population. These signals converge across multiple datasets and metrics, and while they do not establish an intentional campaign, they do indicate that the long-settled Southeast Asian refugee population is being affected by the current enforcement environment at a scale and intensity that is unprecedented.

The profile of who is being removed under this enforcement environment is not monolithic. The data reveal two distinct populations within the SEA deportation cohort: those removed with no criminal record of any kind, and those removed on the basis of a prior conviction. Each raises a different set of questions, and each warrants treatment on its own terms.

The first group is substantial. Of the 1,506 SEA nationals removed in 2025, 586 (38.9 percent) had no criminal charge of any kind. The human consequences of these removals are severe, given the lives being disrupted. A person removed in 2025 with no criminal record is, in the SEA case, statistically likely to have spent thirty or more years in the United States, raised U.S.-citizen children, contributed to the workforce, paid taxes, and built the kind of community ties that displacement once severed. The downstream effects fall hardest on the families left

behind. One advocate described the family-level pattern in concrete terms: "When someone is deported, partners become single-parents (and have to play the role of father and mother); children lose their father/mother." The same advocate shared the words of a child whose father had been deported: "I know my father is still alive, but the level of grief from him being deported feels like he has died."¹²⁶

Beyond the family rupture, the deportation transfers an entire built life to a country the deportee may not remember, in some cases, to a regime their family explicitly fled. The principle of non-refoulement, examined further in Section 5.5, carries particular weight here: refugees being returned to the conditions their refugee status was meant to protect them from, without even the surface-level rationale that a criminal conviction might provide. Advocate accounts also describe pre-removal harms compounding the picture: community members with deportation orders are already seeing "their work authorizations are not being approved and thus being let go by their employers," resulting in financial collapse in households where the deportation itself has not yet been executed.¹²⁷ If the case for deporting long-resident SEA individuals with old convictions is morally fraught, as Section 5.3 develops, the case for deporting this group, long-resident SEA individuals with no convictions at all, is harder still to defend on any coherent rationale the administration has offered.

5.2 The Conditions of Conviction

The second group, those removed on the basis of a prior conviction, also looks little like the "worst of the worst" framing the administration has invoked.

Before considering deportation itself, the conditions under which the underlying convictions were produced merit examination. Many of those now facing removal had, at the time of conviction, very little proper legal representation, limited information about the legal implications of their pleas, and a limited understanding of the long-term immigration consequences attached to a criminal plea. Interviews with directly impacted individuals corroborate this gap concretely. Both described having no understanding, at the time of their actions or convictions, of what either would mean for their futures. As one put it plainly:

¹²⁶ Author interview with Advocate, April 2026.

¹²⁷ Author interview with Advocate, April 2026.

"Nobody told me anything would happen to my citizenship."¹²⁸ Many were coerced into accepting plea bargains and harsher charges than the underlying conduct warranted. The category of offense recorded against an SEA name in ICE's databases is, in many cases, several steps removed from what the person actually did. This matters for how the criminal profile of those being removed should be read: the "aggravated felony" flag records what a plea agreement says the offense was, not necessarily what the conduct was. Advocates corroborated that this representation gap is not a historical artifact; one organizational respondent described an ongoing shortage of "pro-bono or low-bono attorneys that understand this work at the intersection of criminal justice and immigrant rights (crimmigration)," meaning the inadequate counsel that shaped the original pleas continues to shape what relief is realistically accessible to those facing removal today.¹²⁹

The age-at-conviction data presented in Section 4.3.3 further strengthens this argument. The median violent-crime defendant was 25 at the time of conviction, with nearly half under 25 and two-thirds under 30. Property crime defendants had a median age of 28. Drug and sex offenses had medians in the early thirties but still included substantial youth representation. Across all four categories, conviction in the teenage years or early twenties was the norm, not the exception. The community accounts referenced in Section 4 corroborate that many were tried as adults despite being teenagers. The picture this paints is not one of hardened career criminals convicted in adulthood but of people who encountered the criminal legal system as teenagers and young adults, often without adequate representation, often pleading to charges that overstated their conduct, and often under the structural trauma of refugee resettlement that Section 2 documents.

The broader question this raises is whether this population fits the "worst of the worst" framing the administration invokes, or whether the criminal records being weaponized today are themselves the product of an environment the U.S. government bears substantial responsibility for creating. Section 2 documents that environment in detail: under-resourced neighborhoods, over-policing, underfunded schools, gang exposure as a defensive response to bullying and racial violence, and the absence of trauma-informed services in resettlement infrastructure that was

¹²⁸ Author interview with Advocate, April 2026.

¹²⁹ Author interview with Advocate, April 2026.

unprepared for the population it received. If criminal records are themselves a product of resettlement conditions the U.S. government produced, the moral case for using those records as a basis for deportation a generation later weakens substantially. The argument is not that SEA individuals deserve no accountability for what they have done; rather, they have served their time, and responsibility, in this case, is distributed, and the U.S. government and American society more broadly bear a share of it that the current enforcement regime refuses to acknowledge. This refusal is, in part, a function of political invisibility: as one advocate observed, "elected officials and people in positions of power [have] little to no knowledge of how Southeast Asians are impacted by the immigration system and its connection to the criminal justice system," a knowledge gap that has insulated the structural conditions of conviction from the policy responses they warrant.¹³⁰

Together, these figures describe an enforcement environment whose impact on this community cannot be explained by the criminal threat profile of the population being removed. The SEA enforcement surge is, by the administration's own data, falling disproportionately on a population that the administration's own systems do not identify as posing a contemporary national-security or violent-crime threat.

5.3 Second Punishment

Highlighted by an interviewee, "Community members are double-punished for their crimes when they are transferred to ICE detention after serving their time in prison," a framing the data in Section 4 makes it empirically difficult to dismiss.¹³¹ A good majority of those being removed today are people whose convictions and removal orders are decades old. They have served their sentences. They have returned to society. They have spent the intervening years building lives, raising families, working, and rebuilding the community ties that displacement once broke. One interviewee described, in concrete terms, what this rebuilding has looked like in his own life: working steadily, paying taxes, paying the recurring fees required to maintain his employment authorization, and structuring his life around the conscious goal of doing everything right so as not to make the same mistakes again.¹³² Deportation now functions, for them, as a second

¹³⁰ Author interview with Advocate, April 2026.

¹³¹ Author interview with Advocate, April 2026.

¹³² Author interview with Advocate, April 2026.

punishment, taken away from the place they have grown up in, taken away from their families, on the basis of a sentence the state has already extracted. The age-at-removal data and the conviction-age data converge here. Even under the conservative assumption that every individual served their full statutory sentence, the median SEA serious-charge removal has been free for three to fifteen years since release, depending on charge category. For the pre-1996 violent-crime subset, the median is over two decades.

The legal question of whether the conviction still makes the person removable is settled; the harder question, given the data, is whether ICE should be exercising its discretion to remove someone this long after the underlying offense. The second-punishment framework must be considered when making decisions on deportation orders, particularly when the underlying convictions are old, often youthful, often the product of plea agreements rather than full adjudication, and unaccompanied by any subsequent criminal record. One advocate respondent named the political dimension of this same pattern, describing "elected officials not having the will to stand up for immigrant communities in general and immigrant communities with a conviction where they have already served their time and transformed themselves for the better", a failure of political will that allows the double-punishment mechanism to operate without meaningful intervention.

5.4 International Law and the Refugee Question

A separate framework that bears on these removals is international law. A substantial share of those being removed are returning to countries where their existence, and in some cases their family histories, would put them at risk. Cambodia, Laos, and Vietnam each retain political conditions in which return is not merely difficult but harmful for portions of the deportee population, particularly those whose family histories are tied to wartime alignment with U.S. forces. The refugee status these individuals or their families were granted when they entered the United States was meant to protect them from precisely this kind of return. As flag-bearers of democracy, and as architects of the postwar international refugee regime, the United States is bound by Article 33 of the 1951 Refugee Convention and its 1967 Protocol to honor the principle of non-refoulement. The current enforcement campaign raises serious questions about whether that obligation is being met.

The further point bears repeating: the creation of the SEA refugee community in the United States is itself a product of U.S. policy. The wars in Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia, the bombing campaigns, the Secret War, and the post-1975 reprisals against U.S. allies all produced the displacement that brought this community here. The United States, in its self-presentation as a proponent of freedom and democracy, owes this population more, not less, than it owes other immigrant communities.

Section 6: Recommendations

The findings of this paper necessitate intervention across three distinct timelines. There is work California can do tomorrow, work that requires an act of Congress, and work that requires a generational shift in how the country thinks about the relationship between criminal records and immigration status. The three are not alternatives. All three need to happen simultaneously.

6.1 What California Can Do Now

There are four state-level reforms to consider.

First, institutionalize a streamlined pardon track for SEA refugees facing removal on decades-old convictions. Governor Newsom has used the state pardon power in individual SEA cases, granting pardons that, under federal immigration law, can eliminate the deportation order for certain categories of offense.¹³³ The precedent exists. What is missing is structure. A community member should not have to win the lottery of media attention to access a remedy that is, at the level of legal mechanism, already available. The Governor's office should establish a publicly known intake track for SEA refugees with served-out convictions facing imminent removal, with clear submission criteria, transparent timelines, and dedicated staff capacity to handle the caseload at the volume required by the current enforcement environment.

Second, expand state funding for vacatur litigation under California Penal Code § 1473.7. Section 1473.7 allows individuals to move to vacate convictions where the plea was entered without a meaningful understanding of its immigration consequences. The mechanism speaks directly to the conditions of conviction documented in Section 5: limited representation, language barriers, plea agreements taken under coercion, and immigration consequences not explained at the time of plea. Each 1473.7 motion costs between \$5,000 and \$15,000 in attorney time alone, plus investigation costs, interpreter fees, transcript fees, and expert declarations. For a population that is overwhelmingly low-income and increasingly held in detention, paying for this representation privately is not an option. The state should fund this work directly: through

¹³³ Author interview with Advocate, April 2026.

grants to the legal services organizations already handling the caseload and a centralized, state-administered representation fund that qualified counsel can draw on for long-term residents facing removal.

Third, close the CalGang loophole in California's sanctuary regime. The TRUST Act, TRUTH Act, and Values Act collectively establish one of the strongest non-cooperation regimes in the country, prohibiting state and local agencies from assisting federal immigration enforcement except in narrowly defined circumstances. CalGang is the loophole that has survived this architecture. The database, operated by the California Department of Justice, catalogs individuals whom local police have identified as suspected gang members or gang associates, frequently without notification, often on the basis of adolescent conduct, and almost never on the basis of a conviction. It has been documented as disproportionately listing Black, Latino, and Southeast Asian youth. ICE queries the database and applies its own "suspected gang member" flag based on those entries, and that flag, as Section 4.3.3 documents, is the only enforcement classification in which SEA nationals exceed the general population. Cutting off the CalGang-to-ICE data flow, by amending the Values Act to fold gang-database sharing into the non-cooperation regime, or through independent CalGang reform that requires conviction, notification, and meaningful audit, disrupts one of the central operational pipelines this paper documents.

Fourth, extend these state remedies to SEA community members who have already been deported. The Governor's pardon power and California Penal Code § 1473.7 vacatur mechanism remain available to individuals after removal, and a successful pardon or vacated conviction creates the legal predicate for a federal motion to reopen the underlying immigration case. California should not treat a completed deportation as the closing of the file. The state should establish a coordinated intake track for SEA community members already deported under the post-1996 framework, facilitating the filing of pardon and 1473.7 applications from abroad, coordinating with overseas counsel when required, and providing the legal infrastructure to convert state-level relief into federal motions to reopen. This effort complements the return provision in the federal SEADRA legislation discussed in Section 6.2: state-level action on the underlying conviction creates the legal basis for a federal return. Without it, those already exiled remain beyond the reach of every other state remedy described above.

6.2 What Congress Should Do: SEADRA

The federal legislation, Southeast Asian Deportation Relief Act (SEADRA), was reintroduced in February 2026 by Representatives Judy Chu, Pramila Jayapal, Zoe Lofgren, and Ayanna Pressley. The bill does three things. It limits DHS's authority to remove Southeast Asian nationals who arrived in the United States by 2008. It permanently authorizes employment eligibility for SEA refugees who have been issued final removal orders but remain in the country, addressing the population currently living in limbo with a final order they cannot lawfully act on. And it creates a process for the estimated two thousand-plus SEA refugees who have already been deported to apply to return.

The 2008 cutoff is not arbitrary. It corresponds to the close of the major SEA refugee resettlement waves documented in Section 2.1 and captures the entire population whose presence in the United States is a direct product of the Indochina conflicts and their aftermath. The employment-eligibility provision recognizes that for a population whose removal orders were issued under diplomatic conditions that made the orders unexecutable for decades, the resulting status, a final order, no path forward, no lawful work, has been a thirty-year-long penalty in its own right. The return provision is the only meaningful remedy for the population whose removal has already been carried out but whose exile can still be ended.

SEADRA's central ask is for the return of people exiled and a moratorium on further exile from a community displaced by the US.

6.3 What Structural reform is needed: The 1996 Laws

The third tier is generational. The reform of the two statutes that built the architecture this paper has documented: AEDPA and IIRIRA, taken together, retroactively expanded the definition of "aggravated felony" to cover offenses that were neither aggravated nor felonies in any conventional sense, eliminated most forms of judicial discretion in removal proceedings, and applied these changes to convictions entered before the statutes existed. They are the legal foundation that makes it possible, in 2025, to deport someone for a 1994 conviction that was not a removable offense at the time of the plea.

Three reforms are necessary. The aggravated-felony definition needs to be narrowed to track the criminal-law sense of the term, thereby restoring the distinction between serious, violent, or large-scale offenses and the misdemeanors and minor felonies that the post-1996 definition now sweeps in. Judicial discretion needs to be restored: immigration judges and the Board of Immigration Appeals should be empowered to weigh contextual factors, length of residence, family ties, rehabilitation, age at conviction, age of the conviction itself, against the removal predicate, rather than being statutorily compelled to order removal whenever the predicate technically applies. And the procedural protections that attach to criminal proceedings should extend, by statute if not by constitutional ruling, to long-term lawful permanent residents facing removal on the basis of old convictions: appointed counsel, meaningful judicial review, and a clear statutory bar on the retroactive application of new removal predicates to convictions entered before those predicates existed.

The state remedies are tractable and could be implemented within the current legislative session. SEADRA has been introduced, reintroduced, and will be reintroduced again until it passes; the path is through committee markup, floor votes, and the kind of coalitional work that produced the Refugee Act of 1980 and the Civil Liberties Act of 1988 in earlier generations. Structural reform of the 1996 laws is slower, harder, and will outlast any single administration. None of these tiers substitutes for the others. The state remedies will not undo three decades of retroactive enforcement; SEADRA will not protect immigrant communities outside the SEA population; structural reform, even if achieved, will not return the people who have already been removed. The three layers are responses to three different time horizons of the same harm. The community this paper has documented is owed all three.

Appendix A — Methodology

A.1 Interview Methodology

This study triangulates its quantitative findings against qualitative interviews with two distinct populations: directly affected individuals (SEA refugees who have had contact with the immigration enforcement system, or family members of those who have) and practitioners and advocates (legal services providers, organizers at SEA-serving organizations, and policy experts working on this issue area). Directly affected individuals were interviewed in semi-structured in-person or video format following the protocol in B.7.1. Practitioners were offered the option of a full interview or, when their schedules did not permit, an abbreviated written response via email following the protocol in B.7.2.

All participants gave verbal or written informed consent prior to participation. Confidentiality is maintained, and no participant is identified by name in this study without their explicit prior permission. Interviewees retained the right to skip questions and to end the conversation at any point.

Semi-Structured Interview for Impacted Individuals

Introduction (read at start of interview):

Thank you so much for taking the time to speak with me. I'm working on a research project focused on Southeast Asian refugees in California who are at risk of deportation. The goal is to better understand what people go through, from initial contact with the system to potential deportation, and where there are gaps in support or policy.

This conversation is confidential. I will not use your name or identifying details unless you explicitly give permission. You can skip any question or stop at any time.

With your permission, I'd like to take notes (and optionally record) so I can accurately capture what you share. Before we begin, do you have any questions for me?

Section A, Background:

1. Can you tell me a little about yourself and your background? When did you come to the U.S., and what was that experience like?
2. What was your life like growing up here?

Section B, First Contact with the System:

1. Can you walk me through the first time you had contact with the criminal or immigration system?
2. What led up to that moment?
3. At that time, did you understand how this could affect your immigration status?

Section C, Arrest, ICE, Detention:

1. What happened after your arrest or conviction in terms of immigration involvement?
2. When did ICE first become involved, if at all?
3. Can you describe what that interaction felt like?
4. Were you detained? If yes:
 - What was detention like?
 - How long were you there?
 - What support (if any) did you have?

Section D, Legal Process:

- What did the legal process look like for you?
- Did you have access to a lawyer? How did that happen?
- What were the hardest parts of navigating the system?
- Were there moments where things could have gone differently?

Section E, Support Systems:

- What kinds of support helped you (legal, family, community, organisations)?
- What support did you wish you had but didn't?
- Did any organisations (like AAPI groups) play a role?

Section F, Impacts:

- How has this experience affected your life (family, work, mental health)?
- How has it shaped your sense of belonging in the U.S.?

Section G, Changes Over Time (Post-Trump):

1. Thinking back over your experience, do you feel things changed at any point — especially in recent years?
2. Did you notice any differences in how immigration enforcement was handled over time?
3. Were there moments when things felt stricter, faster, or more aggressive?
4. Did your sense of risk or fear change over time? When and why?
5. Did access to support (lawyers, organisations, information) change at all?
6. If you had gone through this process at a different time, do you think your outcome might have been different?

Section H, Reflection:

- Looking back, what do you think people misunderstand about deportation cases like yours?
- What would have made the biggest difference in your situation?
- What changes would you want to see in the system?

Debrief (read at close of interview):

Thank you again for sharing your experiences and insights — it's incredibly valuable for this project. Before we wrap up:

- Is there anything important that I didn't ask about that you think I should understand?
- Is there anyone else you recommend I speak with?

If you're comfortable, I may follow up if I have clarification questions later. Thank you again. I really appreciate your time and trust.

Abbreviated Email Interview Protocol for Advocates

The abbreviated email protocol was used when practitioner time constraints made a full interview impractical. The intent was to capture expert framing and field-level observations on the six analytic dimensions most relevant to this study, in a format that respected respondents' workloads.

Email introduction:

My name is Ayesha, and I'm a UC Berkeley (Public Policy) student completing my capstone research project on Southeast Asian refugees in California who are at risk of deportation. I am working with Timmy Lu (AAPI Force) and Nkauj Iab Yang (Sac Defence). My central goal is to quantify the increase in deportations as a result of immigration enforcement by the current administration, and assess how many SEA refugees might be at risk. By SEA, we are particularly referring to Laos, Cambodia, and Vietnam. I want to

encapsulate their entire stories, exploring what people experience from initial contact with the criminal legal system through potential deportation, and where the biggest gaps in policy and support exist.

I'm reaching out because your work and expertise would add tremendous depth to this project, and your perspective is exactly the kind of insight my research is missing.

I know your time is incredibly limited, so rather than asking for an interview, I'd be deeply grateful if you could reply to this email with your thoughts on any or all of the six questions below. Even brief answers — a few sentences per question, or just the ones most relevant to your work — would be enormously helpful. I'm working under a tight deadline and really need experienced voices to ground my analysis.

The six questions:

1. What makes Southeast Asian refugee communities uniquely vulnerable to deportation, and what does current policy fail to account for (e.g., arrival as child refugees, pathways into the criminal legal system, barriers to naturalization)?
2. What are the biggest barriers you face in supporting this community, and what would need to change — whether in the system itself, legal structures, state-level support, or the resources available to organizations like yours — to meaningfully address them?
3. How has the enforcement environment changed from pre-2016 through the Trump administrations to today? Which changes have had the most lasting impact, and which have been rolled back?
4. Where does meaningful discretion exist in the system (ICE, prosecutors, judges, governors), and what relief pathways are realistically accessible versus rarely used? What are the biggest barriers to accessing relief?
5. What happens to the families and communities left behind when someone is deported, particularly U.S. citizen children, spouses, and elderly parents — and how, if at all, does the current system account for those impacts?
6. What policy changes would most meaningfully reduce unjust deportation risk, what's politically feasible in the near term, and what do you think is most misunderstood about deportation policy?

Email closing:

Your responses will remain confidential, and I won't attribute any comments to you by name without your explicit permission. If you'd prefer a brief phone or video call instead, I'm happy to work around your schedule.

If there's someone else on your team or in your network you think I should connect with, I'd also be grateful for the introduction.

Thank you so much for considering this. I know how much is on your plate, and any input you can share would genuinely shape the quality of this project.

A.2 Regression Model

To formally estimate the change in SEA removal volume associated with the second Trump administration, a Poisson regression is fit at the month-by-nationality-group level. The unit of observation is one month for one nationality group; the dependent variable is the count of removals in that group-month.

Specification:

$$Removals_{gt} \sim \text{Poisson}(\mu_{gt}), \quad \log(\mu_{gt}) = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \cdot Group_g + \beta_2 \cdot T1_t + \beta_3 \cdot T2_t + \beta_4 \cdot (Group_g \times T1_t) + \beta_5 \cdot (Group_g \times T2_t)$$

where:

- $Group_g$ is a 12-level categorical with Mexico as the reference. The non-reference levels are the remaining nine of the top-10 nationalities (by 2025 removal volume), an SEA aggregate covering Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia, and an “All Other Nationalities” residual.
- $T1_t = 1$ if month t falls within the first Trump administration (Jan 20, 2017 – Jan 19, 2021), 0 otherwise.
- $T2_t = 1$ if month t falls within the second Trump administration (Jan 20, 2025 onward), 0 otherwise.
- Months in which both $T1_t = 0$ and $T2_t = 0$ form the reference period; this combines the Obama (FY2012 onward) and Biden administrations. Most of the weight in that reference falls on the Biden period, which is why the headline IRR is described in the main text as relative to a Biden baseline.

Choice of distribution. Poisson is appropriate for non-negative integer count data. The dependent variable is the monthly removal count for a given nationality group, which satisfies this support condition.

Choice of reference category. Categorical predictors in a generalized linear model require one level to serve as a reference to avoid perfect multicollinearity in the dummy encoding (if every level had its own indicator, the indicators would sum to one across rows and could not be distinguished from the intercept). Mexico was chosen as the reference because it is by far the largest nationality group in U.S. removal records and the conventional baseline for U.S. immigration enforcement analysis, which allows each remaining group’s IRR to be read as enforcement intensity relative to the dominant enforcement target.

Reported quantity. Coefficients are exponentiated and reported as incidence rate ratios (IRRs) with 95% confidence intervals. For each non-reference nationality group, the reported “Total IRR” under the second Trump administration is computed as $\exp(\beta_3 + \beta_{5,g})$. The multiplicative change in that group’s monthly removal rate moving from the reference period to T2. For SEA, the point estimate is 17.28, with a 95% confidence interval of 15.92–18.77, reported in Appendix Table B12.

Interpretation. An IRR of 17.28 indicates that the SEA monthly removal rate under the second Trump administration is approximately 17 times its pre-T2 rate. This is the headline statistical finding of the regression analysis and corresponds to the phrasing “approximately 17-fold increase” in the main text. The lower bound of the confidence interval (15.92) places SEA enforcement intensification on the same order of magnitude as Cuba (24.37x) and Venezuela (22.19x), the only two groups with larger point estimates, and an order of magnitude above the Mexican and Northern Triangle multipliers (0.95–1.52).

What the regression does not estimate. This is a descriptive regression of the change in observed removal volume. It does not estimate a causal treatment effect of the inauguration. There is no exogenous variation in T2 status, no control for confounding policy changes that occurred concurrently with the administration change (DHS budget reallocations, repatriation-agreement status, immigration-court backlog dynamics, ICE field office reorganizations), and no identification strategy beyond the pre/post comparison. The IRR should be read as a quantification of the magnitude of the observed change, not as a causal claim about which T2 policy lever produced that change. The mechanistic argument linking the change to the AEDPA/IIRIRA framework is made qualitatively in the main report, drawing on the order-age, age-distribution, targeted-arrest, and aggravated-felon-classification evidence in combination.

A.3 ICE Data Cutoff: Verification of the 2022 Cutoff for Detention Analysis

The detention analysis in this thesis is restricted to records dated October 2022 onwards. The Deportation Data Project's ICE detention file nominally contains records dating back to December 2004, but the volume of pre-2022 records is extremely sparse, far below what would be expected given known ICE detention activity in those years. To determine whether this sparseness reflects an actual decline in enforcement or a data-release artifact, the DDP file was cross-referenced against three independent aggregate detention time series.

1. Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse (TRAC). TRAC maintains a long-running time series of ICE detention population data going back to FY2003, sourced through its own FOIA litigation against ICE. The series documents average daily detained populations consistently in the tens of thousands throughout the 2003–2021 period.
2. Vera Institute of Justice. Vera publishes detention trend data based on ICE statistical releases and independent analysis, with coverage confirming steady detention activity at scale across the entire 2003–2021 period.
3. American Immigration Council. The Council's 2017 report, *The Landscape of Immigration Detention in the United States*, documents that ICE's average daily detention population had increased more than fivefold from the early 2000s to FY2015, a baseline that already vastly exceeds what the DDP file records for those years.

All three sources independently document ICE detention activity at scale throughout 2003–2021, averaging between roughly 20,000 and 50,000 individuals detained on any given day and generating hundreds of thousands of bookings per year. The DDP file shows nothing approaching this volume in those years. The most plausible explanation is therefore a FOIA snapshot artifact: ICE's operational system at the time of disclosure contains active and recently-closed records, not the full historical archive of every stay since 2004. The detention analysis in this thesis is therefore restricted to 2022 onwards to ensure findings reflect actual enforcement patterns rather than data-release coverage.

A.4 Cross-Validation of the "No Criminal Charge (Immigration Violator Only)" Classification

The "No Criminal Charge (Immigration Violator Only)" category used in this thesis is derived from the `msc_charge` field in the ICE removals data: records with a blank `msc_charge` are classified into this category. A reader might reasonably ask whether these records actually represent people with no criminal history, or whether the blank charge field simply reflects missing data, that is, people whose criminal history exists but was not entered into ICE's system. To rule out the missing-data interpretation, the classification was cross-validated against three independent ICE fields.

1. `case_criminality`. This is ICE's own categorical classification of each removed individual's criminal history, populated independently of the `msc_charge` field. Of the 809 SEA records categorized as "No Criminal Charge (Immigration Violator Only)" in 2025, 780 (96.4%) map to ICE's classification "3 Other Immigration Violator", its designation for individuals with no criminal history. The remaining 29 records (3.6%) map to "2 Pending Criminal Charges," meaning charges were filed, but no conviction was recorded. No record in this category maps to "1 Convicted Criminal." Under the stricter definition adopted in the final analysis, the 29 pending-charges records are reclassified into a separate "Not Recorded" category, so that the "No Criminal Charge" classification is restricted to records where `case_criminality` independently confirms no criminal history.

2. `known_terrorist_yes_no` and `suspected_gang_yes_no`. These flags reflect the background checks ICE runs on each individual. For all 809 records, both flags are actively coded "NO" with zero missing values, indicating ICE completed the checks and returned negative results, rather than leaving the fields blank, which would be the signature of incomplete data entry.

3. `case_threat_level`. This field is fully populated (100%) across all criminality classifications in the data, convicted criminals, pending charges, and immigration violators alike, ruling out the possibility that records in the no-criminal-charge group reflect a systematic data-entry gap specific to that population.

Three independent ICE fields, each capturing a different aspect of an individual's record, categorical criminality classification, terrorist and gang background checks, and threat-level assessment, converge on the same finding: records categorized as "No Criminal Charge (Immigration Violator Only)" represent individuals with no criminal history. The missing-data interpretation is implausible. These are people ICE itself classified, checked, and recorded as having no criminal record.

Appendix B — Statistical Tables

Table B1. Total ICE Arrests, Removals, and Detentions by World Region

Region	Total Arrests	% of Arrests	Total Removals	% of Removals	Total Detentions	% of Detentions
Mexico	201,872	46%	1,930,469	52.6%	302,319	28.7%
Central America	148,529	33.9%	1,256,668	34.2%	300,281	28.6%
South America	54,295	12.4%	247,680	6.7%	245,873	23.4%
Caribbean	16,091	3.7%	91,777	2.5%	64,893	6.2%
Europe & Central Asia	5,369	1.2%	44,207	1.2%	32,072	3%
South Asia	2,699	0.6%	25,876	0.7%	33,766	3.2%
Sub-Saharan Africa	2,492	0.6%	24,282	0.7%	30,500	2.9%
Other East/Southeast Asia	3,057	0.7%	22,700	0.6%	17,685	1.7%
Middle East & North Africa	1,551	0.4%	17,293	0.5%	17,749	1.7%
Canada	382	0.1%	5,198	0.1%	665	0.1%
Southeast Asia (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	1,348	0.3%	3,252	0.1%	4,781	0.5%
Oceania	668	0.2%	2,859	0.1%	849	0.1%
Other / Not Classified	27	0%	457	0%	315	0%
Total	438,380	100%	3,672,718	100%	1,051,748	100%

Region	Total Arrests	% of Arrests	Total Removals	% of Removals	Total Detentions	% of Detentions
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Note: Arrests data covers Oct 2022 – Mar 2026. Removals data covers FY2012 – Mar 2026. Detentions data covers Jan 2019 – Mar 2026.

Table B2. ICE Arrests, Removals, and Detentions: Pre vs Trump 2nd Term — by World Region

Region	Metric	Pre (n)	Pre (mo. avg)	% of Pre	T2 (n)	T2 (mo. avg)	% of T2	% Change
Mexico	Arrests	83,538	2983.5	50.6%	118,334	9102.6	43.3%	205.1%
Mexico	Removals	1,760,543	11003.4	54.3%	169,926	13071.2	39.2%	18.8%
Mexico	Detentions	144,786	5170.9	22.8%	157,533	12117.9	37.7%	134.3%
Central America	Arrests	53,427	1908.1	32.3%	95,102	7315.5	34.8%	283.4%
Central America	Removals	1,119,501	6996.9	34.6%	137,167	10551.3	31.7%	50.8%
Central America	Detentions	163,556	5841.3	25.8%	136,725	10517.3	32.7%	80.1%
South America	Arrests	15,545	555.2	9.4%	38,750	2980.8	14.2%	436.9%
South America	Removals	175,364	1096	5.4%	72,316	5562.8	16.7%	407.6%
South America	Detentions	180,903	6460.8	28.5%	64,970	4997.7	15.5%	-22.6%
Caribbean	Arrests	6,193	221.2	3.7%	9,898	761.4	3.6%	244.2%
Caribbean	Removals	71,113	444.5	2.2%	20,664	1589.5	4.8%	257.6%
Caribbean	Detentions	42,631	1522.5	6.7%	22,262	1712.5	5.3%	12.5%
Europe & Central Asia	Arrests	2,367	84.5	1.4%	3,002	230.9	1.1%	173.3%

Region	Metric	Pre (n)	Pre (mo. avg)	% of Pre	T2 (n)	T2 (mo. avg)	% of T2	% Change
Europe & Central Asia	Removals	34,991	218.7	1.1%	9,216	708.9	2.1%	224.1%
Europe & Central Asia	Detentions	23,240	830	3.7%	8,832	679.4	2.1%	-18.1%
South Asia	Arrests	682	24.4	0.4%	2,017	155.2	0.7%	536.1%
South Asia	Removals	18,236	114	0.6%	7,640	587.7	1.8%	415.5%
South Asia	Detentions	26,513	946.9	4.2%	7,253	557.9	1.7%	-41.1%
Sub-Saharan Africa	Arrests	1,066	38.1	0.6%	1,426	109.7	0.5%	187.9%
Sub-Saharan Africa	Removals	20,093	125.6	0.6%	4,189	322.2	1%	156.5%
Sub-Saharan Africa	Detentions	23,870	852.5	3.8%	6,630	510	1.6%	-40.2%
Other East/Southeast Asia	Arrests	835	29.8	0.5%	2,222	170.9	0.8%	473.5%
Other East/Southeast Asia	Removals	17,593	110	0.5%	5,107	392.8	1.2%	257.1%
Other East/Southeast Asia	Detentions	11,636	415.6	1.8%	6,049	465.3	1.4%	12%
Middle East & North Africa	Arrests	566	20.2	0.3%	985	75.8	0.4%	275.2%
Middle East & North Africa	Removals	12,862	80.4	0.4%	4,431	340.8	1%	323.9%

Region	Metric	Pre (n)	Pre (mo. avg)	% of Pre	T2 (n)	T2 (mo. avg)	% of T2	% Change
Middle East & North Africa	Detentions	13,567	484.5	2.1%	4,182	321.7	1%	-33.6%
Canada	Arrests	229	8.2	0.1%	153	11.8	0.1%	43.9%
Canada	Removals	4,831	30.2	0.1%	367	28.2	0.1%	-6.6%
Canada	Detentions	349	12.5	0.1%	316	24.3	0.1%	94.4%
Southeast Asia (Vietnam/Laos/ Cambodia)	Arrests	307	11	0.2%	1,041	80.1	0.4%	628.2%
Southeast Asia (Vietnam/Laos/ Cambodia)	Removals	1,474	9.9	0%	1,778	136.8	0.4%	1281.8%
Southeast Asia (Vietnam/Laos/ Cambodia)	Detentions	1,987	71	0.3%	2,794	214.9	0.7%	202.7%
Oceania	Arrests	467	16.7	0.3%	201	15.5	0.1%	-7.2%
Oceania	Removals	2,560	16.4	0.1%	299	23	0.1%	40.2%
Oceania	Detentions	509	18.2	0.1%	340	26.2	0.1%	44%
Other / Not Classified	Arrests	11	1.4	0%	16	1.6	0%	14.3%
Other / Not Classified	Removals	380	3	0%	77	5.9	0%	96.7%
Other / Not Classified	Detentions	159	5.7	0%	156	12	0%	110.5%
TOTAL	Arrests	165,233	—	100%	273,147	—	100%	—

Region	Metric	Pre (n)	Pre (mo. avg)	% of Pre	T2 (n)	T2 (mo. avg)	% of T2	% Change
TOTAL	Removals	3,239,541	—	100%	433,177	—	100%	—
TOTAL	Detentions	633,706	—	100%	418,042	—	100%	—

Note: Pre-arrest period = Oct 2022 – Jan 2025. Pre-removal period = FY2012 – Jan 2025. Pre-detention period = Jan 2019 – Jan 2025. T2 = Jan 2025 – Mar 2026. % of Pre and % of T2 columns show each region's share of all-region total for that metric and period. Final three rows show metric totals.

Table B3. Total ICE Arrests, Removals, and Detentions — Top 10 Nationalities, SEA, and All Others

Nationality	Total Arrests	% of Arrests	Total Removals	% of Removals	Total Detentions	% of Detentions
Mexico	201,872	46%	1,930,469	52.6%	302,319	28.7%
Guatemala	61,704	14.1%	563,181	15.3%	123,686	11.8%
Honduras	52,100	11.9%	405,903	11.1%	103,079	9.8%
All Other Nationalities	33,405	7.6%	264,185	7.2%	212,404	20.2%
El Salvador	20,057	4.6%	233,421	6.4%	41,785	4%
Colombia	12,406	2.8%	74,859	2%	72,848	6.9%
Ecuador	11,153	2.5%	61,570	1.7%	59,184	5.6%
Nicaragua	13,862	3.2%	47,344	1.3%	28,391	2.7%
Venezuela	19,587	4.5%	36,470	1%	64,790	6.2%
Brazil	4,797	1.1%	35,201	1%	13,633	1.3%

Nationality	Total Arrests	% of Arrests	Total Removals	% of Removals	Total Detentions	% of Detentions
Cuba	6,089	1.4%	16,863	0.5%	24,848	2.4%
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	1,348	0.3%	3,252	0.1%	4,781	0.5%
Total	438,380	100%	3,672,718	100%	1,051,748	100%

Note: Top 10 = 10 largest nationalities by 2025 removal volume. SEA shown separately to enable like-for-like comparison with regression results in Table B12.

Table B4. ICE Arrests, Removals, and Detentions: Pre vs Trump 2nd Term — by Nationality

Nationality	Metric	Pre (n)	Pre (mo. avg)	% of Pre	T2 (n)	T2 (mo. avg)	% of T2	% Change
Mexico	Arrests	83,538	2983.5	50.6%	118,334	9102.6	43.3%	205.1%
Mexico	Removals	1,760,543	11003.4	54.3%	169,926	13071.2	39.2%	18.8%
Mexico	Detentions	144,786	5170.9	22.8%	157,533	12117.9	37.7%	134.3%
Guatemala	Arrests	19,098	682.1	11.6%	42,606	3277.4	15.6%	380.5%
Guatemala	Removals	503,742	3148.4	15.5%	59,439	4572.2	13.7%	45.2%
Guatemala	Detentions	62,986	2249.5	9.9%	60,700	4669.2	14.5%	107.6%
Honduras	Arrests	20,266	723.8	12.3%	31,834	2448.8	11.7%	238.3%
Honduras	Removals	361,224	2257.7	11.2%	44,679	3436.8	10.3%	52.2%
Honduras	Detentions	58,342	2083.6	9.2%	44,737	3441.3	10.7%	65.2%

Nationality	Metric	Pre (n)	Pre (mo. avg)	% of Pre	T2 (n)	T2 (mo. avg)	% of T2	% Change
Venezuela	Arrests	3,187	113.8	1.9%	16,400	1261.5	6%	1008.5%
Venezuela	Removals	10,999	69.2	0.3%	25,471	1959.3	5.9%	2731.4%
Venezuela	Detentions	36,963	1320.1	5.8%	27,827	2140.5	6.7%	62.1%
Colombia	Arrests	5,121	182.9	3.1%	7,285	560.4	2.7%	206.4%
Colombia	Removals	57,965	362.3	1.8%	16,894	1299.5	3.9%	258.7%
Colombia	Detentions	60,033	2144	9.5%	12,815	985.8	3.1%	-54%
El Salvador	Arrests	8,155	291.2	4.9%	11,902	915.5	4.4%	214.4%
El Salvador	Removals	216,137	1350.9	6.7%	17,284	1329.5	4%	-1.6%
El Salvador	Detentions	23,634	844.1	3.7%	18,151	1396.2	4.3%	65.4%
Nicaragua	Arrests	5,545	198	3.4%	8,317	639.8	3%	223.1%
Nicaragua	Removals	32,515	203.2	1%	14,829	1140.7	3.4%	461.4%
Nicaragua	Detentions	16,075	574.1	2.5%	12,316	947.4	2.9%	65%
Ecuador	Arrests	3,098	110.6	1.9%	8,055	619.6	2.9%	460.2%
Ecuador	Removals	47,391	296.2	1.5%	14,179	1090.7	3.3%	268.2%
Ecuador	Detentions	46,664	1666.6	7.4%	12,520	963.1	3%	-42.2%
Cuba	Arrests	1,235	44.1	0.7%	4,854	373.4	1.8%	746.7%

Nationality	Metric	Pre (n)	Pre (mo. avg)	% of Pre	T2 (n)	T2 (mo. avg)	% of T2	% Change
Cuba	Removals	6,935	43.9	0.2%	9,928	763.7	2.3%	1639.6%
Cuba	Detentions	13,216	472	2.1%	11,632	894.8	2.8%	89.6%
Brazil	Arrests	1,397	49.9	0.8%	3,400	261.5	1.2%	424%
Brazil	Removals	27,687	173	0.9%	7,514	578	1.7%	234.1%
Brazil	Detentions	8,015	286.2	1.3%	5,618	432.2	1.3%	51%
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/ Cambodia)	Arrests	307	11	0.2%	1,041	80.1	0.4%	628.2%
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/ Cambodia)	Removals	1,474	9.9	0%	1,778	136.8	0.4%	1281.8%
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/ Cambodia)	Detentions	1,987	71	0.3%	2,794	214.9	0.7%	202.7%
All Other Nationalities	Arrests	14,286	510.2	8.6%	19,119	1470.7	7%	188.3%
All Other Nationalities	Removals	212,929	1330.8	6.6%	51,256	3942.8	11.8%	196.3%
All Other Nationalities	Detentions	161,005	5750.2	25.4%	51,399	3953.8	12.3%	-31.2%
TOTAL	Arrests	165,233	—	100%	273,147	—	100%	—
TOTAL	Removals	3,239,541	—	100%	433,177	—	100%	—
TOTAL	Detentions	633,706	—	100%	418,042	—	100%	—

Nationality	Metric	Pre (n)	Pre (mo. avg)	% of Pre	T2 (n)	T2 (mo. avg)	% of T2	% Change
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Note: Pre-arrest period = Oct 2022 – Jan 2025. Pre-removal period = FY2012 – Jan 2025. Pre-detention period = Jan 2019 – Jan 2025. T2 = Jan 2025 – Mar 2026. % of Pre and % of T2 columns show each nationality's share of all-nationality total for that metric and period. Final three rows show metric totals.

Table B5. California's Share of National SEA Enforcement — Arrests, Removals, and Detentions

Metric	Period	California (n)	California (mo. avg)	National (n)	National (mo. avg)	% of National
Arrests	Pre T2	135	4.8	295	10.5	45.8%
Arrests	T2	368	26.3	1,053	75.2	34.9%
Removals	Pre T2	49	0.3	1,474	9.9	3.3%
Removals	T2	484	37.2	1,778	136.8	27.2%
Detentions	Pre T2	490	17.5	1,987	71.0	24.7%
Detentions	T2	500	38.5	2,794	214.9	17.9%

Note: California identified via AOR (Los Angeles, San Francisco, San Diego) for arrests and detentions; via AOR or state field for removals. Monthly averages computed using months-with-data per metric and period. Pre-T2 detention period = Jan 2019 – Jan 2025; pre-T2 arrests = Oct 2022 – Jan 2025; pre-T2 removals = FY2012 – Jan 2025 (note: AOR field unpopulated pre-2023, so pre-T2 California removal share is undercounted).

Table B6. California ICE Arrests, Removals, and Detentions — SEA Nationals by Country and Period

Country	Metric	Pre (n)	Pre (mo. avg)	T2 (n)	T2 (mo. avg)	% Change
Cambodia	Arrests	18	1.5	22	2.8	86.7%
Cambodia	Removals	11	1.8	24	2.7	50%
Cambodia	Detentions	21	1.3	33	2.8	115.4%

Country	Metric	Pre (n)	Pre (mo. avg)	T2 (n)	T2 (mo. avg)	% Change
Laos	Arrests	16	1.1	87	7.9	618.2%
Laos	Removals	5	1.2	94	10.4	766.7%
Laos	Detentions	29	1.7	78	6.0	252.9%
Vietnam	Arrests	101	3.7	259	18.5	400%
Vietnam	Removals	33	1.8	366	28.2	1466.7%
Vietnam	Detentions	440	15.7	389	29.9	90.4%
SEA Total	Arrests	135	4.8	368	26.3	447.9%
SEA Total	Removals	49	2.3	484	37.2	1517.4%
SEA Total	Detentions	490	17.5	500	38.5	120%

Note: California identified via AOR (Los Angeles, San Francisco, San Diego). Pre-arrest = Oct 2022 – Jan 2025. Pre-removal = Jan 2023 – Jan 2025 (AOR field unpopulated pre-2023). Pre-detention = Jan 2019 – Jan 2025. T2 = Jan 2025 – Mar 2026. Monthly averages computed using months-with-data per group, so SEA Total mo. avg may not equal the sum of country mo. avgs. % Change computed from monthly averages.

Table B7. ICE Actual Removals vs EOIR Court Orders — by Nationality and Administration

Nationality	Administration	ICE Removals (n)	ICE Mo. Avg	% of ICE Admin Total	EOIR Orders (n)	EOIR Mo. Avg	% of EOIR Admin Total	ICE/EOIR Ratio
Mexico	Obama	1,044,171	16,315.2	63.3%	177,189	2,768.6	43.9%	5.89
Mexico	Trump 1st	461,845	9,621.8	52.8%	116,726	2,431.8	23.1%	3.96
Mexico	Biden	254,527	5,302.6	35.6%	114,421	2,383.8	15.3%	2.22
Mexico	Trump 2nd	169,926	13,071.2	39.2%	127,275	9,790.4	21.7%	1.34
Guatemala	Obama	223,758	3,496.2	13.6%	56,614	884.6	14%	3.95

Nationality	Administration	ICE Removals (n)	ICE Mo. Avg	% of ICE Admin Total	EOIR Orders (n)	EOIR Mo. Avg	% of EOIR Admin Total	ICE/EOIR Ratio
Guatemala	Trump 1st	159,975	3,332.8	18.3%	127,339	2,652.9	25.2%	1.26
Guatemala	Biden	120,009	2,500.2	16.8%	137,972	2,874.4	18.4%	0.87
Guatemala	Trump 2nd	59,439	4,572.2	13.7%	77,619	5,970.7	13.3%	0.77
Honduras	Obama	160,318	2,505.0	9.7%	51,073	798.0	12.7%	3.14
Honduras	Trump 1st	107,207	2,233.5	12.3%	110,245	2,296.8	21.8%	0.97
Honduras	Biden	93,699	1,952.1	13.1%	147,674	3,076.5	19.7%	0.63
Honduras	Trump 2nd	44,679	3,436.8	10.3%	80,573	6,197.9	13.8%	0.55
Venezuela	Obama	996	15.6	0.1%	719	11.2	0.2%	1.39
Venezuela	Trump 1st	1,109	23.6	0.1%	2,153	44.9	0.4%	0.53
Venezuela	Biden	8,894	185.3	1.2%	30,780	641.2	4.1%	0.29
Venezuela	Trump 2nd	25,471	1,959.3	5.9%	55,496	4,268.9	9.5%	0.46
Colombia	Obama	6,970	108.9	0.4%	2,699	42.2	0.7%	2.58
Colombia	Trump 1st	4,294	89.5	0.5%	2,043	42.6	0.4%	2.10
Colombia	Biden	46,701	972.9	6.5%	39,909	831.4	5.3%	1.17
Colombia	Trump 2nd	16,894	1,299.5	3.9%	36,860	2,835.4	6.3%	0.46
El Salvador	Obama	118,273	1,848.0	7.2%	41,425	647.3	10.3%	2.85
El Salvador	Trump 1st	58,932	1,227.8	6.7%	63,943	1,332.1	12.7%	0.92
El Salvador	Biden	38,932	811.1	5.4%	47,676	993.2	6.4%	0.82
El Salvador	Trump 2nd	17,284	1,329.5	4%	28,787	2,214.4	4.9%	0.60
Nicaragua	Obama	6,125	95.7	0.4%	2,245	35.1	0.6%	2.73
Nicaragua	Trump 1st	5,408	112.7	0.6%	5,109	106.4	1%	1.06

Nationality	Administration	ICE Removals (n)	ICE Mo. Avg	% of ICE Admin Total	EOIR Orders (n)	EOIR Mo. Avg	% of EOIR Admin Total	ICE/EOIR Ratio
Nicaragua	Biden	20,982	437.1	2.9%	59,938	1,248.7	8%	0.35
Nicaragua	Trump 2nd	14,829	1,140.7	3.4%	33,696	2,592.0	5.8%	0.44
Ecuador	Obama	7,971	124.5	0.5%	4,590	71.7	1.1%	1.74
Ecuador	Trump 1st	7,717	160.8	0.9%	8,683	180.9	1.7%	0.89
Ecuador	Biden	31,703	660.5	4.4%	37,837	788.3	5%	0.84
Ecuador	Trump 2nd	14,179	1,090.7	3.3%	31,126	2,394.3	5.3%	0.46
Cuba	Obama	337	5.3	0%	5,157	80.6	1.3%	0.07
Cuba	Trump 1st	3,488	72.7	0.4%	8,582	178.8	1.7%	0.41
Cuba	Biden	3,110	66.2	0.4%	7,025	146.4	0.9%	0.45
Cuba	Trump 2nd	9,928	763.7	2.3%	9,120	701.5	1.6%	1.09
Brazil	Obama	7,186	112.3	0.4%	2,010	31.4	0.5%	3.58
Brazil	Trump 1st	6,594	137.4	0.8%	5,370	111.9	1.1%	1.23
Brazil	Biden	13,907	289.7	1.9%	23,195	483.2	3.1%	0.60
Brazil	Trump 2nd	7,514	578.0	1.7%	12,563	966.4	2.1%	0.60
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	Obama	577	9.0	0%	2,210	34.5	0.5%	0.26
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	Trump 1st	635	14.8	0.1%	1,098	22.9	0.2%	0.65
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	Biden	262	6.2	0%	904	18.8	0.1%	0.33
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	Trump 2nd	1,778	136.8	0.4%	1,083	83.3	0.2%	1.64

Nationality	Administration	ICE Removals (n)	ICE Mo. Avg	% of ICE Admin Total	EOIR Orders (n)	EOIR Mo. Avg	% of EOIR Admin Total	ICE/EOIR Ratio
All Other Nationalities	Obama	72,254	1,129.0	4.4%	57,530	898.9	14.3%	1.26
All Other Nationalities	Trump 1st	57,439	1,196.6	6.6%	53,557	1,115.8	10.6%	1.07
All Other Nationalities	Biden	83,236	1,734.1	11.6%	102,653	2,138.6	13.7%	0.81
All Other Nationalities	Trump 2nd	51,256	3,942.8	11.8%	91,040	7,003.1	15.6%	0.56

Note: Ratio > 1.0 = ICE executing more removals than courts issue orders (drawing down accumulated backlog). % of Admin Total = each nationality's share of all ICE removals (or EOIR orders) within that administration. Obama coverage begins FY2012.

Table B8. SEA Removals by Charge Category (2022–2025)

Charge Category	2022 (n)	2023 (n)	2024 (n)	2025 (n)	2025 (%)	Change 2024→25 (n)	Change 2024→25 (%)
No Criminal Charge (Immigration Violator Only)	1	28	72	564	38%	492	683.3%
Violent Crime	10	10	28	436	29.4%	408	1457.1%
Property & Financial Crime	4	8	8	239	16.1%	231	2887.5%
Drug Offenses	1	2	3	87	5.9%	84	2800%
Sex Offenses	4	3	5	84	5.7%	79	1580%
Other	2	2	2	34	2.3%	32	1600%
Traffic & Minor Offenses	3	1	1	21	1.4%	20	2000%
Immigration Only	0	0	1	11	0.7%	10	1000%

Charge Category	2022 (n)	2023 (n)	2024 (n)	2025 (n)	2025 (%)	Change 2024→25 (n)	Change 2024→25 (%)
Public Order & Court Violations	0	0	0	8	0.5%	8	800%

Note: 'No Criminal Charge (Immigration Violator Only)' confirmed via cross-validation against case_criminality field — 96.4% map to ICE classification '3 Other Immigration Violator' (no criminal history).

Table B9. ICE Enforcement Flags (Terrorist & Gang) — SEA Nationals vs All Other Nationalities (2023–2026)

Group	Year	Total Removals	N Terr Populated	N Terrorist	% Terrorist	N Gang Populated	N Gang	% Gang
All Other Nationalities	2,023	206,194	206,194	691	0.34%	206,194	3,893	1.89%
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	2,023	56	56	0	0%	56	2	3.57%
All Other Nationalities	2,024	355,036	355,036	821	0.23%	355,036	4,021	1.13%
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	2,024	120	120	0	0%	120	5	4.17%
All Other Nationalities	2,025	389,366	389,366	1,332	0.34%	389,366	6,059	1.56%
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	2,025	1,506	1,506	0	0%	1,506	85	5.64%
All Other Nationalities	2,026	68,146	68,146	182	0.27%	68,146	720	1.06%
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	2,026	291	291	0	0%	291	12	4.12%

Group	Year	Total Removals	N Terr Populated	N Terrorist	% Terrorist	N Gang Populated	N Gang	% Gang
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Note: Flag variables available in FY2023+ files only. 'Suspected' gang flag reflects ICE classification, not criminal conviction. Percentages computed on populated subset (records where the flag field is filled out); the N Populated columns show denominator size.

Table B10. Aggravated-Felon Rate by Nationality (FY2023+)

Nationality	Period	Total Removals	N Populated	N Aggravated Felon	% Aggravated Felon
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	Pre Trump 2nd	195	129	20	10.26%
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	Trump 2nd	1,778	1,174	546	30.71%
Mexico	Pre Trump 2nd	193,392	106,510	6,217	3.21%
Mexico	Trump 2nd	169,926	116,615	3,018	1.78%
Guatemala	Pre Trump 2nd	108,349	19,238	343	0.32%
Guatemala	Trump 2nd	59,439	31,072	234	0.39%
Honduras	Pre Trump 2nd	82,558	19,946	430	0.52%
Honduras	Trump 2nd	44,679	23,693	218	0.49%
Venezuela	Pre Trump 2nd	8,376	1,438	6	0.07%
Venezuela	Trump 2nd	25,471	8,141	20	0.08%
Colombia	Pre Trump 2nd	40,796	3,766	110	0.27%

Nationality	Period	Total Removals	N Populated	N Aggravated Felon	% Aggravated Felon
Colombia	Trump 2nd	16,894	3,190	41	0.24%
El Salvador	Pre Trump 2nd	28,564	8,588	326	1.14%
El Salvador	Trump 2nd	17,284	10,999	213	1.23%
Nicaragua	Pre Trump 2nd	16,863	1,685	84	0.5%
Nicaragua	Trump 2nd	14,829	1,980	29	0.2%
Ecuador	Pre Trump 2nd	28,351	2,066	39	0.14%
Ecuador	Trump 2nd	14,179	3,324	15	0.11%
Cuba	Pre Trump 2nd	3,000	986	53	1.77%
Cuba	Trump 2nd	9,928	4,439	734	7.39%
Brazil	Pre Trump 2nd	9,818	1,820	11	0.11%
Brazil	Trump 2nd	7,514	1,912	15	0.2%
All Other Nationalities	Pre Trump 2nd	67,276	23,467	614	0.91%
All Other Nationalities	Trump 2nd	51,256	21,597	516	1.01%

Note: % of removals flagged as aggravated felon among records where the field is populated. Combines OTHER, DRUGS, and BOTH classifications under post-1996 INA §101(a)(43). Top 10 ranked by total FY2023+ removals (excluding SEA so Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia stay grouped). Field unpopulated for 28–55% of FY2023+ records; rates computed as share of all recorded removals. 2026 partial year (Jan–Feb).

Table B11. Age Distribution of SEA Removals by Administration

Administration	N Removals	Median Age	Mean Age	% Under 25	% 25–34	% 35–44	% 45–54	% 55–64	% 65+	% Over 40	% Over 50
Obama (2012–16)	511	37	38.1	8%	33.5%	34.6%	15.9%	7%	1%	42.3%	13.3%
Trump 1st (2017–20)	640	40	41.2	4.1%	21.2%	40.5%	23.6%	7.3%	3.3%	53.3%	17.5%
Biden (2021–24)	243	41	41.1	10.3%	25.5%	23%	25.5%	11.1%	4.5%	55.6%	25.9%
Trump 2nd (2025–26)	1,789	46	43.7	11%	15.5%	18%	35.3%	16.3%	3.9%	65.5%	38.3%

Note: Ages below 15 and above 80 excluded as implausible.

Table B12. Regression Results — Removal Rate Multipliers vs Biden Baseline (Trump 2nd Term)

Nationality	Total IRR	95% CI Lower	95% CI Upper	Group
Cuba	24.37x	23.44x	25.35x	Top 10
Venezuela	22.19x	21.67x	22.72x	Top 10
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	17.28x	15.92x	18.77x	SEA
Nicaragua	4.71x	4.62x	4.81x	Top 10
Ecuador	3.08x	3.02x	3.14x	Top 10
Brazil	3.07x	2.99x	3.15x	Top 10
All Other Nationalities	2.84x	2.81x	2.87x	Other Nationalities

Nationality	Total IRR	95% CI Lower	95% CI Upper	Group
Colombia	2.71x	2.66x	2.76x	Top 10
Honduras	1.52x	1.5x	1.53x	Top 10
Guatemala	1.49x	1.47x	1.5x	Top 10
Mexico (Reference)	1.13x	1.12x	1.13x	Mexico
El Salvador	0.95x	0.93x	0.96x	Top 10

Note: Poisson regression with nationality × administration interaction. Mexico = reference. All coefficients $p < 0.001$. IRR = Incidence Rate Ratio.

Table B13. Age of Final Removal Orders Being Executed — by Nationality and Administration

Nationality	Administration	N Removals	Median Years	25th Pctile	75th Pctile	% Order ≥ 5 yrs old	% Order ≥ 10 yrs old	% Order ≥ 15 yrs old
Mexico	Obama	929,605	0.02	0.00	0.18	6%	2.8%	1.2%
Mexico	Trump 1st	433,872	0.04	0.00	0.49	12.7%	6.2%	3%
Mexico	Biden	234,269	0.04	0.00	0.74	16.5%	10.3%	4.6%
Mexico	Trump 2nd	123,085	0.03	0.01	0.54	17.3%	11.1%	5.5%
Guatemala	Obama	218,761	0.04	0.02	0.08	3.6%	1.4%	0.6%
Guatemala	Trump 1st	156,105	0.05	0.02	0.14	5.8%	2.7%	1%
Guatemala	Biden	112,215	0.02	0.01	0.08	7.2%	3.2%	1.4%

Nationality	Administration	N Removals	Median Years	25th Pctile	75th Pctile	% Order ≥ 5 yrs old	% Order ≥ 10 yrs old	% Order ≥ 15 yrs old
Guatemala	Trump 2nd	44,535	0.10	0.02	5.16	25.3%	10.6%	4.6%
Honduras	Obama	157,401	0.05	0.02	0.12	6.9%	2.3%	0.7%
Honduras	Trump 1st	105,056	0.07	0.03	0.24	9.8%	6%	2%
Honduras	Biden	87,022	0.04	0.01	0.18	10.6%	6%	3.5%
Honduras	Trump 2nd	35,779	0.31	0.04	5.83	27.6%	13.8%	7.9%
Venezuela	Obama	801	0.15	0.07	1.19	12.9%	5%	1%
Venezuela	Trump 1st	859	0.08	0.03	0.20	4.2%	2.1%	0.3%
Venezuela	Biden	4,807	0.14	0.07	0.25	1.2%	0.8%	0.5%
Venezuela	Trump 2nd	19,005	0.09	0.04	0.43	0.9%	0.3%	0.2%
Colombia	Obama	6,346	0.17	0.08	1.85	15.6%	6.7%	3.5%
Colombia	Trump 1st	3,825	0.13	0.07	0.45	12.5%	7.8%	4.4%
Colombia	Biden	31,952	0.07	0.04	0.12	1.7%	1.3%	1%
Colombia	Trump 2nd	10,563	0.12	0.06	0.66	2.6%	2%	1.6%
El Salvador	Obama	115,644	0.10	0.05	0.21	8%	2.7%	1.1%
El Salvador	Trump 1st	57,036	0.08	0.04	0.30	11.4%	7.3%	2.4%

Nationality	Administration	N Removals	Median Years	25th Pctile	75th Pctile	% Order ≥ 5 yrs old	% Order ≥ 10 yrs old	% Order ≥ 15 yrs old
El Salvador	Biden	36,166	0.04	0.02	0.17	11.1%	6.7%	4.1%
El Salvador	Trump 2nd	14,331	0.35	0.04	7.71	33.4%	20.3%	12.6%
Nicaragua	Obama	5,842	0.13	0.08	0.43	12.7%	4.4%	2%
Nicaragua	Trump 1st	5,161	0.15	0.09	0.30	8.4%	5.8%	1.9%
Nicaragua	Biden	11,668	0.27	0.15	0.77	5.9%	4.1%	2.9%
Nicaragua	Trump 2nd	9,874	0.29	0.08	1.69	5.1%	3.1%	2.3%
Ecuador	Obama	7,330	0.12	0.08	0.43	11%	6%	2.4%
Ecuador	Trump 1st	7,190	0.12	0.07	0.27	7.9%	4%	2.1%
Ecuador	Biden	24,332	0.07	0.04	0.12	2.1%	1.3%	0.6%
Ecuador	Trump 2nd	9,725	0.10	0.04	0.86	5.8%	2.5%	1.4%
Cuba	Obama	257	4.48	0.22	13.96	47.9%	33.9%	22.6%
Cuba	Trump 1st	3,377	0.11	0.08	0.18	6.3%	5%	3.7%
Cuba	Biden	1,321	0.24	0.12	2.52	8.8%	6%	4.8%
Cuba	Trump 2nd	5,753	0.33	0.11	6.32	31.2%	18.7%	13%
Brazil	Obama	6,635	0.63	0.10	7.03	42%	6.4%	1%

Nationality	Administration	N Removals	Median Years	25th Pctile	75th Pctile	% Order ≥ 5 yrs old	% Order ≥ 10 yrs old	% Order ≥ 15 yrs old
Brazil	Trump 1st	5,935	0.14	0.08	0.39	15.3%	13.1%	3%
Brazil	Biden	8,276	0.14	0.08	0.35	7.2%	5.7%	5%
Brazil	Trump 2nd	4,479	0.19	0.07	2.02	12.3%	8%	6.9%
Vietnam	Obama	214	0.85	0.32	2.21	15.4%	4.2%	0.9%
Vietnam	Trump 1st	330	1.26	0.42	6.16	30.9%	13%	4.8%
Vietnam	Biden	159	0.63	0.24	1.31	16.4%	13.8%	10.7%
Vietnam	Trump 2nd	1,095	0.56	0.17	18.36	43.5%	40.4%	32%
Laos	Obama	25	0.68	0.11	5.65	28%	24%	8%
Laos	Trump 1st	24	2.53	0.31	8.04	41.7%	16.7%	16.7%
Laos	Biden	10	11.46	3.96	16.63	70%	60%	30%
Laos	Trump 2nd	416	18.00	11.63	23.10	85.6%	77.2%	61.8%
Cambodia	Obama	261	2.38	0.75	8.38	36.8%	19.5%	7.7%
Cambodia	Trump 1st	245	7.55	0.91	14.83	60%	42.9%	24.1%
Cambodia	Biden	46	7.13	0.68	18.77	50%	50%	41.3%
Cambodia	Trump 2nd	96	16.81	5.43	24.12	75%	74%	57.3%

Nationality	Administration	N Removals	Median Years	25th Pctile	75th Pctile	% Order ≥ 5 yrs old	% Order ≥ 10 yrs old	% Order ≥ 15 yrs old
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	Obama	500	1.20	0.57	5.46	27.2%	13.2%	4.8%
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	Trump 1st	599	3.14	0.59	10.23	43.2%	25.4%	13.2%
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	Biden	215	0.74	0.34	8.87	26%	23.7%	18.1%
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	Trump 2nd	1,607	11.26	0.26	20.88	56.3%	51.9%	41.2%
All Other Nationalities	Obama	59,594	0.21	0.09	1.62	14.1%	7%	2.9%
All Other Nationalities	Trump 1st	50,852	0.22	0.08	1.03	14.6%	7.8%	4%
All Other Nationalities	Biden	52,496	0.16	0.08	0.44	10.2%	6.9%	4.7%
All Other Nationalities	Trump 2nd	36,302	0.19	0.08	0.65	10.2%	6.7%	4.4%

Note: Years between immigration judge's final order date and ICE removal date. Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia shown individually; SEA total combines all three. Negative or implausible (>30 yr) values excluded.

Table B14. Detention Length by Nationality - Pre Trump 2nd vs Trump 2nd

Nationality	Period	N Total	N Completed	% Ongoing	Median (days)	Mean (days)	25th Pctile (days)	75th Pctile (days)
Mexico	Pre Trump 2nd	141,376	140,579	0.1%	7.3	26.0	0.6	29.9
Mexico	Trump 2nd	160,943	150,337	6.1%	8.9	22.9	1.7	30.4

Nationality	Period	N Total	N Completed	% Ongoing	Median (days)	Mean (days)	25th Pctile (days)	75th Pctile (days)
Guatemala	Pre Trump 2nd	61,884	61,161	0.1%	24.0	37.0	10.2	45.8
Guatemala	Trump 2nd	61,802	56,974	7.8%	17.3	30.6	8.2	39.6
Honduras	Pre Trump 2nd	57,410	56,567	0.1%	30.8	45.1	16.0	53.9
Honduras	Trump 2nd	45,669	41,435	9.2%	20.8	34.1	9.1	45.4
Venezuela	Pre Trump 2nd	36,297	35,899	0%	41.7	64.4	19.9	89.0
Venezuela	Trump 2nd	28,493	24,106	15.3%	41.6	52.0	21.4	69.7
Colombia	Pre Trump 2nd	59,684	59,330	0%	31.8	41.5	17.6	51.6
Colombia	Trump 2nd	13,164	11,141	15.2%	44.1	53.7	23.5	72.2
El Salvador	Pre Trump 2nd	23,207	22,944	0.6%	32.8	56.4	17.8	60.3
El Salvador	Trump 2nd	18,578	16,012	13.7%	26.8	42.3	11.8	55.9
Nicaragua	Pre Trump 2nd	15,824	15,594	0%	49.8	69.1	23.8	93.3
Nicaragua	Trump 2nd	12,567	10,833	13.8%	43.7	55.5	23.9	73.8
Ecuador	Pre Trump 2nd	46,302	45,631	0%	30.3	38.2	14.2	49.5
Ecuador	Trump 2nd	12,882	11,325	11.7%	33.7	44.0	17.1	58.5
Cuba	Pre Trump 2nd	13,045	12,970	0.2%	24.1	46.5	7.0	54.4

Nationality	Period	N Total	N Completed	% Ongoing	Median (days)	Mean (days)	25th Pctile (days)	75th Pctile (days)
Cuba	Trump 2nd	11,803	7,551	36%	73.0	88.3	37.8	121.7
Brazil	Pre Trump 2nd	7,851	7,813	0.1%	40.2	55.5	19.9	67.9
Brazil	Trump 2nd	5,782	4,940	12%	37.9	50.6	16.0	72.8
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/ Cambodia)	Pre Trump 2nd	1,881	1,820	3%	49.7	98.0	23.0	131.9
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/ Cambodia)	Trump 2nd	2,900	1,768	39%	85.3	99.7	47.3	134.1
All Other Nationalities	Pre Trump 2nd	158,738	155,728	1.5%	39.2	70.8	17.6	79.2
All Other Nationalities	Trump 2nd	53,666	39,323	26.6%	49.6	71.4	23.4	95.7

Note: Median, mean, and quartiles computed on completed stays only (those with both stay_book_in and stay_book_out dates). Stays exceeding 730 days excluded as data-quality outliers (~1-2% of right tail). '% Ongoing' = share of stays in that group/period with no book-out date as of latest data refresh; because people who exit quickly are over-represented in completed stays, the true population median is likely higher than reported. Pre Trump 2nd combines Jan 2019 - Jan 2025 (Trump 1st partial + Biden).

Table B15. Detention Outcomes by Nationality and Administration — Share Ending in Removal

Nationality	Administration	N Completed	N Removed	% Removal
Mexico	Biden	141,268	113,172	80.1%
Mexico	Trump 2nd	151,195	132,084	87.4%
Guatemala	Biden	61,845	46,779	75.6%
Guatemala	Trump 2nd	57,007	52,243	91.6%

Nationality	Administration	N Completed	N Removed	% Removal
Honduras	Biden	57,367	43,187	75.3%
Honduras	Trump 2nd	41,458	37,747	91%
Venezuela	Biden	36,285	5,295	14.6%
Venezuela	Trump 2nd	24,141	20,561	85.2%
Colombia	Biden	59,668	23,447	39.3%
Colombia	Trump 2nd	11,164	9,515	85.2%
El Salvador	Biden	23,068	16,459	71.3%
El Salvador	Trump 2nd	16,025	13,725	85.6%
Nicaragua	Biden	15,817	5,824	36.8%
Nicaragua	Trump 2nd	10,836	9,819	90.6%
Ecuador	Biden	46,292	20,439	44.2%
Ecuador	Trump 2nd	11,377	9,895	87%
Cuba	Biden	13,018	1,575	12.1%
Cuba	Trump 2nd	7,556	5,904	78.1%
Brazil	Biden	7,844	3,641	46.4%
Brazil	Trump 2nd	5,090	4,055	79.7%

Nationality	Administration	N Completed	N Removed	% Removal
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	Biden	1,824	461	25.3%
SEA (Vietnam/Laos/Cambodia)	Trump 2nd	1,769	1,347	76.1%
All Other Nationalities	Biden	156,404	43,999	28.1%
All Other Nationalities	Trump 2nd	39,365	27,824	70.7%

Note: Removal classification based on stay_release_reason field; includes values matching 'removed', 'departed', or 'deported'. Completed stays only (those with a stay_book_out date). Trump 1st coverage is partial — detention data begins Jan 2019.

Table B16a. Conviction Year Statistics — SEA Aggravated Felons

Group	N	Earliest Year	P25 Year	Median Year	P75 Year	Latest Year	% Pre-1996	% Pre-2000
All SEA AF (FY2023+)	567	1,980	1,996.00	2,001.0	2,007.50	2,025	22.4%	42.5%
Biden	20	1,988	1,994.75	1,999.5	2,005.25	2,011	30%	50%
Trump 2nd	547	1,980	1,996.00	2,002.0	2,008.00	2,025	22.1%	42.2%

Note: Pre-1996 = convictions predating AEDPA/IIRIRA. Restricted to SEA AF removals with populated msc_conviction_date.

Table B16b. Conviction Age Statistics — SEA Aggravated Felons

Group	N	Median Age (yrs)	P25 Age (yrs)	P75 Age (yrs)	% Over 20 yrs	% Over 30 yrs
All SEA AF (FY2023+)	567	23.8	17.5	29.3	66.1%	21%
Biden	20	24.4	17.9	29.6	65%	25%

Group	N	Median Age (yrs)	P25 Age (yrs)	P75 Age (yrs)	% Over 20 yrs	% Over 30 yrs
Trump 2nd	547	23.8	17.5	29.3	66.2%	20.8%

Note: Median Age = years between conviction and removal. Same record set as Table B16a.

Table B17. Conviction Age by Charge Category — SEA Serious-Charge Removals

Charge Category	N	Missing Year	Earliest Year	P25 Year	Median Year	P75 Year	Median Age (yrs)	Mean Age (yrs)	% Pre-1996	% Over 20 yrs
Violent Crime	829	0	1,980	1,996	2,002	2,009.0	19.0	18.5	22.2%	46.3%
Sex Offense	301	0	1,981	1,998	2,006	2,012.0	14.9	15.9	13.3%	36.2%
Drug Offense	352	0	1,986	2,006	2,010	2,014.0	7.9	10.4	4.3%	15.9%
Property Crime	303	0	1,985	1,999	2,006	2,012.5	14.8	15.4	12.5%	36.3%

Note: Restricted to SEA removals (Vietnam, Laos, Cambodia) in the four most serious charge categories with populated departure dates. Median Age = years between conviction and removal at time of departure. Implausible conviction years (pre-1970 or post-2026) excluded. Missing Year column shows records where *msc_conviction_date* is NA — these are excluded from the year-based statistics but counted in N.

Table B18. SEA Charge Categories — Aggravated Felons vs Not Aggravated Felons

Charge Category	AF (n)	AF (%)	Non-AF + NA (n)	Non-AF + NA (%)
Violent Crime	245	43.2%	584	37.4%
Property Crime	95	16.8%	208	13.3%
Sex Offense	87	15.3%	214	13.7%
Drug Offense	62	10.9%	290	18.6%

Charge Category	AF (n)	AF (%)	Non-AF + NA (n)	Non-AF + NA (%)
Weapons Offense	47	8.3%	97	6.2%
Public Order / Procedural	10	1.8%	32	2.1%
Fraud / Financial	9	1.6%	58	3.7%
Family / Domestic Violence	8	1.4%	32	2.1%
Terrorism / Threats	3	0.5%	7	0.4%
Other	1	0.2%	7	0.4%
DUI / Traffic	0	0%	15	1%
Immigration	0	0%	16	1%

Note: Among SEA removals with msc_charge populated. Aggravated Felon column includes records flagged YES for OTHER, DRUGS, or BOTH under post-1996 INA §101(a)(43). Non-AF + NA column includes records flagged 'NOT AN AGGRAVATED FELON' plus records where the AF field was not populated. Categories ordered by AF count.

Table B19. Age at Time of Conviction by Charge Category — SEA Serious-Charge Removals

Charge Category	N	Missing Data	Youngest	P25 Age	Median Age	P75 Age	Oldest	Mean Age	% Under 25	% Under 30
Violent Crime	829	0	14	21	25	32	65	27.6	46.9%	68%
Sex Offense	301	0	14	24	32	39	62	32.6	27.9%	43.2%
Drug Offense	352	0	18	26	31	38	73	32.6	19%	44.9%
Property Crime	303	0	15	22	28	36	70	30.5	36.3%	53.8%

Charge Category	N	Missing Data	Youngest	P25 Age	Median Age	P75 Age	Oldest	Mean Age	% Under 25	% Under 30
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Note: Restricted to SEA removals (Vietnam, Laos, Cambodia) in the four most serious charge categories with populated birth year and conviction date. Age computed as conviction year minus birth year. Implausible ages (<5 or >90) excluded as data-entry artifacts. Missing Data column shows records where conviction date or birth year is NA — these are excluded from the age-based statistics but counted in N.

Table B20. Missingness Summary — Key Analytical Fields Across Datasets

Dataset	Field	N Total	N Missing	% Missing
Arrests	citizenship_country	438,380	0	0%
Arrests	apprehension_date	438,380	0	0%
Arrests	apprehension_year_month	438,380	0	0%
Arrests	apprehension_aor	438,380	2,113	0.5%
Removals	citizenship_country	3,672,718	5	0%
Removals	departed_date	3,672,718	0	0%
Removals	departed_year_month	3,672,718	0	0%
Removals	ca_location	3,672,718	0	0%
Removals	removal_year	3,672,718	0	0%
Removals	charge_category	3,672,718	1,263,046	34.4%
Removals	msc_charge	3,672,718	1,883,093	51.3%
Removals	msc_conviction_date	3,672,718	1,883,095	51.3%

Dataset	Field	N Total	N Missing	% Missing
Removals	aggravated_felon_yes_no	3,672,718	3,240,412	88.2%
Removals	age_at_departure	3,672,718	18	0%
Removals	days_order_to_removal	3,672,718	353,196	9.6%
Removals	case_threat_level	3,672,718	0	0%
Removals	case_criminality	3,672,718	2,627,588	71.5%
Removals	known_terrorist_yes_no	3,672,718	2,627,588	71.5%
Removals	suspected_gang_yes_no	3,672,718	2,627,588	71.5%
Detentions	citizenship_country	1,051,748	2	0%
Detentions	stay_book_in_date_time	1,051,748	0	0%
Detentions	stay_book_out_date_time	1,051,748	54,065	5.1%
Detentions	book_in_year_month	1,051,748	0	0%
Detentions	ca_location	1,051,748	0	0%
Detentions	stay_release_reason	1,051,748	94,148	9%
EOIR	nationality	10,555,204	2,520	0%
EOIR	case_outcome	10,555,204	3,308,773	31.3%

Dataset	Field	N Total	N Missing	% Missing
EOIR	ij_final_date	10,555,204	3,308,761	31.3%

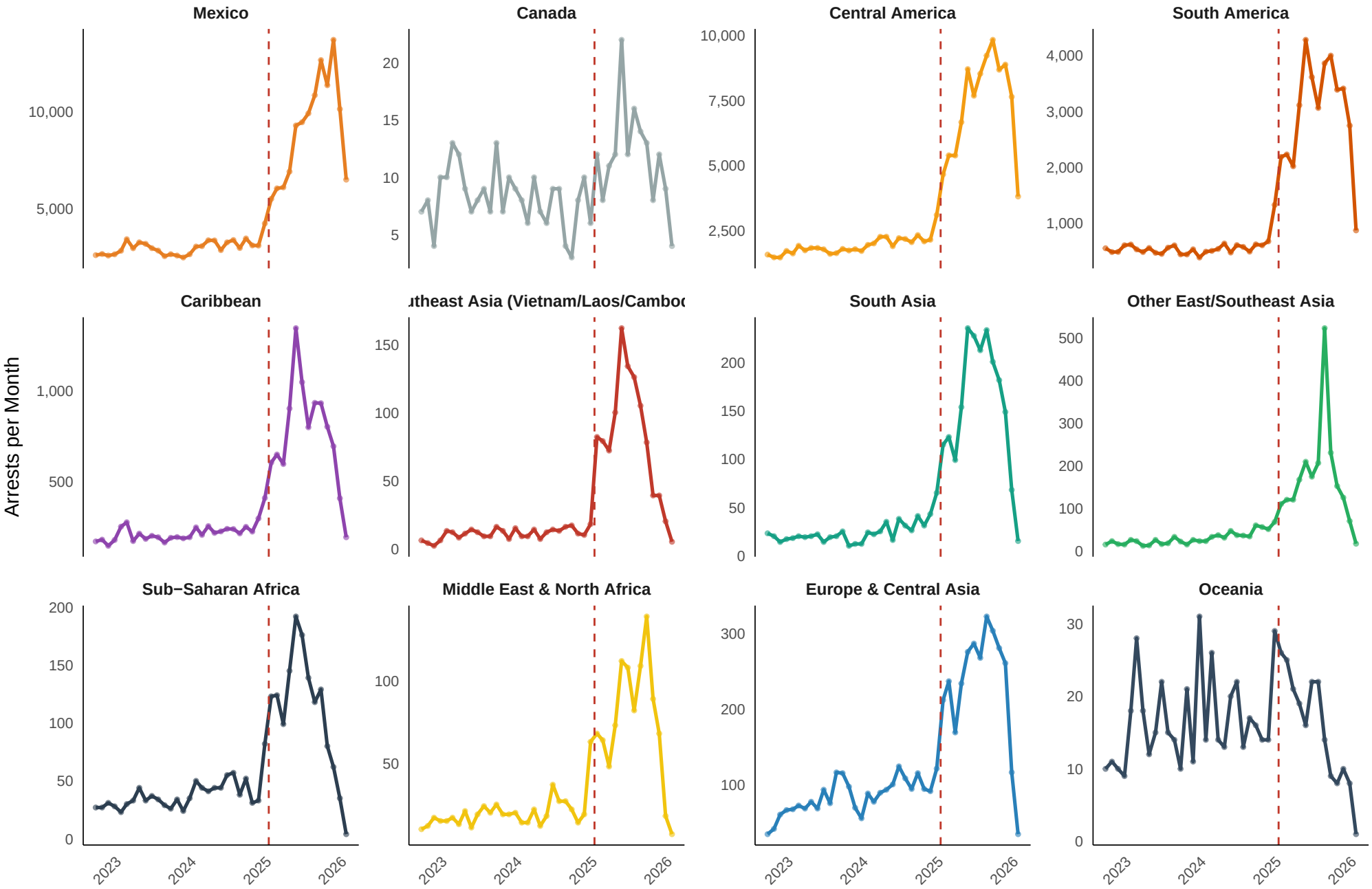
Note: Counts and rates of missing values (NA) for each key analytical field across the four underlying datasets. Fields with high missingness are flagged in the corresponding analytical chapters and handled via NA-inclusive filters (see methodology section 3.3). Datasets shown in the order they appear in the analysis: Arrests (Oct 2022 – Mar 2026), Removals (FY2012 – Mar 2026), Detentions (Jan 2019 – Mar 2026, restricted to 2022+ in analysis), EOIR Case Database (Obama administration onwards).

Appendix C — Supplementary Figures

Figure C1

National Monthly ICE Arrests by World Region

All nationalities grouped by region | Oct 2022 – Feb 2026
Each panel uses its own y-scale | Dashed line marks Trump 2nd inauguration



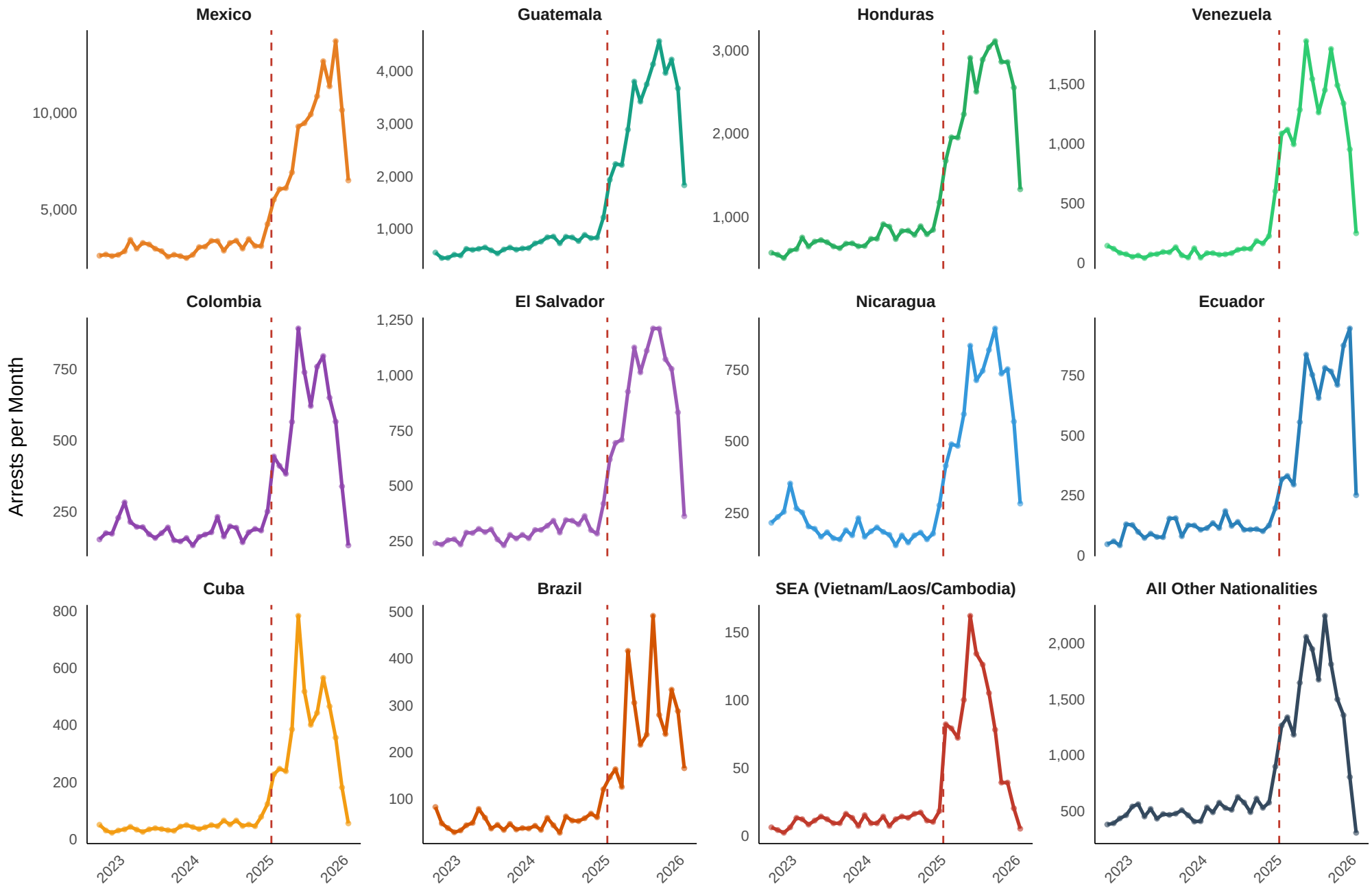
Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA)

Figure C2

National Monthly ICE Arrests: Top 10 Nationalities, SEA, and All Others

All nationalities grouped by region | October 2022 – early 2026

Each panel uses its own y-scale | Dashed line marks Trump 2nd inaugurations

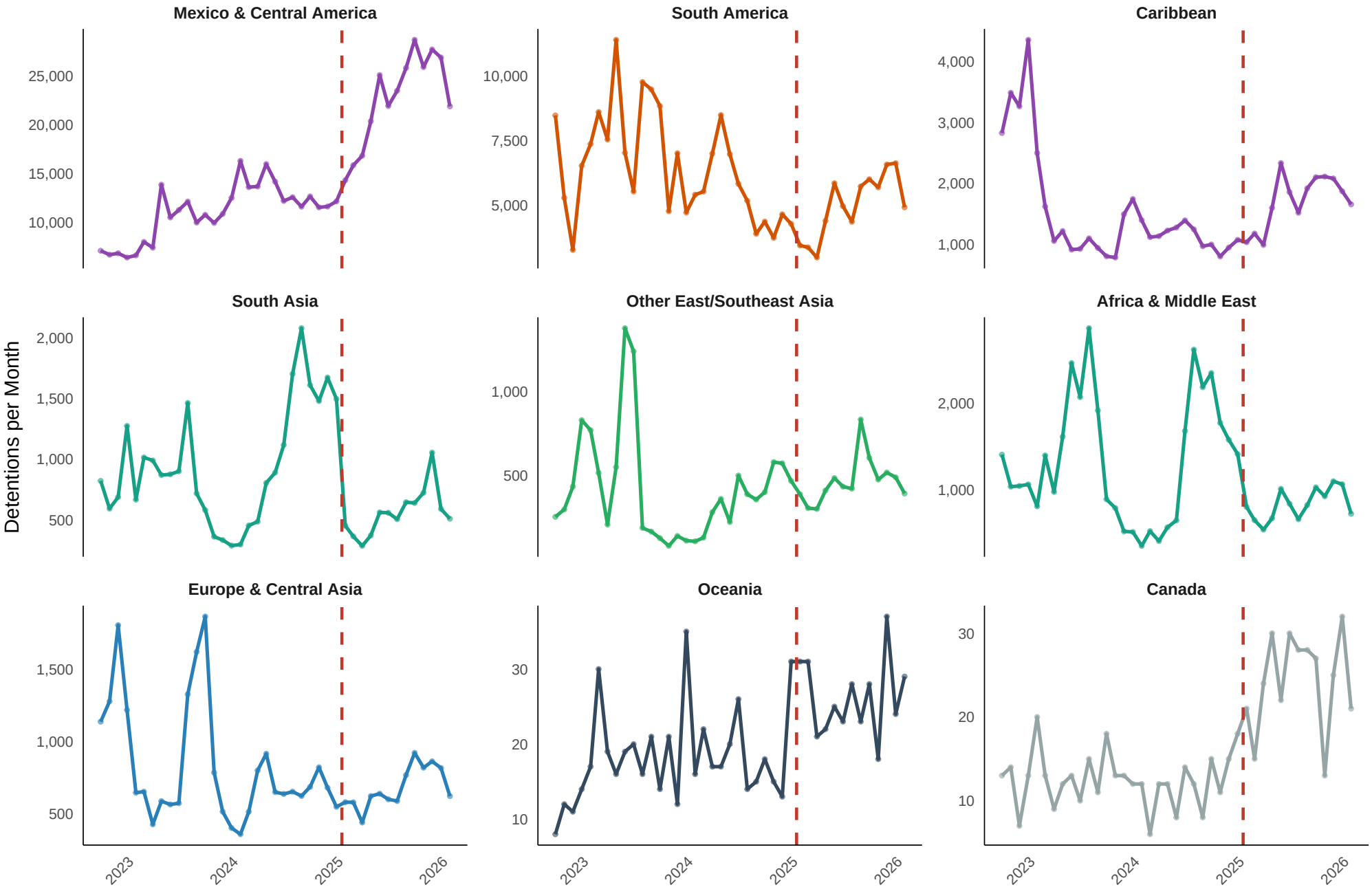


Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA)

Figure C3

National Monthly ICE Detentions by World Region

All nationalities grouped by region (excl. Southeast Asia) | Oct 2022 – Feb 2026
Each panel uses its own y-scale | Dashed line marks Trump 2nd inauguration



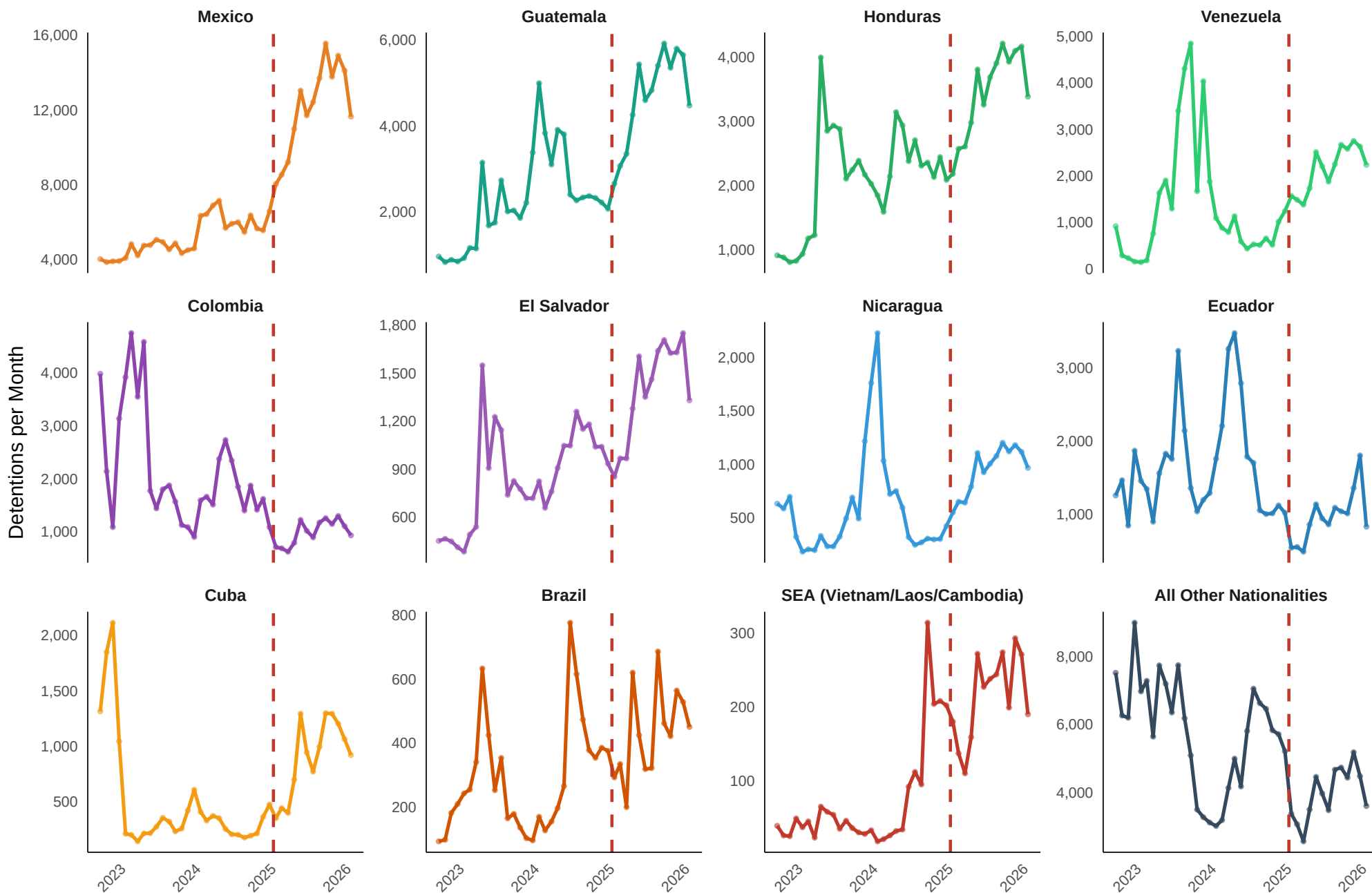
Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA)

Figure C4

National Monthly ICE Detentions: Top 10 Nationalities, SEA, and All Others

Top 10 by 2025 removal volume | Jan 2022 – Feb 2026

Each panel uses its own y-scale | Dashed line marks Trump 2nd inauguration

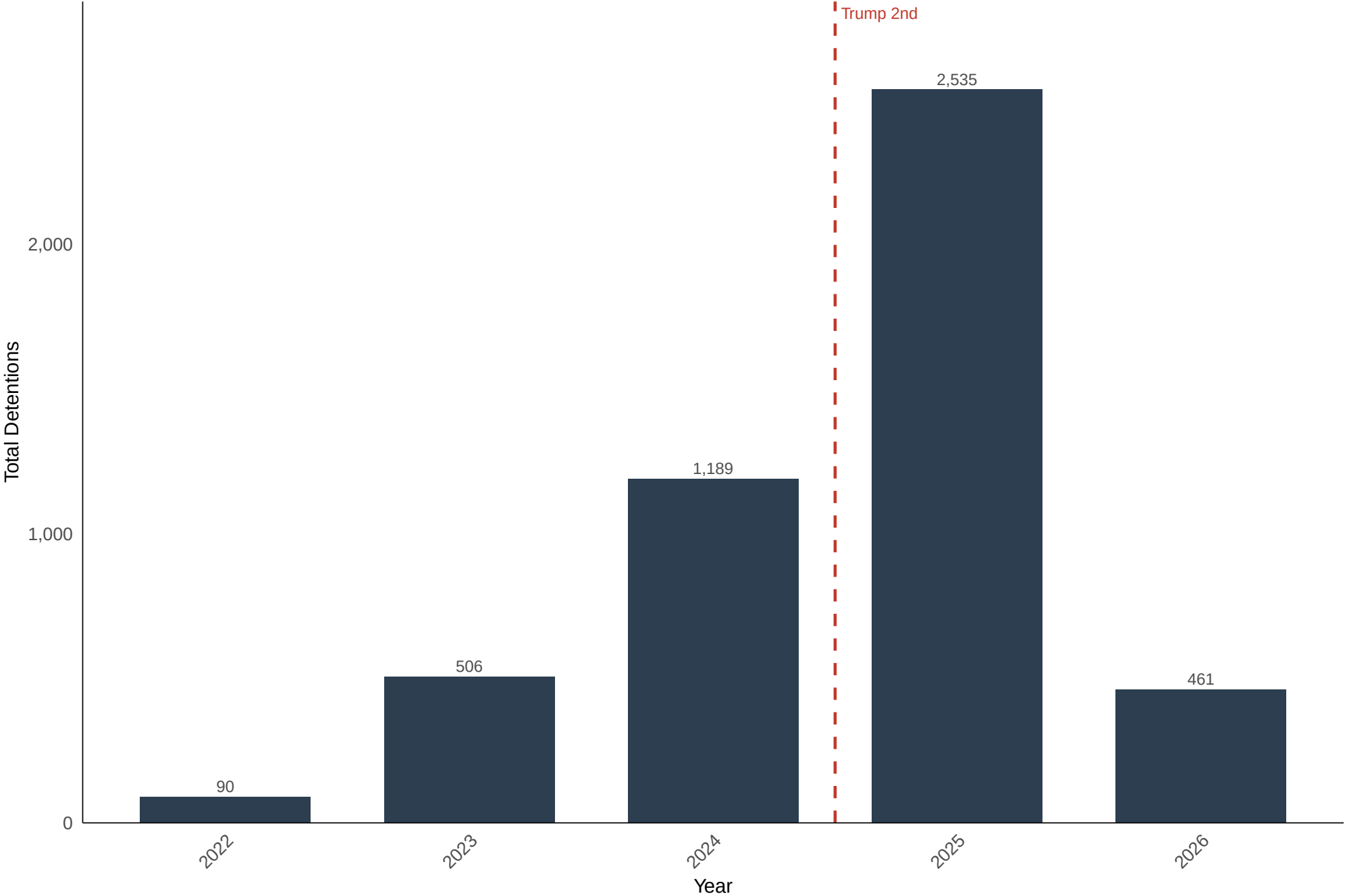


Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA)

Figure C5

National Annual ICE Detentions

Vietnam, Laos & Cambodia combined | Oct 2022 – Feb 2026

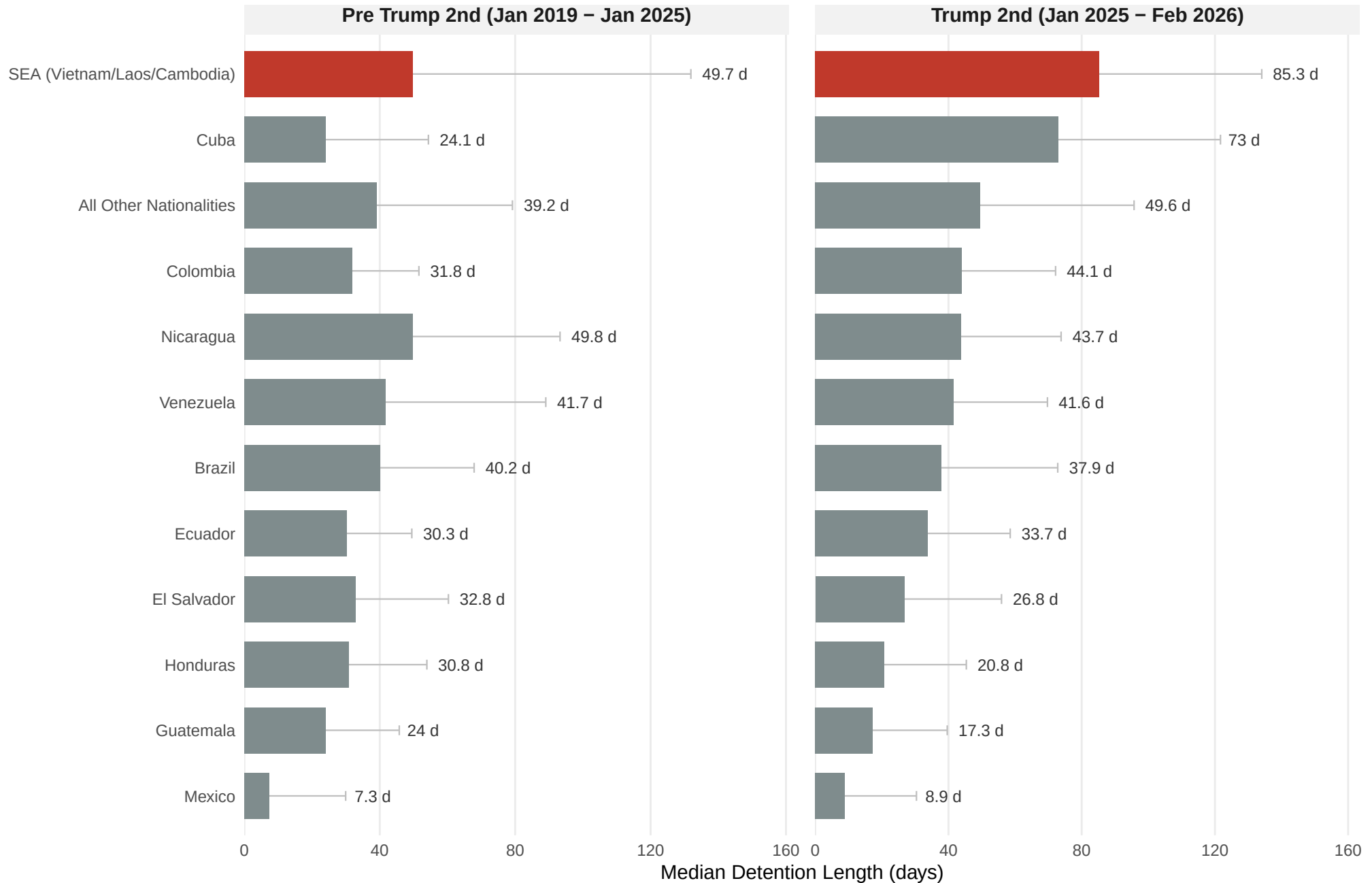


Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA)

Figure C6

Median Detention Length by Nationality – Pre Trump 2nd vs Trump 2nd

Pre Trump 2nd combines Jan 2019 – Jan 2025 (Trump 1st partial + Biden).



Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA)

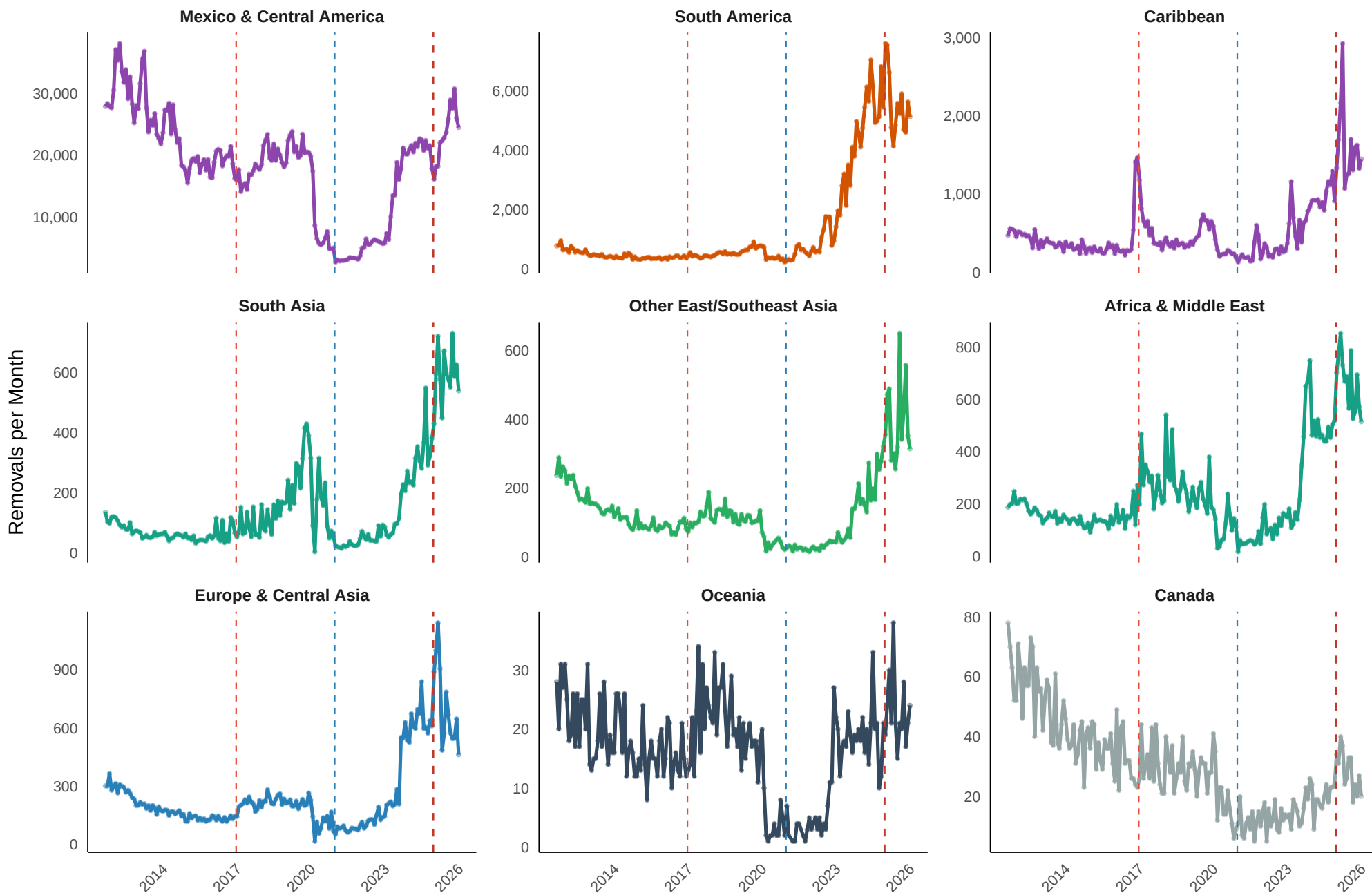
Completed stays only; capped at 730 days. Light-grey range = 25th–75th percentile (IQR).

Figure C7

National Monthly ICE Removals by World Region

All nationalities grouped by region (excl. Southeast Asia) | Oct 2011 – early 2026

Each panel uses its own y-scale | Dashed lines mark Trump 1st, Biden, and Trump 2nd inaugurations



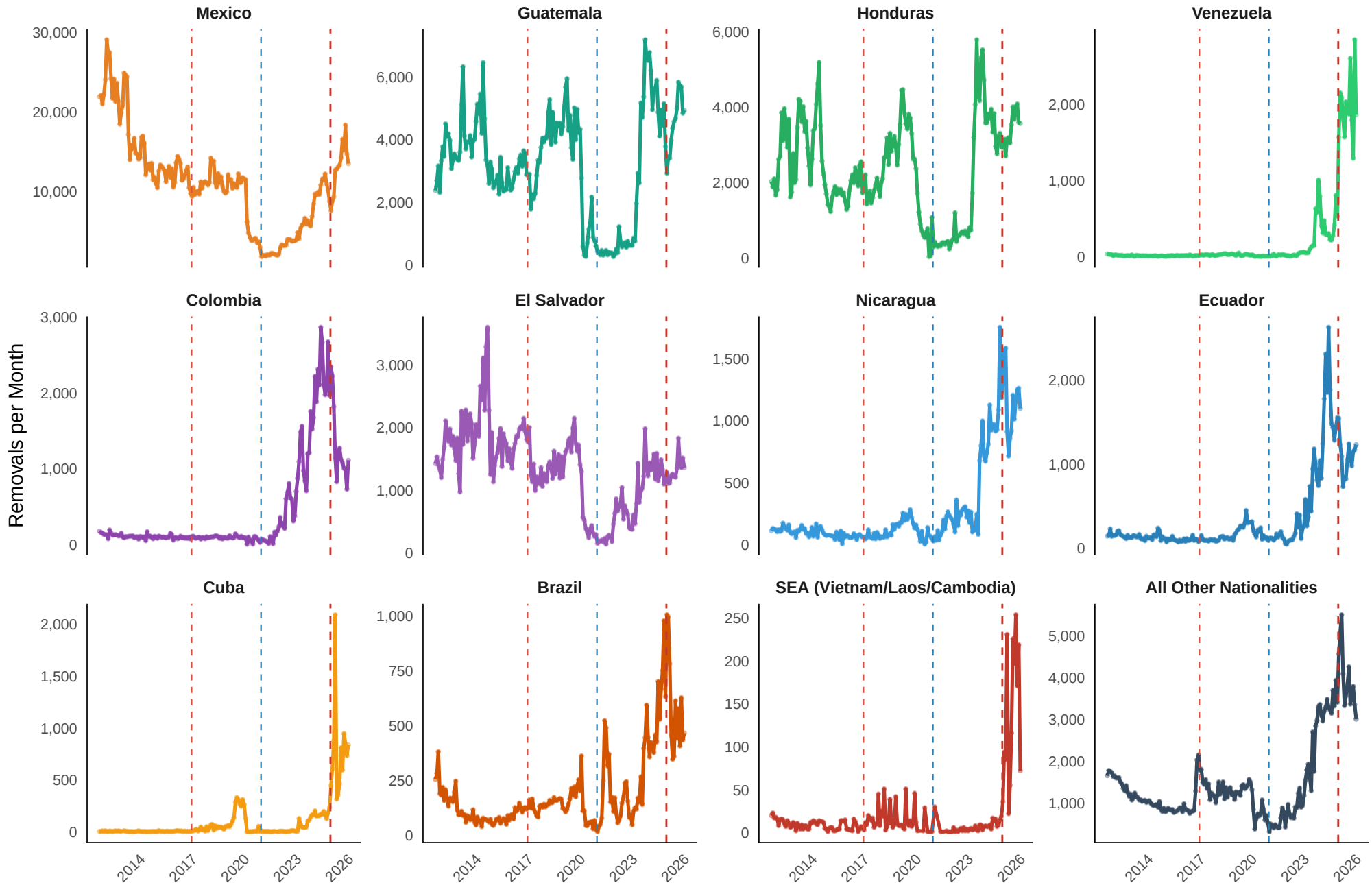
Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA)

Figure C8

National Monthly ICE Removals — Top 10 Nationalities, SEA, and All Others

All nationalities grouped by region | Oct 2011 – early 2026

Each panel uses its own y-scale | Dashed lines mark Trump 1st, Biden, and Trump 2nd inaugurations

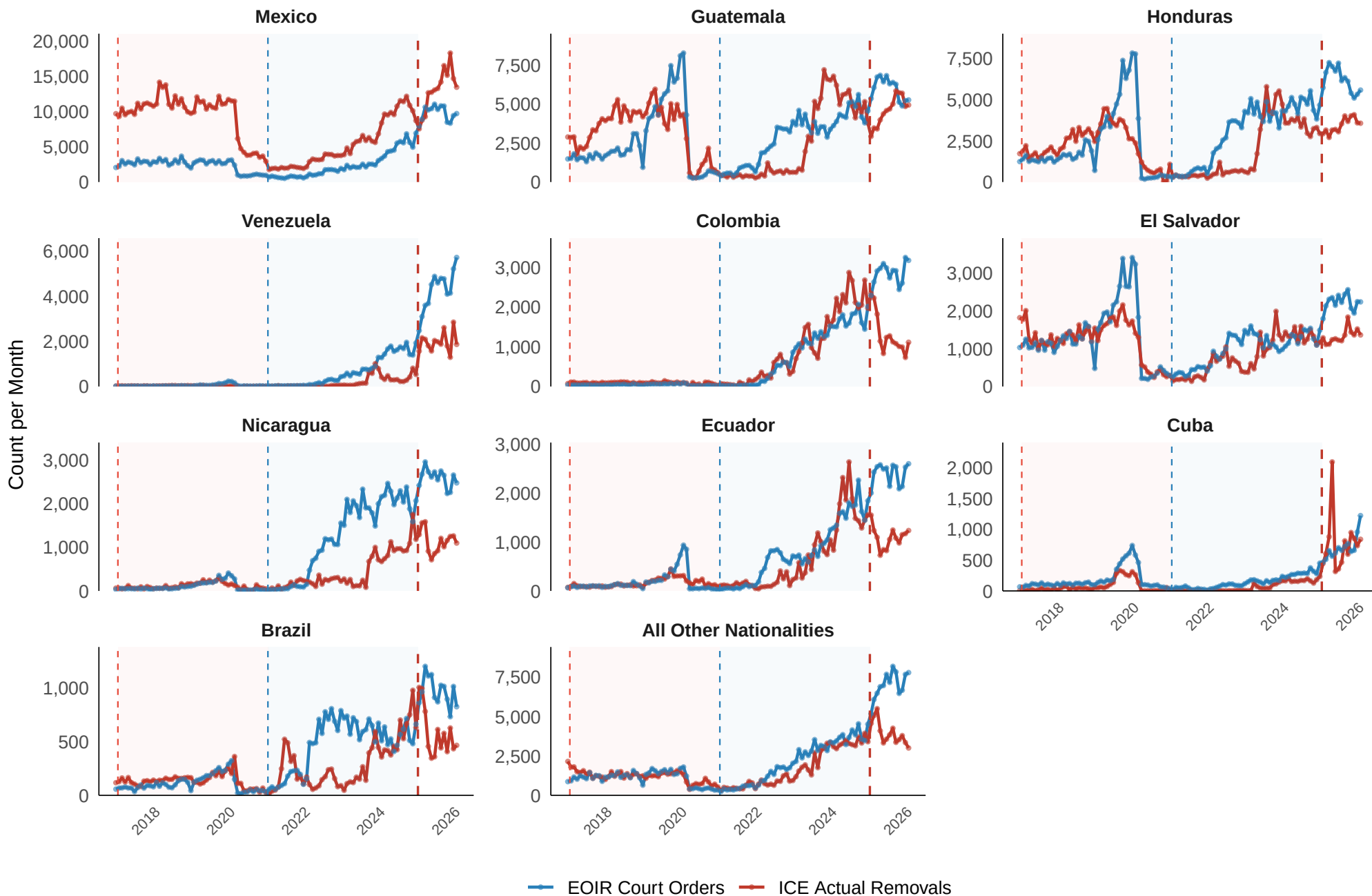


Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA)

Figure C9

National ICE Actual Removals vs Immigration Court Orders by Nationality

Jan 2017 – Feb 2026 | Top 10 nationalities + all others combined | Vietnam, Laos & Cambodia shown separately

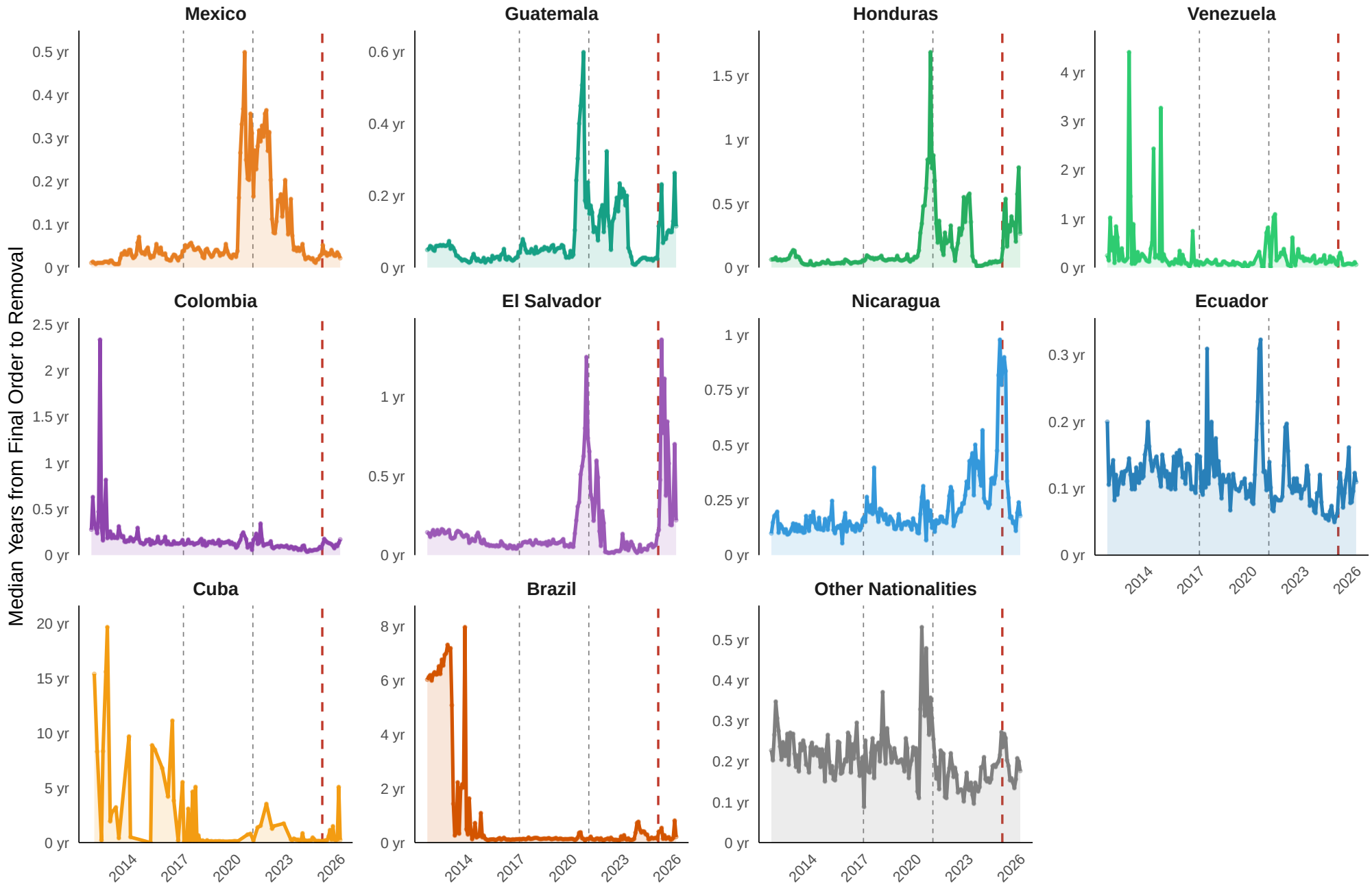


Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA & EOIR)

Figure C10

National Median Age of Final Orders Being Executed — Other Nationalities

Top 11 nationalities + all others combined | Monthly median years from final order to removal
Each panel uses its own y-scale | Dashed lines mark Trump 1st, Biden, and Trump 2nd inaugurations

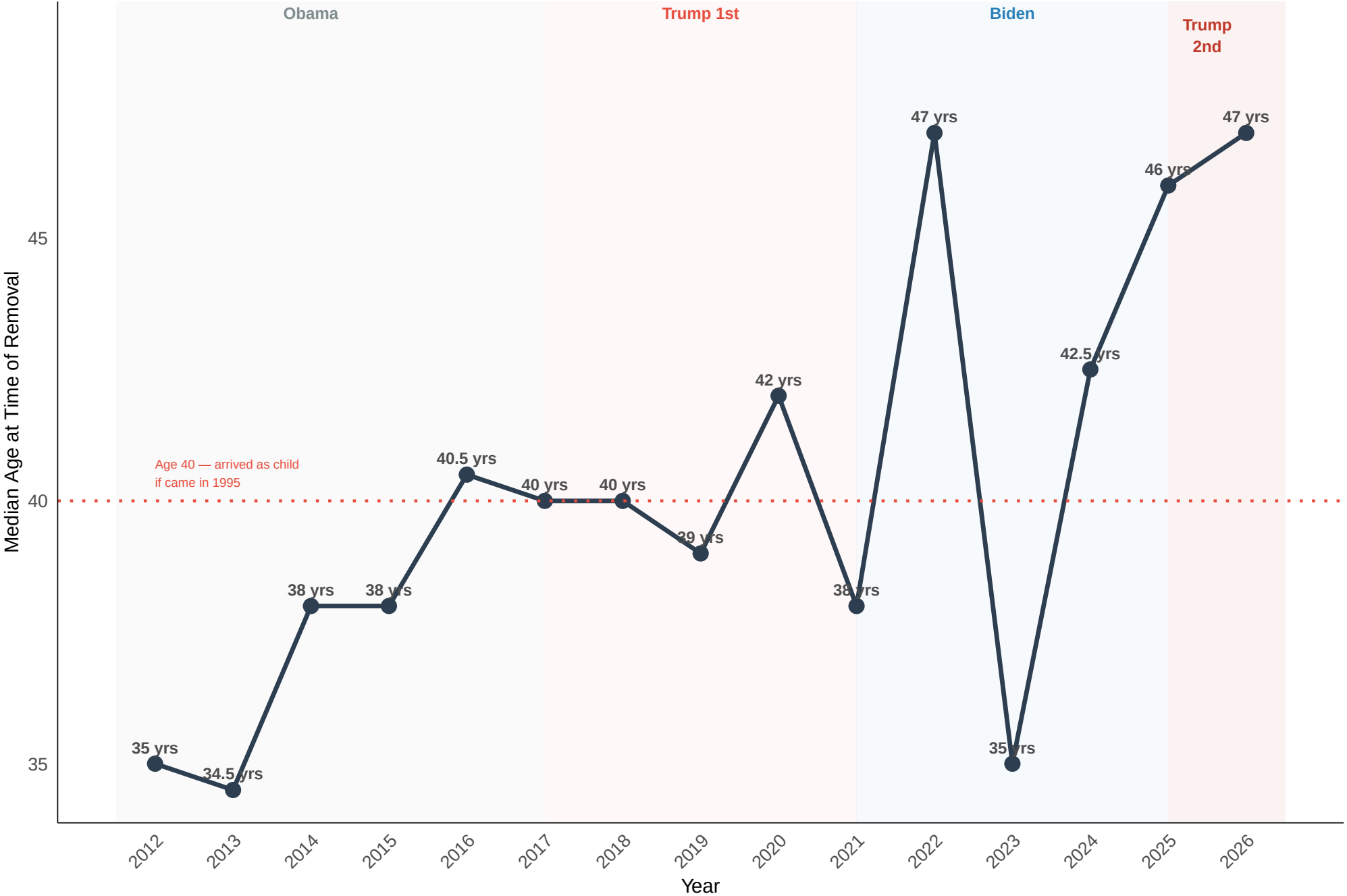


Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA). Months with <5 removals per group suppressed.

Figure C11

National Median Age at Removal — SEA Nationals Over Time

Vietnam, Laos & Cambodia | Dotted line = age 40 (arrived as child if came in 1995)

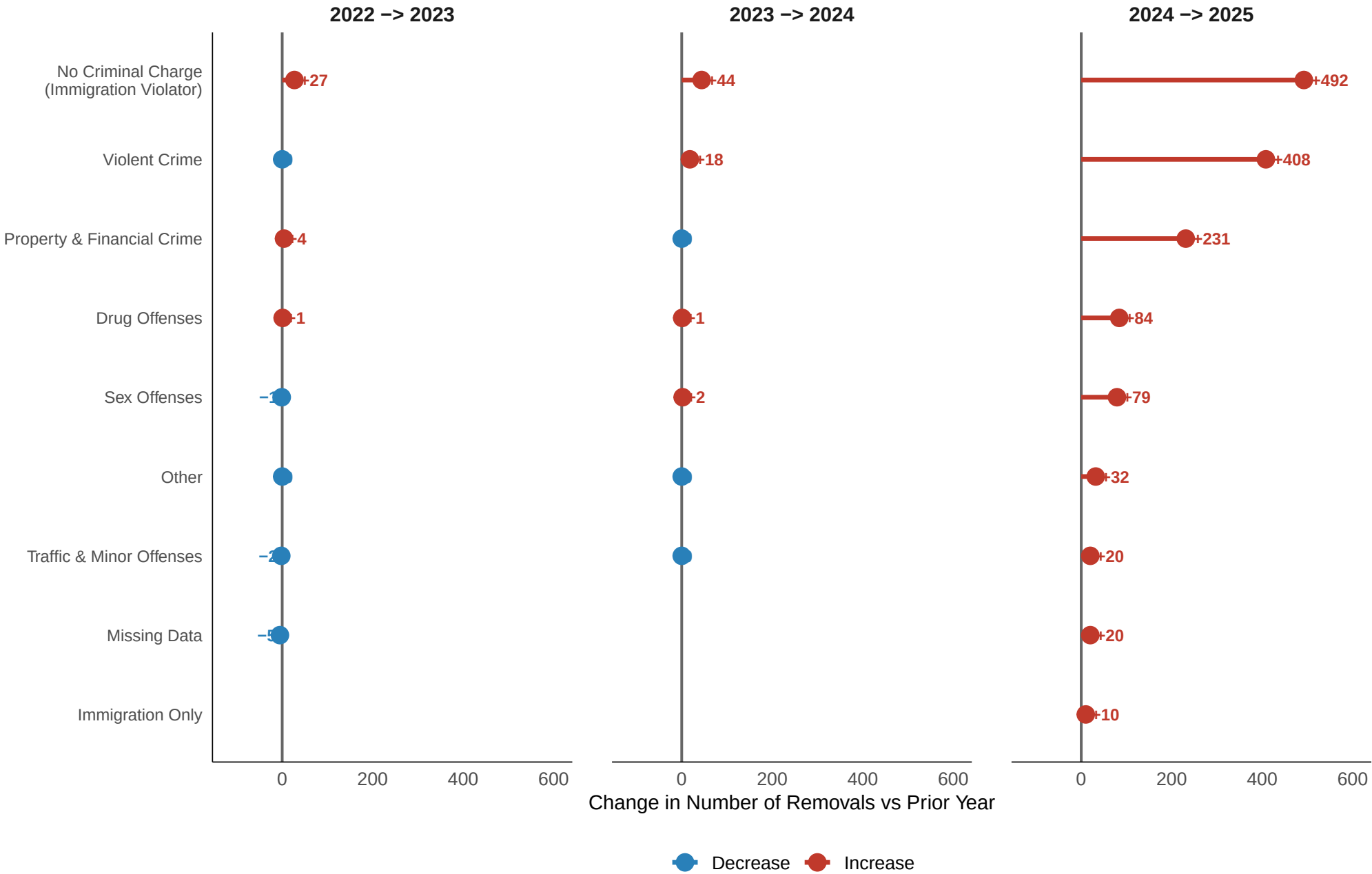


Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA) | 2026 partial year

Figure C12

National Year-on-Year Change in SEA Removals by Charge Category

Vietnam, Laos & Cambodia | Each panel = one year transition
Ordered by 2024 -> 2025 change

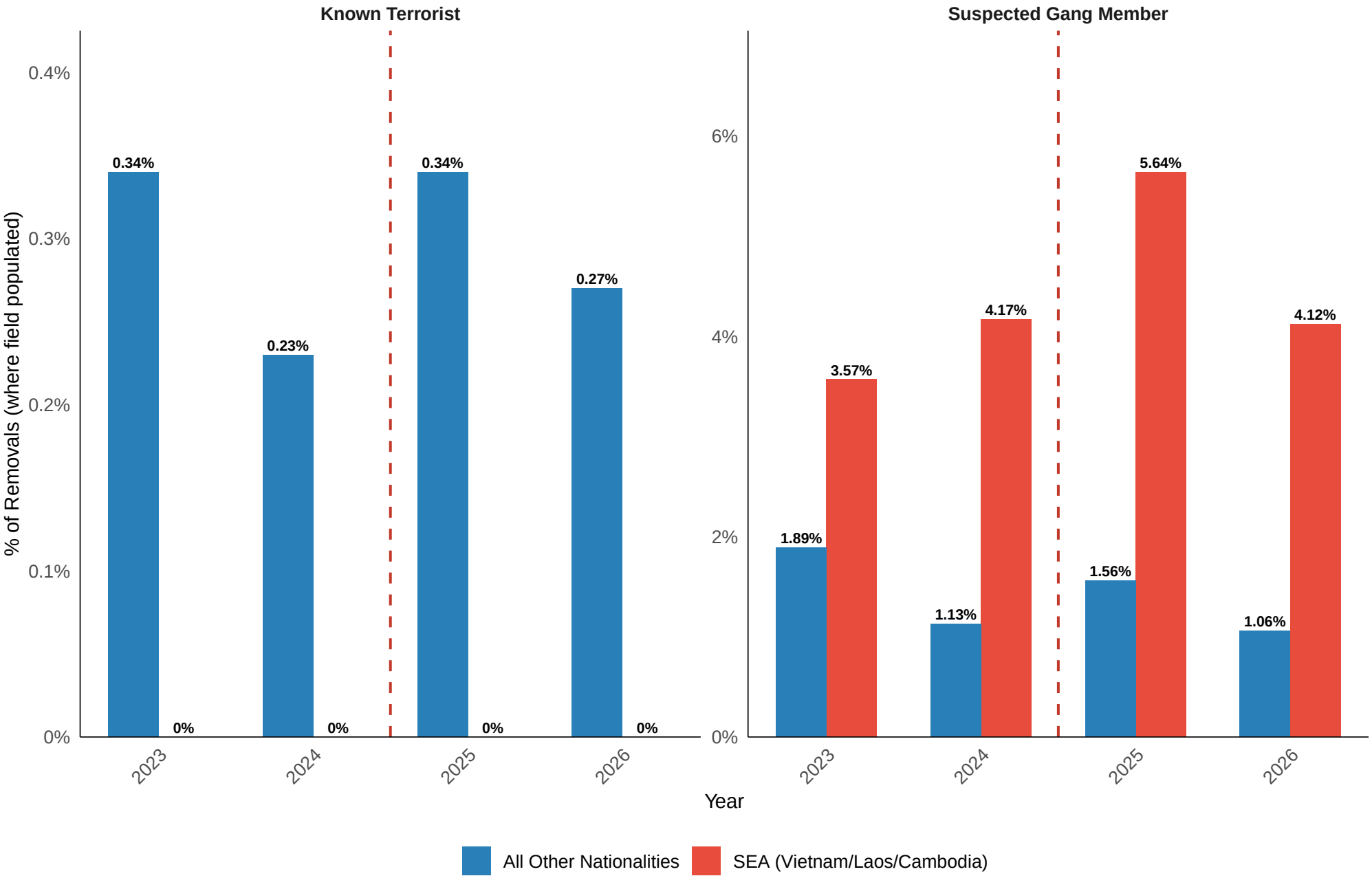


Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA)

Figure C13

National ICE Enforcement Flags – Terrorist & Gang

% of removals flagged among records where the field is populated | Oct 2022 – Feb 2026
Dashed lines mark Pre T2 and Post T2



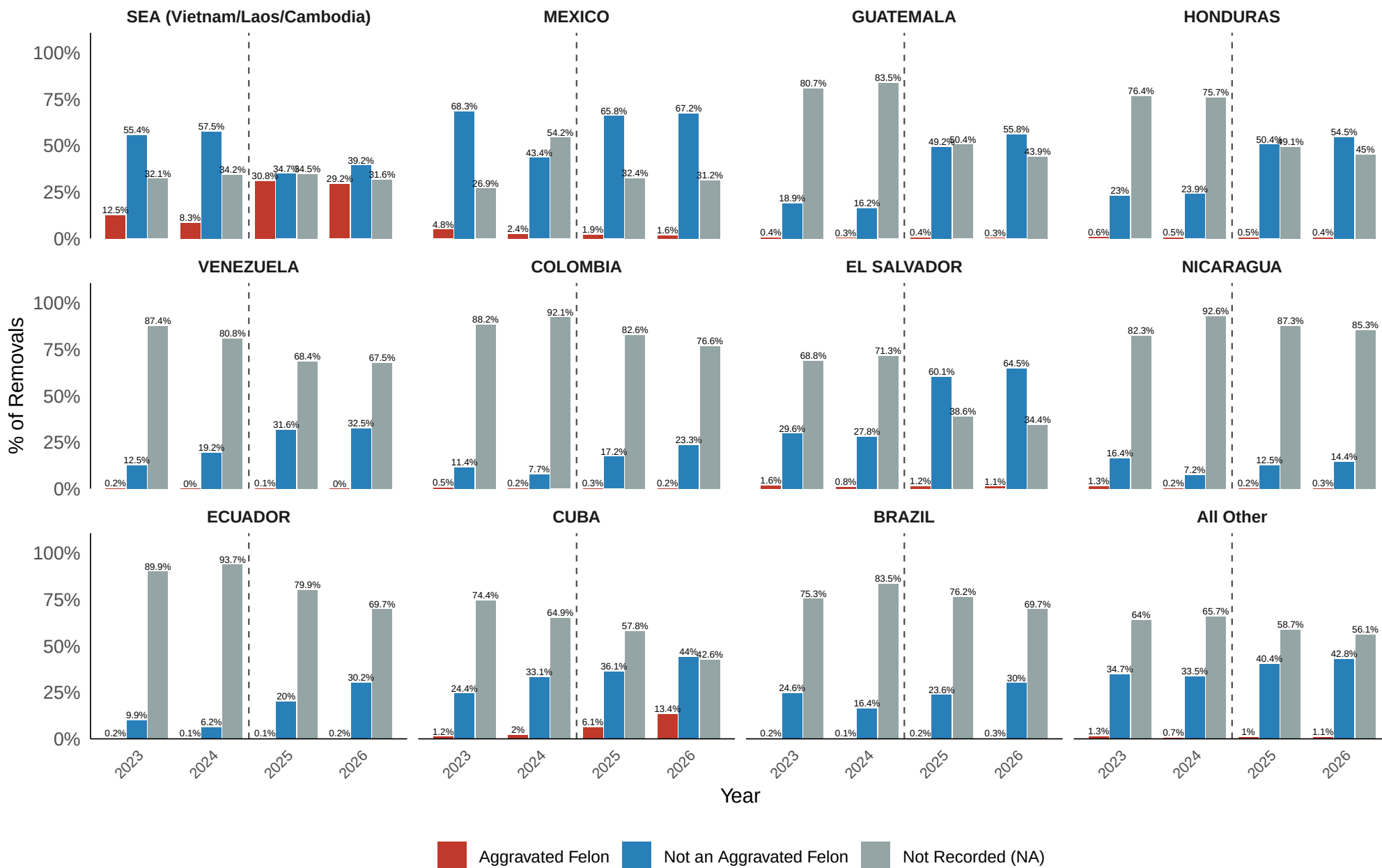
Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA)

Figure C14

Aggravated–Felon Classification by Nationality

Oct 2022 – Feb 2026

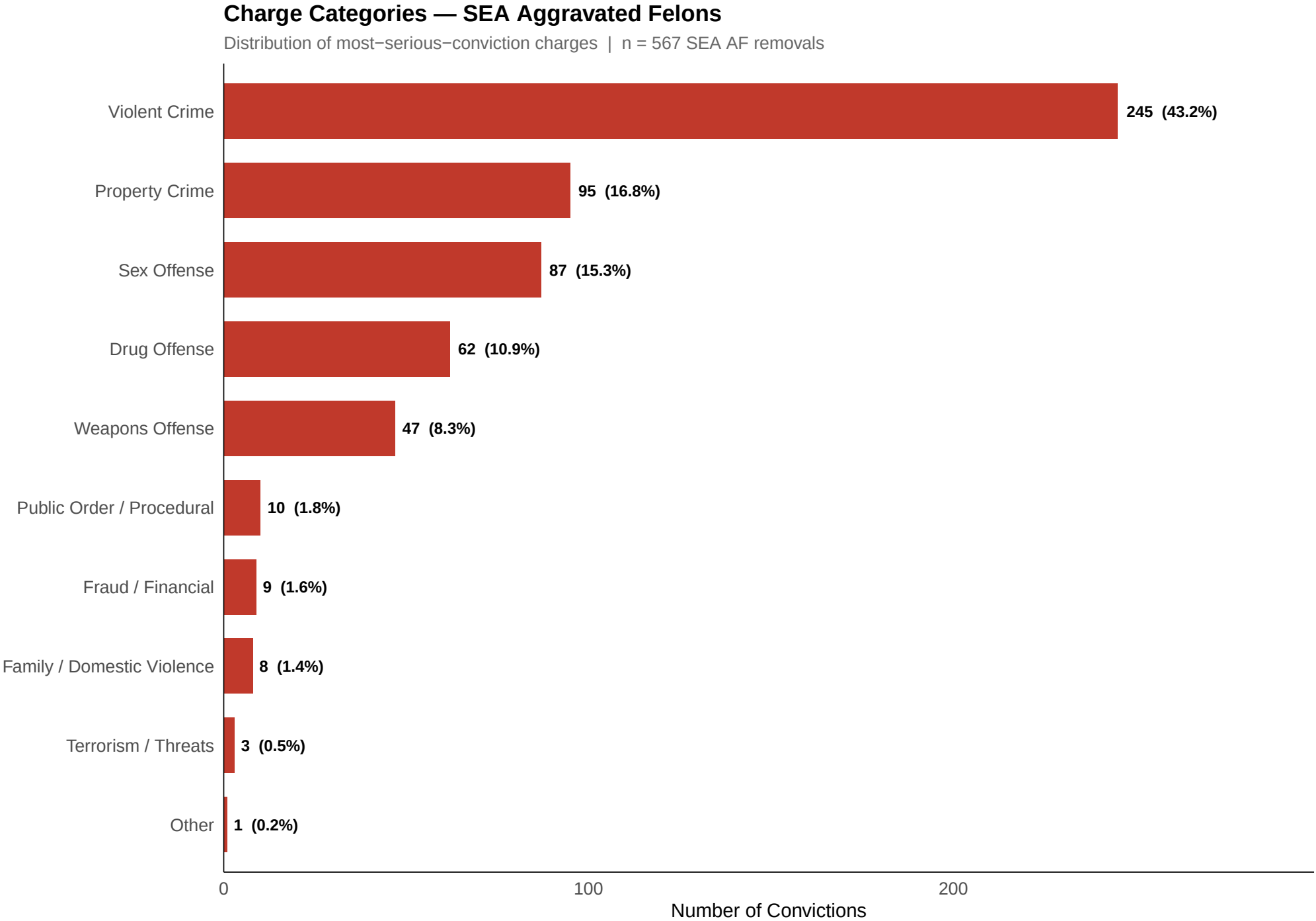
Aggravated Felon combines OTHER, DRUGS, and BOTH classifications under post–1996 INA §101(a)(43)



Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA)

2026 partial year | Trump 2nd term begins Jan 2025

Figure C15



Source: Deportation Data Project (ICE FOIA)
Aggravated-felon flag combines OTHER, DRUGS, and BOTH classifications under post-1996 INA §101(a)(43).